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Introduction to Language

If we think of language and its place in the achievements of human beings, we see that probably, it is related to a great extent to the tendency for exploration. When human beings first arrived on earth, they had to begin to explore – to find food. They must have needed to let other people know what they had found and where they had found it, to pass on knowledge.

There are ways to communicate without the use of speech. You can make a gesture or a dramatic pose or mime. None of those use spoken language. They are forms of communication but they only partially convey knowledge. In fact, whether its a gesture or a dramatic posturing, they only convey meaning to us if we put our own language to what we see. Some believe that even if there is not spoken language, our mind is attaching language to the interpretation of what we see. Thought processes are dependent on language. The agreement of a gesture with meaning implies a language agreement.

An American who is significant in the study of language is a man named **Edward Sapir**. **In a book he wrote called Language, he says that he “is inclined to believe that language antedated even the lowliest developments of material culture**, that these developments, in fact, were not strictly possible until language, the tool of significant expression, had its shape.”

Language must have been one of the first tools created by human beings. In the same book, Sapir says, “The universality and the diversity of speech lead to a significant inference. We are forced to believe that language is an immensely ancient heritage of the human race, whether or not all forms of speech are the historical outgrowth of a single pristine form.”

Another language expert, Harold Goad, in a book he wrote called Language in History, says, “**Human individuality and individual needs are the parents of language.**” C.L. Barber, in a

book he wrote called *The Story of Language*, speaks of language as “that great machine tool which has made human culture possible.”

A number of years ago, there was a program on public television entitled “The Making of Mankind.” This program was talking about some of the **earliest discoveries of fossils in Ethiopia**, fossils that were at that time **dated to be about 3 million BC**. On this program, an anthropologist drew attention to the small size of the teeth of the fossils. This led him to the hypothesis that genus **Homo was walking and probably killing animals with tools** way back then, and that if in fact, this was going on, there was **probably some system of communication** in place because people were apparently working together.

Whether we consider that human beings were first here 3 million or 4 million years ago, what seems logical to conclude is that language must have been one of the characteristics of that species. The intellect of a human beings can't function without language in some form. It needs language, needs to be able to communicate. Sapir says that language is a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions and desires, by means of a system of voluntarily produced symbols, produced by the organ of speech.

It is this tool of culture, this tool of communication, that we have to consider in the language program of a Montessori school, whether we're talking about the Casa dei Bambini or the elementary level. For the children **in the elementary class, language has to be considered as a creation of culture. It is part of the building up of the territory** in which human beings lived and in which human beings still live their lives. Language has developed over the many years that human beings have been on earth. It is still developing. It's been fashioned to respond to the needs of human beings. Isn't that still true today? When a new means of meeting a need is found, that new way has to be named, right? So the language is still developing as a result.

As human beings began to live their lives on earth, language became a **function of society, a function of cooperation and agreement, an agreement of sounds and an agreement of order**. Once again, **language fits into a pattern of order** that we've been

talking about throughout Montessori theory. Language relies and is founded on order. But along side of that comes a mystery and a wonder.

If we reflect on language, we can hopefully realize that language can be used to enthrall and inspire. It can be used to raise human beings to heights of achievement. But it also has its dangers. It can also be used to drag down and degrade. It **can move people to love but can also be used to move people to hate**. Language can be full of meaning but it can also be meaningless and worthless.

What we need to realize and what we need to help the children realize, is that **language carries with it a personal responsibility. Language is an expression of the spirit of the speaker**. It is a reflection of that individual person.

In the book Education for a New World, Maria Montessori wrote, **“Our world has been torn to pieces and is in need of reconstruction. Human teachers can only help the great work that is being done as servants help the master. Doing so, they will be witnesses to the unfolding of the human soul and to the life of a new man who will not be the victim of events but will have the clarity of vision to direct and shape the future of human society.”**

What we have to be aware of is that **clarity of vision presupposes clarity of thought. Thoughts, to be expressed, need language**. We might remember from our study of the first plane child that one of the things that attracted Maria Montessori early on to working with children was watching language development, particularly from birth to three years old. She noticed that no matter where the child was born, no matter what country, no matter what language was being spoken, all children all over the world began to speak at about the same time. She contrasted that with the difficulty that many adults have learning a new language. Adults struggle to learn another language. The young child makes those developments so easily in comparison.

So when we work with children at the second plane, we

always have to keep in mind all of the developments and construction that's taken place in the first plane of development. In the book The Absorbent Mind, there's a chart showing the steps the young child goes through in developing her language. Use that as a reference tool. Become familiar with those steps. The child then takes that already constructed language into the Casa dei Bambini. Now he has the benefit of the conscious absorbent mind to continue with the next stage of language development. We have to remember to help the child develop his language as a means of communication, rather than turning it into lessons of reading and writing. We are helping those skills develop because they are part of his ability to communicate. It is that tool of communication that we need to stay focused on.

Helping each child with this development means helping each unique individual develop independence. And to be properly understood, independence means in its final form, **intellectual independence.** Even if we're a prisoner of war or in some way under duress or isolated, we can still maintain the integrity of our own independent intellect. Other people can take away physical independence but not this other aspect.

Throughout all of our work in language, we want to **think of language as an expression of thought.** That is what we are helping to develop, the expression of thought and the expression of intellect. Probably in both the Casa dei Bambini and the elementary class, language is one of the most difficult areas for teachers to fully implement. They don't fully understand it. Therefore they don't make full use of it. **Inherently, language is an intangible. The practical life materials are concrete and real. The sensorial materials, math materials, are concrete and manipulative. So much of language is intangible that it is easy to overlook it or to lose sight of it.** If that happens, then children move on to the next plane of development without that understanding, without those basic skills, those tools ready to use.

So, let's think about language at the first plane of development. We need to think of language as **four discoveries.** There are **more words** to learn. We help them discover this through conversation, stories and so on. Secondly, they should discover that **spoken sounds can be made visible.** This is done through sandpaper letters, the movable alphabet, metal insets and such items.

Thirdly, the child should discover that **visible symbols are a means of telling** what someone else has said. This is done, for example, in presenting the Phonetic Object Box. The fourth discovery is that **words have certain functionality** and need to go in a certain order. The means of showing this is sentence analysis and function of words.

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Language in the Elementary Environment

During the first plane, children want facts, so the sounds of their language and the words of their language are taken in as fact. At the second plane, because psychological characteristics have changed, we have to give the children the chance to explore the reasons behind those facts. Why does our language use these sounds? Why does our language use these symbols? Why does our language use this order for words in a sentence? These are the kinds of reasons behind the facts, that second plane children need a chance to explore.

The children should ideally come into the elementary class able to write and to read with facility. So that language can become an imaginative exploration of its origins and its developments. We will later discuss how to handle exceptions. But if they do come in with those abilities, language can be presented to them imaginatively so that it sparks their interest. It's not the rules of grammar and syntax as such that we need to give to the children. It's not spelling to be memorized for its own sake that we should be giving to the children. It's not compositions to be written for the sake of writing a composition that they should be doing. And it is not reading books and then requiring them to analyze and dissect those books, i.e., write a book report. We destroy their love for literature by doing this. We can teach them how to write a book report at the proper time and place.

At the elementary level, it is the mystery and the magic and the wonder of this creation of human beings, which is our language, that we want to give the children to explore. We help the child to understand and appreciate the power of language. We help them realize that through language, human beings can communicate, intellect responding to intellect, using the tool of language.

All of the areas of work in language that the child explored in the Casa dei Bambini will continue at the elementary level. But they are going to be treated in a different way and the children's exploration of them will be done in a different way. As the child is now turning psychologically outside his home, language has to be explored in conjunction with the exploration of society.

One area for exploration is the **history of language**. That means the history of its two forms; the history of written language and the history of spoken language. The history develops from the sandpaper letters in the primary years. In the Story of Language we heard the history of written language. This exploration has to be carried out through the imagination because we weren't there at the beginning of writing and reading. When we look at the spoken language, we'll help the children use their imaginations to follow the unfolding of our language by tracing it through our language family.

Along with the story of spoken English comes the study of the written symbols and how they were developed. Some of the different written hands, some of the different materials and implements used in writing, printing and its story, radio, television, space communication, all of these will fall into the developments in history of language.

The aim is not to make a linguistic scholar out of the child, but rather our aim is to intrigue them with all of the different facets of our language. The same language that he's probably spoken since he was very young. Our aim is to open up, for the child, just a glimmering of the knowledge of his own language, and in this way perhaps help the child become conscious of and concerned about the language that he himself uses - and the language he accepts from other people.

Another area that we're going to explore is **grammar and syntax**, through the study of words and parts of speech and sentence analysis. This is an area of study because in order to think clearly and write clearly and speak clearly, an appreciation of grammar and syntax is necessary. In a literate society, correct spelling is also necessary. We cannot ignore spelling. But in the exploration that we do with the children, rules of grammar, the rules of syntax, the spelling rules, are not going to be given as exercises to memorize. They are going to be presented as part of the development of language through the ages.

Generally, there are historical reasons and historical answers for the spelling difficulties children encounter. There are historical reasons for irregular verbs and how they are conjugated. So we are going to investigate those. There are historical reasons for exceptions to the rules in grammar and syntax. If we can present these historical reasons to the children, we can get them interested in literate language. They'll see that it's attached to real life, that's it's not just something in a grammar or work book to be memorized.

Another area we'll look at this year is **written composition**. This can take the form of imaginative writing, factual reporting and researching. In the Casa dei Bambini, the children have hopefully been encouraged to write down their thoughts and ideas, to begin to creatively express themselves, to tell a story in writing rather than with spoken words. Any writing that the children have started to do has hopefully been illustrated and decorated – and this will continue in the elementary class.

A lot of the work the children will be doing in the elementary is connected to researching and reporting. We will talk about the different forms that will take. If the children do need to learn how to write a book report for the public school curriculum, that will fall into this work on written compositions; it is simply one type of written compositions that one can do.

Another area that we will look at is that of **spoken language**. Spoken language forms a large part of the language work in the elementary class. Just as in the Casa dei Bambini, where the children are encouraged to have conversations with each other, they will have conversations here in the elementary level. The elementary class should not be a silent class. But by the same token, most of these conversations should center around their work – not what movie one saw last night.

We're going to encourage independent thinking and independent expression so that means the children have to be allowed to discuss, to debate topics or decisions. This is one of the ways in which we build responsibility in the children. Through the spoken language work, we can help the children come to an exact expression of what they want to say. We can help them learn to take care about the words they choose to use and how they use them. The society in the elementary classroom develops through spoken language. Cooperation, care and service all need spoken language.

Another area of study will be that of **literature**. Reading aloud to the children should have begun in the Casa dei Bambini and it should continue in the elementary class. The children should be allowed to choose books and read them on their own. They should have access to the books in the classroom and they should be taught how to use the public library, a university library or a museum library if there is one. The stories that we read in the primary level need to be factual and real life, stories about animals, people and so on. At the

elementary level, the reading can now be of a great variety. We no longer have to be confined to just true or factual stories but the children do still enjoy them and we want to still include them; and this is where we can bring in stories of adventures and of heroes.

Another side to the literature involves those who have written it. This is where history and language come together. Writers can be put into an historic context and within a certain social structure. In fact, many times we need to do this or the children won't really understand what they're reading or what is being read to them. So the history of literature should be studied through the people involved in developing that literature - the writers, the authors, the publishers.

Alongside the child's own writing and reading in the elementary, will go the **study of style** - the last area of work in the elementary level. In the Casa dei Bambini, the child has already been introduced to something called the grammar symbols. We introduce them through "Functions or Words".

In the elementary class, the symbols can be used to help the children begin to look at the patterns in certain pieces of writing. They can look at the pattern of words in their own writing and in that of other authors. They might compare two different authors to see similarities and differences in these patterns. Through this study in the elementary, they can begin to understand and develop their own taste in literature. They can begin to understand why they like certain authors' writing and why they don't like others - through understanding their writing styles.

Throughout all of this work comes researching and reporting on that research. The children will be using their reading and their writing for an ever-expanding exploration amongst all of the knowledge that's been built up by all societies everywhere that we can now all benefit from. By the time the child comes to the end of the elementary class and is ready to move on, the tool of language should have become usable to the child in an almost limitless way. Language should have also become an exciting avenue for exploration.

All of these different areas of study need to be running parallel in the classroom. The fact that we will use these topics to divide teacher albums into chapters is just an organizational tool for us. We do not start the child at the beginning of one chapter, work through and then begin the next. They all run parallel. **So there are**

six areas of exploration that need to identified and emphasized in parallel in order to help the child in his mastery of language.

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History of Language

The Story of Communication in Signs

Prologue

We have done three Great Lessons. "Creation of the Cosmos", "The Story of the Coming of Life" and "The Story of the Coming of Man." There are two more specific to human beings. This Great Lesson does not need to come as early as the first three do. The first three set the work of the elementary class going. They establish the theme of cosmic education. If the children know how to read and write, they will probably be reading and writing as they later look into aspects of the first three stories. If they come in knowing how to write, they will be writing stories.

This Great Lesson is not an introduction to a subject area in the same way as the others are. But you don't want to wait too long to tell this story. Especially so, because the young children love stories. For those children that don't know how to read and write, this story needs to be told to generate interest, since you will need to get the pupils reading and writing as soon as possible.

So perhaps the 5th or 6th week is the time for this story. It is again a story to which you will require all of the children new to the class but also extend an invitation to all others as well.

Begin

Do you remember the story we had a while ago, the story about Creation of the Cosmos? At the end of that story, you probably remember that we said the earth was ready then for the next part of the story, for the plants and animals to come, for the fish, birds and butterflies and trees to come.

So then we had the story about the coming of life on earth. Another part of that story is about us, about girls and boys, women and men, about human beings, about how and when they came on earth and what they've been doing – that was another story. We also had the Black Strip and the Hand Timeline. We talked about men and women and about some of the things they've been doing since they

arrived on earth.

Now today, we have a story about something that happened after men and women and children had come and were living on the earth. We don't know exactly how long they had been on earth when this story begins. It is one of those 'once upon a time' stories, but it's a true story.

When men and women and children first lived on earth, they needed food to eat just like we do. They had to look around for things that were good to eat. Do you remember that we talked about that when the first human beings came, there were no grocery stores to go to. There were no big stores at all. They had to find it for themselves.

When someone found something and tasted it and liked it and found that it was good to them to eat, he would tell the other people around. "I found something good to eat here. This berry is sweet!" In some way they communicated that this was something good and that others could try it also.

But then there was a problem. What was a person to do if she had walked so far from all of the other people, that they couldn't hear her? Yet, she had found something really good and she wanted to let other people know what she had found. That was really a problem.

Someone, we don't know who, came up with an idea. We will make a picture and we'll leave a message that way - with a picture. So for a long time, this is what people did. For a long long time, people in those far away, long ago, once upon a time days, made pictures of what was important and what they wanted to tell other people about. So time went on and on and on in this way. The picture messages went on and on.

Then, during the time of the picture messages, one group of people called the Egyptians started to make a different kind of picture. Sometimes, they carved their pictures on stone. Sometimes, they painted their pictures after they had been carved. Then they decided that they had better try to find a quicker and easier way to make their pictures messages. You can imagine how long it took to carve stone.

So they found a way of making a kind of paper from a plant that grew near the big river in their country. Along with this paper that they made, they used a kind of brush to draw their pictures on

the paper. That is what they did for a long long time.

Then someone had another idea. Someone had an idea of making something different to use to make their pictures. They made a kind of pen. Then, this is how they drew their pictures on their paper. But it still wasn't always easy to be sure what the picture meant and what the message was saying. Very often people had to guess what kind of message was being left by the Egyptian picture-writing. Often, they guessed wrong. There's a reason why it was so confusing. Sometimes, the Egyptians used a picture to mean an object, like a cup or a chair. They drew a chair and it meant 'chair.' Sometimes they used pictures to mean an idea – something they were thinking about – that picture of a chair could mean 'sitting down', for example. Sometimes, they used the picture to mean just a sound. So the picture an Egyptian made of a leg sometimes meant a leg but other times, the same picture meant running. And other times the same picture of a leg meant quick. So you can see it was not always so easy to understand the message being left. It was a bit confusing. People sometimes got mixed up about the messages

. Sometime later on after the Egyptians had worked on their picture messages, we find there was another group of people; these were the Phoenicians. They also lived a long long time ago. The Egyptians lived near the river Nile and they were farmers and grew a lot of crops. The Phoenicians were sailors and they sailed in their ships to many different countries. In their ships, they carried silver and spices and perfume and jewelry and ornaments. They carried vases and crystals and glass – all kinds of beautiful things. But they also carried one very special thing – something only the Phoenicians made. That special thing was a kind of dye. It was called Tyrian purple – royal purple. It was the color for kings and emperors. It wasn't exactly like the color purple that we know today. It was a kind of red but was called Tyrian purple.

Well the Phoenicians carried all of their goods in their ships and they sailed to other countries and they sold the things they had. Many other people wanted those goods, especially the Tyrian purple cloth. They thought the Tyrian purple dye was something very important – and so it was. This isn't the real reason why the Phoenicians are so important to us. The Phoenicians are so important to our story, important to men and women, girls and boys, important to you and me, for something more important than the Tyrian dye. The Phoenicians knew about the object pictures, the idea pictures and the sound pictures of the Egyptians. They knew the Egyptians used them

all mixed up, so you never knew for sure the meaning. Because the Phoenicians were such busy people, with all that sailing around, and all of that selling of goods to other people in other countries, they didn't have much time to spend making complicated pictures about what people were buying and selling. They wanted an easier way of putting down what they had sold to people – instead of having to draw a picture for everything. So they did something very clever.

The Phoenicians decided to keep only the sound pictures of the Egyptians and they changed them a little bit and then they only kept a few of them. But with just a few of those sound pictures, it was much easier to write what they meant. Can you imagine what the Phoenicians had found so long ago, was what you found out about when you started working with the sandpaper letters? Do you remember the sandpaper letters?

Do you remember if you wanted to write the word 'dog', you could find, first of all, the sandpaper letter for 'd', which the Phoenicians had made so simple. It was just a little mark – and not a real picture anymore. Then you would find the sandpaper letter for 'o' and 'g', which the Phoenicians had also made so simple. They were just other little marks.

But our story doesn't end there with the Phoenicians. They made that exciting discovery for us but then as time went on and time went on, other people called the Greeks took the Phoenician's letters and changed their shape a little bit and used those little marks as their letters. Time went on and on. Some other people called the Romans took those letters and changed their shape a little bit. It is generally the Romans who are credited with calling the 26 letters of the Phoenicians, the alphabet. Do you remember the movable alphabet in your primary class – and making words with it?

What you have to remember, and be glad about, is the story of the Phoenicians. They made the first real letters – or sounds. In that way, they made it possible for us to let other people know what we wanted to say, even if they are far away from us – and cannot hear our voices. We can write the letters and leave messages that way, in writing.

Because this was so exciting and so hard for some people to believe, at the beginning of these marks of the Phoenicians, some people thought it was a kind of magic. When somebody took one of these messages that someone else had written, and was able to read it

and understand it, the other people thought it was magic. How could that be possible? Just those little marks giving a message like that?

Do you remember the story we were reading the other day? It was the Phoenicians who made it possible for us read that story. So, I think we need to say 'thank you Phoenicians', don't you?

End

Epilogue

The broad outline is given in this story. There are lots of details to pick up on in subsequent stories. What are the different kind of Egyptian writing? What is the story about the Phoenicians? How did they make Tyrian purple? Where did the color come from?

Where did the word Tyrian come from? How did the Greeks change the Phoenician alphabet? Where did the word 'alphabet' come from? How did the Romans change the letters? These are all potential follow-up aspects of this story. The Great Lesson gives the broad outline. These are all key lessons for later.

There are charts to bring out afterwards to inspire follow-up ideas or follow-up stories. We also want to have books such as The Twenty-Six Letters by Oscar Ogg. It fills in the development of the alphabet. A more recent book is called Alpha Beta: How Twenty-six Letters Shaped the Modern World, by John Man. You need to keep books and other materials for follow-up in the classroom, six to eight books perhaps. We have to bring in high-interest and hard to find materials. This will inspire interest in other ways - connecting to history, biology and so on.

October 1, 2004

The History of Written Language

From the story Communication in Signs, you need to pick up on some of those elements mentioned and tell many more stories to the children. This is an informational lecture that will fill in the details of this story; we need to take this information, along with other that we gather, and develop new stories out of these for further study. There are things to keep in mind as you plan stories.

Don't give all of the information. Make sure to include information of high interest. Bring in new information but not necessarily what is easy to come by. Appeal to the characteristics of the child. Begin by building on what had come before and is related to the new story. Make sure to end the story with an indication that there is more to know.

Within the story Communication in Signs, there is material for many more lessons. The alphabet as we know it has its own story; the name itself has a story. The ways the alphabet has been written and produced throughout history are full of stories. What is important is that we build on the idea that the alphabet of the Phoenicians is what enables us to come in contact with the thoughts and ideas of other people – even if they're not presently around us from this period of time.

Dr. Glyn Daniels, in his book [The First Civilizations](#), wrote, “By the time writing has arrived and recorded history is upon us, civilized societies have already been born.” In the history work we'll look into some of these early societies and see where they began, how their civilizations came about, whether or not they kept records and what kind and how, if so. Written language is a story that is part of the history of human beings so it is naturally inter-linked with history.

In looking at the development of the alphabet from the time it was first recorded, it appeared that the earliest surviving writing comes from Egypt and Mesopotamia and is not earlier than around 3000 BC. That give us about 5000 years of recorded language and recorded history – not long at all compared with humanity's time on earth. If we accept picture writing of Paleolithic human beings as a formal means of communication, we can go back even further. We can

start with the development of picture-writing being used for keeping records and sending messages. The whole idea of picture-writing is one part of this story of visible communication to pick up on with the children. On our continent of North America, we have the picture-writing that was used by the different Native American tribes that allowed them to communicate with each other – even though they were each speaking a different language.

It's generally easy and interesting to give the children ideas about picture-writing because we still have around us today many remnants of this idea. If we think of all of the international situations where pictures are used, so people know what's meant even if they speak different languages, we can identify restrooms, traffic signs, airport signs for arrival and departures and many other examples that we use today. In the US, each state has its own flag, flower, bird and so forth that are used in similar way – the idea of heraldry – how groups of people are identified by particular symbols – is still used. Maybe you'd like to develop your own family crest. What symbols would be important to you? These are the type of suggestions that may set the child into activity.

In the development of writing from pictures, two things happened. The first is that pictures became simplified and conventionalized until they were no longer pictures in a strict sense. Secondly, this led to a beginning of pictures as representing linguistic items – first whole words, then syllables and finally sounds. It seems as if perhaps the first true writing may have been developed by the Sumerians who were probably the people of one of the very first civilizations. Their society developed in southern Mesopotamia sometime between 4000 and 3000 BC. Because of the material used by the Sumerians, clay tablets, and a tool called a stylus which was made from a reed, that first writing tended to be angular. It was made from groups of wedges formed by pressing the reed into soft clay. Their writing was called cuneiform, which means 'wedge shaped.'

For many centuries, even after the Sumerians had been conquered by the Semitic people, the Babylonians and the Assyrians, cuneiform remained almost the universal script of the Near East. It was also used by the Hittites who lived in Anatolia, and by the Persians. Although these people spoke non-Semitic languages, they used the same writing as the Semitic people used.

As time went on, the Egyptians began to communicate in a visual form, and their writing developed from the carved letters on the

stone, to the use of a brush pen on papyrus. That made it possible to write in a more cursive running-hand, something more like what some of us write now. The original Egyptian script, which goes back to around 3000 BC, was pictorial and today it is called hieroglyphs. Hieroglyph, the word, comes from a Greek word meaning “holy carved letter”, because the Greeks thought the Egyptians used the script mainly for religious inscriptions. That carved script could also be painted and sometimes was. But the Egyptians also developed a less complicated and much faster form of writing which was called hieratic or priestly. Around 700 BC, after a long period of time, a popular form of writing developed from the hieratic writing. It was called 'demotic' writing, meaning 'for the people.' In other words, it was simple enough for most common people to use.

The alphabet that we use, like all those in Western Europe, is almost certainly derived from the alphabet developed by the Phoenicians, which came to us by way of the Greeks and by way of the Romans. Since the Phoenicians were great sailors, they would come in contact with other groups of people. They came in contact with the Greeks. The Greeks probably got the alphabet from the Phoenicians around 900 BC. The letters of the Phoenicians, their alphabet, probably came from Egyptian hieroglyphs – the origin is still not entirely clear since there are still discoveries being made. But the story of the alphabet goes on because the letters we use now are not formally the same as those used by the Phoenicians. The Greeks added symbols for vowels because the Phoenician alphabet only had consonants and the Greeks needed vowels for their language.

The story of the alphabet is the story of human heritage and culture. It developed and changed to respond to the needs of different groups. As it became easier to write the alphabet, it became more available to more people. More and more people could come in contact with the heritage being built up. The Greek writing was all in capital letters. They didn't leave spaces between words. It doesn't sound very easy to read or write. The Romans, when they got the alphabet, added beauty to the letters. These are changes that may interest the child.

Going on through the ages, the alphabet changed. First of all, small letters were added to the capital letters. There came about the development of the beautiful “manuscript hands” of the Irish scribes. The hand-writing by the Irish scribes was modified and a further development of this style was made by a bishop called Alcuin at Tours, in France, where he was appointed to be in charge of

education at the court of Charlemagne. One of the great things he undertook was the development of an alphabet which could be easily and quickly written. He designed an alphabet based on the letters of the Irish scribes. Alcuin called this particular alphabet the “Caroline alphabet”, named after Charlemagne. It was an alphabet of small letters, very clear and very readable. This particular style spread throughout Europe and it became the small letter alphabet we use today.

By the end of the middle ages, there had been developed a group of national hands. One of them was called the Gothic or 'black letter' alphabet. And it was on this style that the first printers modeled their type. In the 10th century AD, another national hand was the Italian “round hand” - or cursive. In the 16th century, the form of that hand became known in France and England as 'italic.' And it is that form that is still used today in italic font.

With the invention of printing, we come to another era. If the children in the Casa dei Bambini have not done something like potato printing or lino printing, they should be introduced to that in the elementary environment. You cut the potato, cut a design into the potato, press it onto ink and press it onto paper. This mimics closely the development in history. The seal of someone important was left in soft wax - in many cases before that person could write his name.

The invention of paper by the Chinese, led to a great increase in printing. But it was still relatively slow. The Chinese carved whole books on wooden blocks and then printed from those wooden blocks. This was certainly an improvement over hand-writing but it was still slow and expensive. The Europeans probably learned block printing from the Chinese.

The next step in spreading the alphabet around was the development of movable type printing, selecting all of the letters for a page, locking them into a frame and then printing the whole page. It is from movable type printing that we've inherited the terms upper-case and lower-case letters. The upper-case letters were literally kept in the upper case, higher up from the printer. Lower case lettered were kept in the lower case.

Not much more than a century ago, there was another big change. Paper was made from wood pulp, rather than from rags. Then came the rotary press and a still faster process - the lino type. Then typewriters and word-processors and computers all became parts of

this story of the alphabet.

One of the things we want to look for in the area where we teach is what possibilities there are for the children to go out and see any of these aspects of printing and the developments of the alphabet. Some children's museums have exhibits of this. Or there may be a printing press or newspaper where work might be witnessed and experienced first-hand. All of these stories of the alphabet developed around these sandpaper letters and movable alphabet the children encountered in primary.

October 1, 2004

The History of Spoken Language

The history of spoken language is not something to take up so early with the children. Its history involves a bit more sophisticated study. Even though it goes here in the first chapter within the history of language, this work wouldn't start until children are around 8 and close to the upper elementary. You can touch on it only at this point.

We said Sapir, in his book on language, said he was inclined to think that language antedated other gains in culture. Where or when exactly spoken language started – we don't know. We weren't there. We don't have written records about it. But when the children are about 8 years old, we can begin to give them some of the theories that have been put forward about how language came about. None of these theories can be proven, so they are just different people's ideas and should be presented as such. Here are some of the main theories linguists speak of.

The first is the bow-wow theory. It says language came about from the imitation of other sounds, such as the sounds made by animals – hence the name. People who hold to this theory talk about some of the words we use that are an indication of this idea like coo-coo or quack-quack.

Another theory is the pooh-pooh theory. It says language developed from emotional or instinctive or expressive cries. For example, a cry of pain or a cry of joy as a basis.

Then there is the ding-dong theory. It says the impressions we receive elicit a vocal response. Getting hit in the head by a limb of a tree might elicit such an expression.

There is the yo-he-ho theory. The voices made by a group of people working together are the basis of this. For example, a group of people trying to build the large figures at Stonehenge may have made such sounds. People who ascribe to this theory believe that spoken language came about because of social cooperation.

There is the gesture theory. It says gestures preceded speech in its development. Taking this theory there is something

called the mouth-gesture theory that asserts gestures of the face and hands were unconsciously followed by movement of the tongue, lips and mouth – until the voice became audible.

There is the musical theory. It asserts the origins of language came about through song. There is the contact theory that language evolved from the sounds made on contact with another. People who ascribe to this theory compare it to the idea of many other animals that have one cry they make to the environment at large and then perhaps a particular cry or sounds they make to another of their species – like a mating call. Some people think sounds like this evolved into speech.

These are only some of the theories for language development. Other discussion centers around whether there was one original spoken language or whether separate ones developed individually. Some language theorists postulate that spoken language began as simple commands, the imperative form of the verb – stop, run and so forth. The only thing we can do is speculate until we come to the time of written records.

We can't prove the theories of spoken language but the children from 9 to 12 may want to look into these theories. Just the names are intriguing to them. Who are those who back the bow-wow theory, for example?

Some of the sorts of questions we could throw out to the children are things like, “Where did our language come from? Why do we speak English and not some other language?” They may wonder when the first English was spoken.

In a book entitled The Testimony of the Spade, the author, Geoffrey Bibby, he says, “With few exceptions, all European languages as well as Persian and Hindustani languages, belong to a single language group. And it has long been clear to philologists that this Indo-European group of languages must have spread outward from a single point of origin at some definite historical moment. There is every reason to believe that the ancestor of the languages we speak today was the tongue spoken by the cattle-herding nomads who burst out of Russia into Central Europe some 4000 years ago.” Who were these cattle-herding nomads speaking the ancestral language of English so long ago? What was Europe like at the time they arrived? It was a land very different from what we would find today if we were to drive across the countries of Europe.

At that time, Europe was a land of scattered agricultural communities – not a land of cities and towns. It was a land to which missionaries had probably come, bringing with them from their own land, their culture and customs – and it was a land of megalith buildings – large funeral tombs used for communal burial. It was a land also where other groups had come to trade. People called the **Bell-beaker people**, because of the shape of the pottery that they made, also brought with them objects made of bronze. All of these people were living relatively peacefully. But into this peaceful scene came the nomads who were probably the first speakers of the ancestral language of English.

People called the '**battle-ax**' people were a nomadic horde. They moved from place to place. The battle-ax was their characteristic weapon. It was made of copper or polished stone. They had particular burial customs. Where their graves have been found, the men are lying on their right sides with their heads to the west. The women are lying on their left sides with their heads to the east. Their legs are bent. Their faces are turned towards the south and for the men, their battle-ax was placed right in front of their eyes. They seemed to have been a warring people, traveling from territory to territory causing upheaval. People surmised from their burial customs that they were sun worshippers. We don't know for sure. We know they were a **Caucasian race** and it is strongly believed that their language was the first example of an Indo-European language. They came from the steppes of Russia, where they had **domesticated the horse**. This is what made it possible for them to travel so far and so quickly. And it is how they were able to invade more peaceful people. Some of the children may want to look into the battle-ax or bell-beaker people. What kind of territory did they come from? What did they do in the places they invaded?

In the book The Testimony of the Spade, Bibby has a chapter on the bell-beaker and the battle-ax people. He also wrote a book entitled Four Thousand years ago and in this book there is also a chapter on the battle-ax people. In the book Pi in the Sky, Barrow mentions the battle-ax people as possibly being the people who spread the decimal system. This is an interesting connection with math for the children.

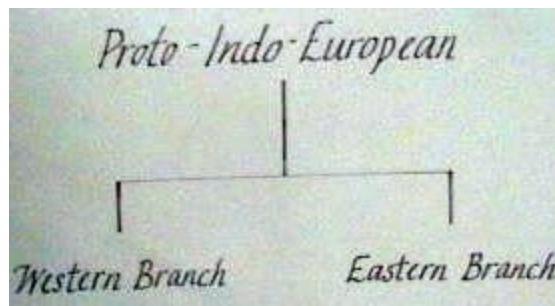
It seems as if these people speaking what we call Proto Indo-European, the first or most ancient of the Indo-European languages, were living on the plains of central or Eastern Europe, and around

2500 BC they began to move to different places. They moved to Armenia and to Mesopotamia. They moved to the plateaus of Iran and later into Western India, which is why we have Hindustani as a related language.

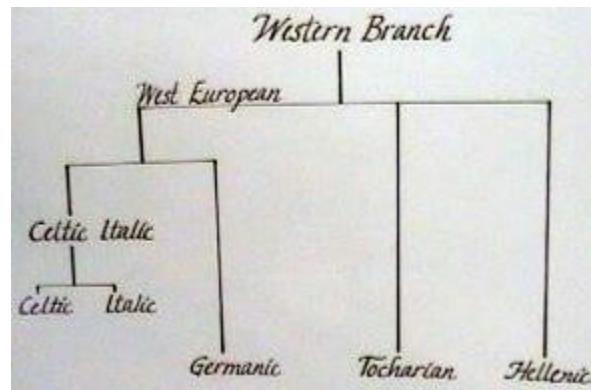
Other groups moved southward to the Balkans. They moved westward to the Alps. So we have a related language there. They moved on to Italy, France and Spain. Others went north to the Baltic and so we get Russian as a related language.

This possibility of traveling so far and spreading out so much was aided by the fact that these people had horse-drawn vehicles. This means that either they invented the wheel or borrowed it from someone else. We have some charts that show our language family. (display chart)

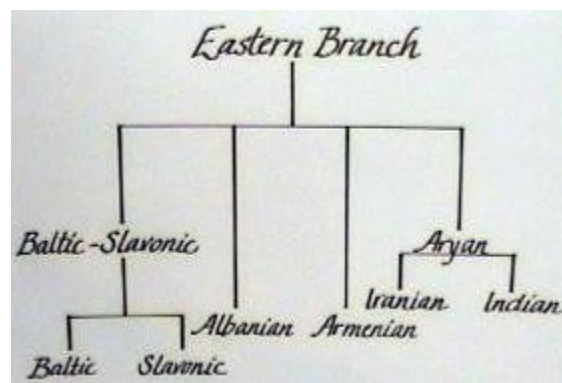
Starting with the first chart Proto-Indo European, the great great grandfather of our language. Proto-Indo European is broken into a western branch and an eastern branch. If we follow this language family down to get to our language, we follow the western branch.



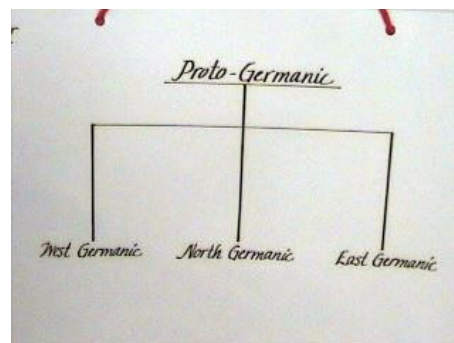
Looking at the second chart, we get the western branch. It comes down to West European, which divides down into Celtic-Italic which separates into Celtic, Italic, Germanic, Tocharian and Hellenic. Maybe the children would like to find out about Tocharian. Though our language follows Germanic.



The third chart shows the eastern branch. It breaks into Baltic-Slavonic, Albanian, Armenian, and Aryan (which breaks into Iranian and Indian).

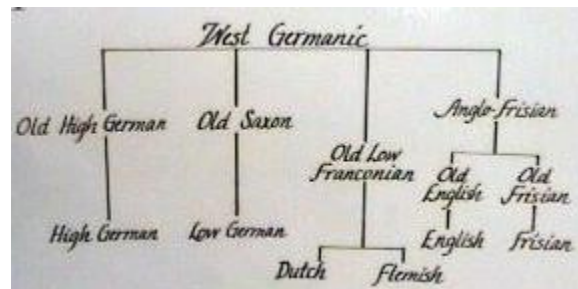


Germanic divides into Proto-Germanic. That in turn divides into West Germanic, North Germanic and East Germanic. We follow the West Germanic branch to pursue English.



On the last chart number 5, we have West Germanic which divides

into Old-high German, Old-Saxon, Old-low Franconian and Anglo-Frisian. Anglo-Frisian divides into Old English which terminates in English while Old Frisian terminates to Frisian.



These charts need to be used with the children to study our language family to understand where English fits in. There are lots of other language families. The children may want to understand what language-family Korean comes from. Does it come from Proto-Indo-European? Probably not.

Frisian, which is our closest cousin is spoken in northern Holland today.

We mentioned earlier that most European languages belong to this language family. But not all of them do. We have our story of numbers from one to ten and how all people have needed words for numbers. One way in which we can compare languages is by using a chart which shows the numbers from one to ten in these language: Latin, Greek, Sanskrit, Gothic and Old-English.

	Latin	Greek	Sanskrit	Gothic	Old English
1	ūnus	heis	ēka	ains	ān
2	duo	duō	dvā	twai	twēpa; twā
3	tres	tris	trayas	~	þrē
4	quattuor	tettāres	catvāras	fidwor	feower
5	quinque	pente	panca	fimf	fif
6	sex	hex	sas	saihs	six
7	septem	hepta	sapta	sibun	seofon
8	octo	oktō	astau	ahtau	eahta
9	novem	enna	nava	nūn	nigon
10	decem	doka	dasa	tailun	ēten

There is a language Ural-Altaic that Finnish and Hungarian belong to. Finish and Hungarian belong to this group. They are similar in the same manner English, French and Swedish numbers are

similar since they are from a common root also.

If the children are exploring language and language families, they will find curious things like the fact that some languages are spoken by certain groups of people but not by a whole country. Italian we identify with Italy but what about Basque? This is a group related to both France and Spain. Cornish is another group of people in Cornwall and is a Gaelic dialect that has been identified; it was spoken only by a group of people but not a whole country. The Basque language doesn't seem to have any relatives. **Linguists are working on trying to make a connection between Basque and Japanese. Isn't that strange when we consider how speakers are so far apart.**

Today, about half the population of the world speaks languages that are part of the Indo-European language family. That leaves the other half of the world to explore for other language families.

For the 9 to 12 year olds, the development of English can be taken a step further. There is no single parent to the English that we speak. **In the 3rd, 4th and 5th centuries AD, England was invaded by the Anglo-Saxons who came from the coasts of Germany. England was eventually divided up into seven little kingdoms.** Each had its own language. The Anglo-Saxons brought their own languages with them. So there was one spoken in southern England, one in southeastern England, one in the north eastern part of England and one in the central part of England. The language spoken in the south-west became the literary language of united England. But it still is not the direct ancestor of modern English.

Our **modern English tongue came from a union of the languages spoken in the northeast and central part of the country.** Then there are several other reasons why English is such a mixed up language.

As you begin to introduce etymology to the children, you find many of our words have roots that go back to different languages. **In 597 AD, St. Augustine came to England as a missionary bishop and he brought Latin to England.** This is why we find all these Latin roots in English. From the **Scandinavian invasions in the 8th, 9th, and 10th centuries**, we find Scandinavian roots and words that became part of English. The suffix 'by' as in Darby is Scandinavian,

from the word byre, meaning a village farm.

In the **11th century, England was invaded again, this time by the Norman French.** With their arrival, English was no longer the language of the governing classes. English was still spoken by the serfs, the lower classes, but **French became the language of the educated.** Court was conducted in French. The wealthy spoke French. It wasn't until **1362 that parliament was again opened by a speech in English given by an English speaking king.** With the **revival of learning in the 16th century and it's spread from Greece,** we find many technical words and many scientific terms with Greek roots.

Sometimes when we work on spelling with the children, they will wonder why a word like 'love' is spelled as it is when it doesn't sound that way. Wouldn't 'luv' be easier? Or the word sun, why is the sun-up in the sky 'sun', while the offspring is 'son'? Must we really have all these complications? We have the Norman-French scribes to thank for these spelling difficulties. When they did their writing, they used a continental style of writing instead of the Celtic script. Their style of writing made it difficult to tell how many strokes had been made when certain letters were written together. So in combinations where there was a 'un' or 'um', they started to write an 'o' instead of the 'u' because it made it easier to identify the letters rather than figuring out how many strokes had been made. We have a chart that show changes in spelling but not in pronunciation. In Old English, the word **'sunu,'** in Middle English **'sone',** and into modern English it became **son** today. 'Come' and 'love' are other examples of how styles of writing affected different spellings of the same word.

Any deep studies of this are for the 9 to 12 class. This is why spoken language is a more sophisticated study for the older children. Another interesting thing to bring in with the children is the difference between American and British English. Our heritage is from British English. But the **English that was brought over to the American colonies was more the language of Shakespeare.** English in England continued to change and evolve in a certain way that was not necessarily brought here. Some who have been in England knows they never use the word 'gotten.' They dropped that in the 17th century. They consider it vulgar. It is part of the verb 'to get'. In American English it is correct but in England it is considered vulgar. The way we speak today is closer to the way Shakespeare spoke.

In the US, there were other influences such as **Native American** words incorporated into the language. Have you ever wondered why we, in the US, spell the word color without a 'u' as they do in England and India? **Noah Webster** had a big impact on the spelling of words because he made changes when he published his dictionary. If they caught on, he kept them. If not, he dropped them. Bilt was one thing he tried but never caught on. During this time, the British, of course, thought we were destroying the language.

So there are many interesting aspects to take up with the children. This lecture provides much material for this purpose.

Epilogue

We can photocopy these charts and reduce them for the albums. We need to make some of these charts for ourselves. Two are in the charts we received but most are not.

It is strongly suggested that we develop a story for the history of spoken English for ourselves. During practice teaching, it can be an area where the teacher wants us to give a presentation. At oral exams, it will be a slip. We will need to have a story to tell the children - about the history of written or spoken language.

For example, we could develop a story about the bishop Alcuin or the Irish scribes and their manuscript writing. In spoken language, we could prepare a battle-ax people story.

Living Words (Ferris 2005)

By Eric Ferris

Did you ever fall down stairs? Did you ever have a door close on your finger? Did you ever eat too much and get a stomach ache? Usually people warn us using words like, "Be careful or you'll fall down the stairs." Sometimes we don't pay attention. But then we fall down the stairs or get sick or the door crushes our finger – and ooooooh that hurts!

After that, we avoid these things and the words, "Be careful or you'll fall down the stairs" cause us to remember our pain. Now, the words, unlike before, form a picture in our mind of something painful to avoid – the words have more meaning to us than before. They are the same words, but now inspire us to act a different way. They have become words that live inside us because we experienced them in a new way. They now change how we live.

There are words adults use in the same way. Sometimes we call these special books sacred books or wisdom literature. The people who wrote them often had experiences like us, when we close the door on our finger, which have inspired them to act differently. The Bhagavad Gita is such a book that came from India thousands of years ago and is used by religious people called Hindus. Because wisdom literature is often thousands of years old, we don't always know who wrote them. Another religion called Taoism originated in China and its teachings are thought to have been created by a man named Lao Tze. But we're not even positive whether he was a real person or a mythical person. Nevertheless, the Chinese have read his teachings and his words have lived in them since about 500 BC. There are books like these – too many to mention here – from all over the world – from many different civilizations – virtually from the beginning of human history. People in colleges and universities study the history of living words from ages past and continually discover new facts about them.

A man named Muhammad, who lived from 570 to 632 AD, founded a set of teachings that created a new religion called Islam. Today, Islam has followers all over the world and they are called Muslims. Some Muslims believe that the words of Muhammad were recorded in a book called the Koran and that these words were sent to him from God and were merely written by Muhammad. But when Muhammad died, there was no Koran – only words Muhammad had been heard to say, written on parchment, bones and animal skins or recorded in the memories of those who knew him.

There were disputes almost immediately after Muhammad's death about what he had actually said. The man who took over as the head of this

new religion, called the first Caliph, began to collect these words into the Koran after his death. The Koran used today was finally completed by the third Caliph around 656 AD. Only the words approved by the third Caliph were included in the Koran. He ordered all other disputed versions of Muhammad's words destroyed.

For hundreds of years, scribes of the ancient religion called Judaism recorded holy text on beautiful long scrolls. These scribes were experts in the art of calligraphy and scrolls were considered precious and closely guarded. Followers of Judaism are called Jews and these people can also be found all over the world – though they are first known in an area around the Mediterranean Sea thousands of years ago.

But there were other groups of Jews who probably lived around Galilee and many were poor wanderers. They were followers of a Jewish man named Jesus whose teachings, like Muhammad's, were at the center of a new religion that started around 30 AD. This new religion was called Christianity and its followers are called Christians. They also can be found all over the world today. Jews have a book of teachings called the Old Testament and Christians have a book of teachings called the New Testament. Together the collection of words is called the Bible. Though the New Testament is about Jesus, he did not write the New Testament.

For hundreds of years, Jews, Christians and Muslims, being from the same part of the world, often from the same cities, have disagreed and fought over who's religion owned certain temples and cities and over which teachings should be followed – those of Jesus, Muhammad or the ancient teachings of Judaism. All three religions trace their heritage to a single man named Abraham. Sometimes, as people struggle to get along, our history becomes important and we protect its traditions. But do we even know history as we think we do?

Often our history is translated from other languages. The Bible was originally written in Hebrew and Aramaic – the latter, a language no one speaks any longer. The earliest translations were into Greek. Often, translations changed the meaning of the words or the words were used differently then than they are used today. Even Greek translations differ from the meaning taught today. The Bible tells us that one day Jesus went off alone for many hours of prayer. But in Jesus' time, the word for prayer meant reciting a well-known set of words aloud in public. Some scholars think that he actually meditated – not prayed, as we know it.

For more than 1800 years, Christians believed that the first words about the story of Jesus in the New Testament were by a Christian man named Matthew. Then in the 1830s, historians discovered that Matthew had actually copied much of his story from another Christian named Mark. In 1838, a lecturer in philosophy and theology at the University of Leipzig

named Christian Weisse found proof that Matthew had copied his words not only from Mark – but from another unknown collection of words. He knew this because another author named Luke had written nearly the same story as Matthew – but scholars have shown that neither of these authors knew of the other's story. Both of these stories were copied from Mark's but they each had several hundred verses of words that were not found in Mark! So what was this other source of words – or source of Wisdom literature?

Today, university teachers and Christian researchers believe the very first Christian writings were collected by the people of Galilee, an area where Jesus lived. But unlike the beautiful scrolls of the Jews, these words were collected in something we call a codex – a forerunner to the modern-day book. Codices were stacks of parchment that were cut to the same size, with holes punched along the side, that were then bound together and covered at both ends by either wood or animal hide.

Unlike Jewish scrolls, these codices were primitive and made by the average working person. These collections of words were intended to be sturdy and used by Christian teachers traveling along the Roman roads connecting the larger towns surrounding Galilee. The stories of Mark, Matthew and Luke were largely centered around the circumstances of the death of Jesus. But this lost collection of words which historians call the lost “Gospel Q” were mostly the sayings of Jesus – not at all concerned with his death but more concerned with his life and his teachings about life. This lost Gospel Q is believed to have been written about 20 years after Jesus died – before any of the other stories about Jesus were written. It is considered by scholars to be the closest historical link to Jesus known. The lost Gospel Q has never been found – its existence was initially based on an educated guess.

But in 1945 an archeological treasure of very early Christian writings were found in Nag Hammadi, a town along the Upper Nile River. Among the findings were codices covered in leather, one of which caused a revolution among researchers of the Bible. It was called the Gospel of Thomas and contained 114 sayings and claimed to have been words spoken by the “Living Jesus.” And this document was very similar to the document Christian Weisse had described in 1838. Most amazing to researchers was that over a third of the sayings in this codex were similar to those researchers had identified as the lost Gospel Q – the unknown source of words found in stories by Matthew and Luke. In the 1980s, the International Q Project and the Q Project of the Society of Biblical Literature were formed to thoroughly investigate what was thought to be the original source of over two-hundred verses in the stories of Matthew and Luke. So, is the New Testament what Jesus intended to teach us? That is left for each of us to decide.

Like the words of the Koran, the Bhagavad Gita and the literature of the Taoists, the lost Gospel Q speaks of villages, neighbors, families and

children – and the importance of helping each other. It speaks of a new age of greater human happiness and tells us it is everyone's responsibility to bring this new age into being. It is a guidebook for everyday life, on how to act and get along in the world. The message to each individual is that each person is important, even necessary, as part of the fabric of this new world. These were meant to be living words that change the way we live. And each culture has had its own unique sacred books.

As we study words for ourselves, they live in us and take unique meaning for us as individuals. When we look into words, their history and original meaning, we make them our own. When words live in our actions and not just in our minds, words become more than just ideas. They change the experiences we have in life – like when we hear, “Be careful or you'll fall” and we actually act in a different way. Whether we are trying to hit a baseball or trying to be a good neighbor, words guide us only when we look for their deepest meaning and allow them to live in us.

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October 4, 2004

Grammar and Syntax

As we've talked about the child at the first plane of development, we've talked about him creating and building up a language for himself - from the language spoken around him. While doing that, he has been using grammar and syntax without having had formal lessons on them. As he comes to the children's house, his language expands and grows. We help him to use more words. We touch on grammar and syntax but not in a formal way.

At the first plane of development, the language work we do is to give the child an impression of the parts of speech that are used in her language. This serves as a foundation for the child so that at the second plane, she can begin to look into the reasons for that grammar, the 'hows' and 'whys' of syntax.

At the second plane, we're going to introduce the child to grammar and syntax in a different way than we did at the first plane. There are three sections to this chapter:

- Word Study
- Parts of Speech with Grammar Boxes
- Sentence (or Logical) Analysis

As this is a foundation study, we'll begin with words to show how changes are made to words for special purposes. We're going to be building on the vocabulary work the child did in the first plane of development. We'll take individual words and show how interesting they are in and of themselves. We'll do this with word study.

In the Casa dei Bambini, the child should have had the exercises of the function of words to help him realize that all words have a special part to play in language, that they have a place in the order and structure of the language that he uses and reads. With that work in the Casa dei Bambini, technically speaking, we are introducing the child to the parts of speech. But this is not how we think of that work. We don't think of it as giving the child grammar but rather we use it as a key to help the child's reading develop and to help him understand what he's reading.

The use of the grammar symbols with the function of words exercises helps the child become more fully conscious of the different words and they're an aid to the child's clearer classification of words.

We recall that with function of word work, we do not name the parts of speech as we work with them; we could compare this with the sensorial work in the primary level where the child has long experience with the material before language is attached to it. In the same manner, the function of words exercises give the experience of the function, the activity carried out by different words. We give impressions of what each special word does.

Now, in the elementary class we're going to return to a study of the parts of speech and we'll help make the child more fully conscious of the work that each part of speech carries out. It is at this stage, while working with the children, that we will give the name for each part of speech. Now that name will help the child make a further classification of each function and the names will help organize the information in the child's mind.

The material that we use to present the parts of speech in the elementary class is called the grammar boxes. We need to use a different material because we have different psychological characteristics to appeal to. The function of word exercises are a reading exercise. The words are written by the teacher right in front of the child. We don't then say – can you read this. We say “do you know what this says?” or anything but can you read this. The child is helped to realize that we can communicate with each other through words written on paper without the use of the voice – we emphasize discovery of the function.

With the children aged 6 to 12 who should be able to read, we're going to use their reading ability to study the classified parts of speech in a different manner. Now adjective phrases are already printed, sentences are already printed on cards and as well as the phrases or sentences, each of the words used is isolated on a separate card, so that we're isolating function by function. These isolated cards are grouped together and classified in packets placed in the various compartments of each grammar box.

As we're using the grammar boxes, we will again use the grammar symbols and they will form the link between the function of word exercises in the Casa dei Bambini and this continued study of the parts of speech in the elementary class. As the child links the grammar symbol to the function of the word, the name of the part of speech is given to the child. So the grammar symbols become a link for the child between the two levels.

The aim of the grammar boxes is not to teach grammar as it used to be taught traditionally but rather to develop interest in the children and to continue to interest the child in the words that he chooses to use in his language. This work begins to answer some of the questions that this age child has. “What do these words do? In

how many ways can they work”?

Following the grammar boxes, there is an extended work with most of the parts of speech that's developed through the printed command cards – material that serves to extend the child's vocabulary and to impress the part of speech on the child's mind. With the grammar work, we will also see a few impressionistic charts used to personify, to help the imagination, to interest the child, to help understanding and classification. We'll also see some work charts.

Dr. Montessori talked about 'psycho-grammar', the philosophy of grammar. It is through this approach that we present the grammar of our language and the syntax of our language. We're not going to just give the children dry definitions taken from a grammar book. We're going to allow the children an experience and an activity from which they will be able to make their own definition after they've come to their own understanding. The grammar boxes, their work on syntax, and the way in which these are presented to the children, become keys for the child to penetrate to the essence of our language. They help the child develop a deeper and deeper understanding of word usage.

What we need to remember is that the grammar boxes are not meant to teach everything there is to learn about grammar. By their very design there are certain limitations in the material. The grammar boxes are a way of emphasizing and isolating a certain part of speech so that its function stands out and can be focused on by the child. The child can dwell on just that one idea until he can make his own abstract understanding of it. We will see that working with grammar books also has its place in the elementary class for an even deeper understanding; we'll use it as a resource though not go over to cover in the traditional manner. So the work with grammar boxes is primarily to develop interest and to provide an activity of learning.

The third part of this chapter, sentence analysis or logical analysis, in particular, works on the syntax of our language. We will see that it picks up on the reading analysis work that began in the Casa dei Bambini. The purpose of that work in primary is to extend the child's reading capacity and his understanding. In the elementary class we will learn the names of the parts of the sentence, just as we added in the names of the parts of speech. We'll help deepen and strengthen the child's understanding of the importance of word order in a sentence and what order determines.

Once again, the material we use is not meant to give all the information possible to the children; there are inherent limitations in it. We can delve deeper through grammar and text books. Just as in all areas, not all grammarians agree so the children can look into these things on their own and form their own conclusions.

October 4, 2004

Word Study

Word study has four aspects.

The **first** is the affixes which include suffixes and prefixes. The **second** is compound words. The **third** is word families and the **fourth** is synonyms. All of this work is an **aid to spelling** and word study generally is a **study of the origins of words** and the changes that have been made to words as our language has developed. It is also an **extension of vocabulary** enrichment.

Word study can begin in the children's house, though it is often not the case. The presentations in primary would be a bit different than those in elementary. Whether the children have done them in primary or not, we can begin word study in the beginning of the elementary level even if the children cannot read or write. We use charts with the word study work (e.g., suffixes, prefixes, compound words and word families).

First it is important to realize these charts have limits. There is only one of each chart. The child can make more if he wants to. Also, the charts are not worked with at the table but from a spot where they hang in the classroom – so the charts are hung at eye level for a six year old.

Affixes are little bits added to an already existing word. They are either suffixes which follow the word or prefixes which precede the word. A suffix or prefix is a syllable(s) added to an existing word to modify its meaning. The suffix or prefix does not have a meaning by itself. For example, -ing – is added onto an existing word to change its meaning. Teach becomes teaching, for example.

Most affixes used in English came into the English language from Greek Latin, French or Scandinavian. The majority come from Greek or Latin. Most did not exist in Old English; there were few prefixes there. As the children work with affixes, they may begin to realize that adding a prefix to a word very often alters its meaning. For example, the verb 'place' means to put something down – but 'misplace' means to lose something. We also have replace and displace, each a verb varying in meaning.

A suffix tends to alter the function of the word. For example, if you have occasion, it can become occasional or occasionally. These words are a noun, adjective and adverb respectively. So this aspect of affixes is a later study for the children late in the 6 to 9 class or the 9 to 12 class. It is a way to bring them

back to word study.

October 4, 2004

Suffixes

Part I - Word Suffixes

Prologue

With affixes, we start with the suffixes because, for the children, they are easier to hear. Remember these are done almost always with the 6 year olds. Two students is a good group size. Make sure materials are carried with two hands since it is a great mess to clean up if dropped.

Materials

Two colored movable alphabets – but not black. The suffix chart, moved to the front of the charts and hung in close proximity.

(place box tops at top of work space and place bottoms atop them; boxes side by side)

Suffixes		
jump	jumper	jumpy
conduct	conductor	conducting
form	former	formed
act	actor	acting
fine	finer	fineness
test	testing	tested
spend	spender	spending
friend	friendship	friendly
pain	painful	painless
music	musical	musician
kind	kindly	kindness

Begin

Melissa, please pick one row of the suffix chart and remember it. Make one word at a time of the words on the chart here on the table using the movable alphabet.

(she has picked friend, friendly friendship. Help student to keep the letters tight together to look like words. Student places them in a column on the work space)

Judy, please pick a different row on the chart and make those words on the table as well, *using the same color* that Melissa used.

(Judy proceeds as described placing her words in a new column and next to Melissa's - using the SAME color)

Okay, Melissa, would you read your words (she reads). **Hmm, is there a part that is the same each time?** Can you use the green alphabet and change just the part that is different?

(suffixes are changed to a new color) **friend**
friendly
friendship

Judy, could you read your words? Is there a part that is the same? Could you change only the parts of your words that are different to a new color?

(Judy replaces the suffixes with alphabet of new color)

This part that is different, we call it a suffix. Friend, friendship. Jump, jumper. These are the same words but we've added a suffix to each. Now see if you can do the whole chart.

End

Prologue

Many times you need to guide the children to keep letters neat. Make the children aware the movable alphabets are in alphabetical order. When the children have done all the words on the chart, then they bring the chart from the table and check their work. Don't leave them too soon; make sure they are on the right track before leaving them to work alone.

For those who are not yet reading and writing, take the child to the chart, pick a row of words, focus on the first word in the row and ask the child to look at the letters that make up the word. Say each sound, phonetically pronouncing each and ask the child to go to the table and find those letters. Do each word separately. Casually, as the child is working, point to a word and say "you made jump" or "you made friendship." Children working at this stage may need to check each row they complete. They take the chart, check the row, return the chart - and repeat the process until complete.

As the children are doing this work, periodically ask, "where is the suffix in this word"? Or "What do we call this part of the word"? - pointing to the suffix. Essentially use 3-period lesson techniques for them.



Part II - Word Roots

Remember we worked with suffixes. Today we're going to continue with that and today you can work with any color alphabet you want - including the black letters.

Emily, can you pick a row and read it aloud to us. Is there a part that's the same each time? Come over here.

(the two go back to the table)

The part that is the same, we call that the root. That's a word that comes from the Latin word Radix. The word grows from the root just as a plant does. 'Fine' is the root word you've chosen. Please make the words like we did last time but this time, make the root letters in black.

(Shilena and Carol go back to the chart hung on the wall)

Shilena, can you choose a word. (she chooses pain, painful, painless). Is there a part that is the same for these three? Yes, pain is the root of the word.

(the two students continue as before in Part I "Word Suffixes", this time making the root parts in black and the suffixes in other colors.

Emily, you had fine, finer and finest. Which part is the root? (Answers 'fine') Good.

Shilena, you had the words, pain, painful and painless. Which part is the root in your words? (Answers 'Pain') Good.

Epilogue

Once again, they will do the whole chart and when they finish, they will bring the chart to the table for a control set check. This chart extends the knowledge from the first part (Part I and the suffix), focusing on the root more directly.

Extension

The children can do this work with colored pencil also.



Part III - Classified Suffix Chart

Prologue

Here we are using colored pencils, building on the previous two exercises. Otherwise, we use the same general procedure as Part I “Word Suffixes” and Part II “Word Roots.” This work is especially good for children who need writing practice.

Concept

On this chart, design and designer, teach and teacher are grouped together. On the left is the root word and on the right the suffix is added. We want the children to see the effect of the suffix with this chart. So a designer is someone who designs and a teacher is someone who teaches, for example.

The children do the same work as done in the first part's work (suffix chart and they use the chart to review their work. They then jump off into different work with suffixes that change the function of the word.

Suffixes	
design	designer
teach	teacher
react	reactor
suit	suitor
organ	organist
art	artist
leaf	leafy
need	needy
kind	kindness
dark	darkness
free	freedom
king	kingdom
moral	morality
acid	acidity
host	hostess
priest	priestess

Epilogue

For those with difficulty in writing or simply for additional practice, they can work a while with the movable alphabet before moving to using colored pencils in a more freeform manner, extending the exercises from their own experience.

Extension

Encourage children to look through books and find words with suffixes. They may make their own suffixes and words with suffixes. They can do their own classifications using words with suffixes. They sometimes want to make their own suffix chart – using their own words (don't let them copy a chart).

Material making

The work suffix chart is required for material making. Use different words but remember you will use these with 6 year olds; difficulty and interest should be appropriate for them – stretching but not breaking. Charts should be done in an easy calligraphy or simple font on the computer. The title – only the title – is done in red. Make sure to list materials in the suffix work (Part I) and the classified suffix work (Part III).

October 5, 2004

Prefixes

Exercise I - Visual

Material

Black movable alphabet and a colored movable alphabet, plus the prefix charts hung on the wall (moved to the front of the stack).

Prologue

Begin with a small group. Let them hear the words first. We began with suffixes since they are easier for the children to hear the differences; now we are moving on.

Begin

I want you to **listen to these words: place, displace, replace**. Is there a part that is the same? Yes, place. And what do we call that part? Yes, It's called the root.

Let's go to the chart. We'll need a black alphabet and you can choose any color movable alphabet you like.

I want you to pick any row on the chart and remember it.

(child chooses lay, mislay, relay and overlay)

I want you to make those words using the black alphabet for the parts that are the same and your color (green) for the parts that are different.

lay
mislay
relay
overlay

What do we call the part that is the same? That's right, the root. We call this other part at the beginning, the prefix.

End

October 5, 2004

Exercise II - Listening

Material

Prefix charts hung on the wall (moved to the front of the stack). Colored pencil and a black pencil and paper.

Prologue

This exercise is done as a dictation exercise. Six year olds tend to like dictation. We would say the word and then the child would write the word down. The root is written in black and the prefix is written in colored pencil.

Begin

I want you to listen to these words: place, displace, replace. Is there a part that is the same? Yes, place. And what do we call that part? Yes, It's called the root.

I want you to write those words using the black pencil for the parts that are the same and your colored (green) pencil for the parts that are different.

What do we call this other part at the beginning? Yes, it's the prefix.

End

Epilogue

At a later time, the children can come back and look at the words with prefixes and identify the parts of speech. That activity must follow the grammar box materials. For example, 'displace' is a verb.

Extension

One child dictates the words on the chart to a second. Second child writes each spoken word without looking and using only

regular lead pencil.

October 5, 2004

Compound Words

Introduction to Compound Words

Materials

Compound word chart, hanging on the wall on the top of the stack. A black movable alphabet and colored movable alphabet. Colored and black pencils (or ink) and paper. A small group of objects named by compound words.

Prologue

With your six year olds, start one group with suffixes and a second group with compound words. With some children, compound words may be their first word study work. We do this to have different things going in the environment in order to cross-pollinate the knowledge in the classroom.

Compound words are two complete words that are put together to make a single new word. We begin with a small group of children as well as a small group of objects. Move the compound word chart to the front of the stack hanging on the wall.

Make sure to look up the additional words beforehand to make sure that the examples you use are true compound words. Good groupings of words to use include books, boxes and brushes.

Begin

This is a textbook (hold up book). This is a cookbook. What's this? Yes, a notebook. And what is this? Yes, it is a handbook.

Do you hear a word over and over again with these names? Yes, book. But each of these things is a different kind of book.

What do we call the things we wear on our ears? Earrings, yes. We call words like these compound words. They are made up of two

words. Each part is a word by itself and then put together to make a new word.

End

Exercise I - Using Movable Alphabet

Have the child then make the compound words using the colored movable alphabet for the first word-part and the black movable alphabet for the second part. The second part is usually a noun, while the first part is usually an adjective. This provides the impression we want, that both words have meaning and together achieve a new meaning.

Exercise II - Using Colored Pencil

Do the same as Exercise I - but use pencils (or inks) and paper to construct the words.

Epilogue

Encourage the children to look in books and magazines for compound words. Children this age like to make collections. So they like making booklets, "my booklet of compound words." You can also do dictation just as was done with prefixes.

For the older children 9 to 12, another aspect of compound words is that of a latent or obscure compound words. There are many in the English language. For example, 'Blackbird' is a true compound word. 'Barn' actually derives from two words of Middle English; 'bere' and 'ern'. Another example is nest. This came from 'nether' and 'sit', where nether means below or under - sitting under - nest. This is also from Middle English. The 9 to 12 year olds may look into books on the origins of English. You might want to contact a university professor of Linguistics as a resource.

Another historical fact to explore with the older children is the order of compound words - with the adjective first and the noun second. Has this always been the case? Are there exceptions to that word order? Prior to the 16th century, the adjective-noun order was almost always the pattern used in compound words; after that time, more types of compound words came into use - such as 'pickpocket'.

October 5, 2004

Word Families

Materials

Word Family chart, hanging on the wall on the top of the stack. A black movable alphabet and 2 colored movable alphabets (or colored and black pencils (or ink) and paper). The 3 boxes of movable alphabet are placed at the top of the table, each box resting on top of its lid.

Prologue

This material is a little more sophisticated and is typically for children 8 or nine years old. This comes a bit after compound word activities. The children need to have been introduced to all of the grammar boxes of the elementary level.

Word families are introduced using the same type of exercises as prefixes and suffixes; the only difference is that we use 3 movable alphabets. If desired, this exercise can move directly to writing instead of using the movable alphabets.

Begin

We're going to do word families today. We need the black movable alphabet and you can choose two other colors for us to use.

(student chooses green and yellow and takes movable alphabets to the table workspace)

Can you go to the chart and choose a row and then memorize the words?

Tell me your words. (enclose, closet, close, disclose). Is there a part that is the same in those words? What do we call that. Yes, the root.

All these words are a family because they are related to the root

word. They are all based on the root word, in this case close.

I want you to build these words, using black letters for the root, green for the prefixes and yellow for the suffixes. (child builds words in his chosen row)

Enclose

closet

close

disclose

Fine, now please go get your chart and bring it here to check your answers.

End

Epilogue

Always have the child use the language charts after they've done a whole chart - for control of error. In some cases, the root may change and the child will discover this using the chart. Part of this work is to look up these words and to study the etymology. In the classroom, there should be 4-6 copies of a good dictionary with etymological information. We are interested in looking at the root. We investigate each word for a given row, noting the etymological background and the similar derivation.

Sometimes, the children will have to discuss what the root is and this is a positive development. After the children have worked with the chart that we've prepared, they may make a list of their own word families to investigate. This often hooks children into an interest in words and their origins.

When making your own word family charts, make sure they have the same root and all go back to Latin or Greek or some common heritage.

An excellent resource is Words Come in Families, by Edward Horowitz. It is out of print but can be found in used book markets.

It is also a good time to introduce a personal dictionary. They can use an alphabetized address book. When they have trouble

spelling a word and come for help, the teacher should write the word in the proper location in the personal dictionary. They can add the definitions if they like, but this is primarily for spelling purposes.

October 5, 2004

Synonyms

Per instructor - see verb work with grammar boxes.

October 7, 2004

Parts of Speech

You may remember this is the second section of the chapter on “Grammar and Syntax.” As an introduction to this work, we need to remind ourselves that Dr. Montessori wanted us to understand the philosophy of grammar. So that instead of presenting it as rules to be memorized, instead of presenting it as something dry and rigid, she wanted the children to see the place that grammar has played in the development and history of a language.

We'll look at it in English since that's what we speak. Teaching in another language, you'd use that language.

In one of the books Maria Montessori wrote called Psycho-grammar, not yet translated into English, she helped us to help the children understand the role of language. In this book she apparently makes an analogy with the universe. She says we have a force, the force of energy – and we have matter. She compares those to a couple parts of speech. She symbolized matter by referring to the noun, the name. She talks about its enduring history. To symbolize the noun, she used a pyramid. She reminded us that a pyramid is one of the most ancient buildings. And yet, many of them have survived in different parts of the world. So the pyramid goes way back in history to the very early civilizations. The pyramids have stood for century after century. A pyramid is a building secure on its base and it seems to stand eternally. In the grammar symbols, what's the symbol for the noun? A black triangle – a simplification of a pyramid. This pyramid will stay right where I place it unless I move it over there.

But what about a ball?

A ball is full of energy. It rolls all over – as long as I've got it started – until something or someone stops it. The red ball was used by Montessori to represent energy, the energy in the universe. And the idea of a red ball was translated into the big red circle that is used to connote a verb. In this book, Psycho-grammar, Maria Montessori talks about the two symbols.

In the grammar boxes, the work centers around these two important parts of speech: nouns and verbs. The other parts of speech have a relationship to either the noun or the verb and that relationship is determined by either the noun or the verb.

In order to get the children interested in exploring their language more deeply, we have to help them use their imaginations around words, not to think of these presentations as “grammar lessons.” These are going to be explorations for the children to undertake.

In the grammar boxes, we'll work with 9 parts of speech. Most grammarians still agree we have 9, though some say there are 8 parts. The children have already encountered 7 of these in function of words in the primary environment: all but interjections and pronouns. We're going to build on that foundation of “function of words” in the primary and help the children further develop those impressions that they should already have.

In the grammar boxes, each part of speech is distinguished by a different color. These are not always the same color as the grammar symbols. Montessori did this on purpose. She did not want the child just matching colors. Rather she wanted the mind to really be focused on and thinking about the part of speech at hand. There is no significance to the colors used – except that they are different.

Most of the grammar boxes are introduced by oral commands. The oral commands you will probably see are somewhat similar to their function of word experience. So, they should serve as a reminder. And for children who have not had function of words in primary, you would extend the oral introductions, extend the oral commands to give them more of a foundation.

We give the oral commands as the first initiation to that part of speech in the elementary environment. The child will carry out the command and get an introduction. From the oral introduction, the formal work with the grammar box begins. So, the grammar boxes come right after the oral introduction, if there is an oral introduction – on the same day – introduce and go on to the card activity.

It is with the grammar box that we will give the name for the part of speech. And the name crystalizes the child's experience and helps the mind classify. The grammar boxes and the contents which fill them allow for a manipulative activity on the part of the children. **It is not a written activity.** They are not used for writing. This kills the joy of that work. It should be fun. There is a writing activity that follows the grammar boxes but the grammar boxes stand alone – without writing at all.

By being a manipulative activity, the child has to put the words in order himself and gets practice doing this. So, over and over again, he's **experiencing building up the structure of a sentence.**

We'll also look at what happens when we change that order – just by manipulating those cards.

Along with each grammar box, there are several “filler boxes”, deriving their name from the fact that the content will be used to fill the grammar box. The filler boxes are designed for further repetition, for more practice, more experience – if a child needs it. This should tell us that the children are not required to work through all of them. If they have worked with the first couple and we can see they have an understanding, we don't need to hold them back – yet we see teachers who require students to work with each and every one. Some children do need this but certainly not all do.

When we're not using a grammar box, they are kept on the shelves - empty except for small colored cards that we call “cover slips.” The cover slips are the only thing left in the grammar boxes. Everything else is kept in the filler box. So each time the child has the **experience of organizing the parts of speech into their proper compartments in the grammar boxes.**

Organizationally, we can see that each of the filler boxes has a number (a small white sticker on the edge, 4a, for example). Every card in this filler box is coded on the back with “4a”. This helps us because when you find a card behind the shelf, we know where it goes at once.

Most of these cards come from Nienhouse and they are already coded. When a card gets lost and you make a new one, be sure to write the code on the back. Make sure you *make the children aware of the coding so that if they find a card dropped under the table and unnoticed, they can help keep the organization of the grammar boxes up to standard.*

Along side the grammar boxes and filler boxes, we have something called the “command cards” (white cards in an open-top box). They contain printed **commands with the purpose of extending the children's work with each part of speech.** In some cases they build vocabulary. Often a command card will need to be carried out by a group of children. So the children doing the command card has to ask for help. They gather friends willing to help them. Sometimes they'll even go to a primary class to get help. So it calls for cooperation and working together.

With some of the parts of speech, there are also other exercises that draw the child's attention to a particular aspect of that part of speech. For example, with the adjective – we'll work with adjectives on command cards. You've heard about the comparative

form of the adjective. We'll have an exercise in the elementary environment that also focuses on the comparative and superlative forms of adjectives.

With some of the parts of speech, we will use either impressionistic charts or charts for classification – charts more like work charts. After the children have completed working with the grammar boxes and all of the various exercises and extended activities, there comes a passage between the grammar boxes and grammar books. It is this passage that allows the children to work abstractly with the parts of speech. This is where written activities would come in. There are a couple different ways in which this can be done.

One of the ways would be to have the child do some writing – a sentence, paragraph or story – and then *underline each word in the color of its grammar symbol*. This is a fast way to tell if they've arrived at that point of identifying the parts of speech.

Another way is to write out a sentence such as “A little boy ate his lunch.” Then take each word of that sentence and write it one at a time on a single line – and write everything we know about that word. For example, 'The' is a “definite article”. 'Little' is a “descriptive adjective”. And so on. This way we know what they have mastered. So this becomes a summing up work of all the previous language experience the child has had.

Finally, in the upper elementary classroom, the children should be **exploring the parts of speech in grammar books** and in grammar text books. In the classroom, there should be a few samples of these at different grade levels. What this does not mean, is that we work through these books – from cover to cover. No. We've studied adjectives, classifications of adjectives. Is there anything else to learn about adjectives? This is more of what our course should be. Invite the child to look in various books to see what else they can learn about adjectives.

We'll learn some classifications about adjectives. This is an area that not all grammarians agree on. So this is one area the children can come to appreciate.

Some people think Maria Montessori made the grammar boxes to get away from grammar books. But she really did it to make it understandable. She made them to allow the child a discovery experience. She certainly intended that the child eventually encounters grammar books and what various people have to say in them.

Along side this work, make sure to keep an eye on the public school curriculum. Cover what needs to be covered by age 9 or age 12. Another work that will parallel all of this work is working with an etymological dictionary. The children look up the origins of words. Particularly as the children get a little older and certainly by the upper elementary class, they may want to start making a list of words that we use today that have changed their meaning from when they first came into our language.

An example is the word 'pretty'. It came from the Anglo-Saxon into Middle English. It originally meant deceitful or tricky. Another example is the word 'villain'. It came from Middle English where it meant servile or slave. It's spelling also changed from the original form as 'vilein'. As our history progressed and our language developed, the spelling changed to 'villain' and now it means scoundrel or a bad person. The word toilet is also an amusing word to follow its history.

Grammar Symbols

The grammar symbols and their part of speech counterparts are the following:

Common Noun		Large black triangle
Abstract Noun superimposed		Large black triangle, a blue circle
Spiritual Noun superimposed		Large black triangle, a gold circle
Proper Noun		Large black triangle, gold triangle at top.
Transitive Verb		Large red circle
Intransitive Verb		Large red circle, a gold circle superimposed

Auxiliary Verb superimposed		Large red circle, a small white circle
Linking Verb superimposed		Large red circle, a small white triangle
Infinitives, Participles		Large silver circle
Adverb		Small orange circle
Article		Small light blue triangle
Adjective		Small dark blue triangle
Possessive Adjective rounded corners		Small light blue triangle with
Conjunction		Dark pink hyphen
Preposition		Green crescent (arching upward)
Pronoun		Tall purple triangle
Interjection		Gold exclamation point

October 7, 2004

Introduction to the Noun

This is background information, some for the teacher and some for the children.

If we remember the introduction of words to the children in the primary, we recall they want to identify people and objects around them. They want names. Montessori's observation was that in a way, this parallels the historical development of language, that names, or nouns, were either the first or one of the first parts of speech to have been developed. People needed to name what was in their environment to be able to communicate about it.

Young children will sit for hours and just have pictures of objects named for them. Long before the child is able to fully use his language, he is fascinated by names. Dr. Montessori used the pyramid to symbolize names because of its stability and enduring history. As we think about names, we can also reflect on the fact that the names for objects endure and are passed down from one age to the next. But the people who gave them the name are generally unknown. We don't know who first thought of calling a tree 'tree'. The name endures but we don't know who established it.

It would appear that names in language are fixed for just about everything. In a book called Our Language by Simeon Potter, there is a chapter on names and people and places. In this chapter he says, "Primitive man felt that the relationship between name and thing, between symbol and referent, was close and intimate. The frivolous or malicious handling of a name in speech might imply insult or injury to the person bearing that name. The very name was hallowed." This is something to remember today - handle names carefully and respectfully.

We know throughout history of many instances where someone's name was changed, either because they did something important or because they were given a special task. For instance, William became known as William the Conqueror. Abram became Abraham. We want to develop little stories about names and changing names to tell the children.

English surnames fall into four categories. If we were in

England and opened a phone book to look at surnames, most of the names would fall into four categories: patronimic, occupational, descriptive or local. Patronymic is like Johnson. McDaniel is also patronimic. The son of John. O'Keith is "of Keith". Occupational names are like baker, barber and smith. There are descriptive names like Black, Brown and Long. Local names apply to just a particular region or area; Forest is considered local as is London and Atwater.

This is one aspect of the study of nouns to take up with the children. If we start with English surnames, they will want to know about other names as well that will get us looking into other languages and name classifications. What do those other names mean and where did they come from? We want to start looking at proper nouns given to people to distinguish one from the other. So the children can start to do research into where these names come from.

Here in the United States, one can look at an atlas or map of our country. Where did some of *those* names come from? Who named the cities and rivers. What does it tell us about our history. St. Augustine, for example. Or Milwaukee. These names have a background and meaning that the child can uncover. Who were the first people to live in those places?

As we begin to study nouns with the children, they will see this aspect of eternity to them and we also want to help them look at the variations that nouns have. In modern English there are only 4 variations that remain: **singular, plural, masculine and feminine**. There are also combinations of these of course. But going back in the history of our language, if we traced English back to Proto-Germanic, we would find that, there, nouns had grammatical gender – as German still does – in which all nouns are either masculine or feminine or neuter. This simplification has made English easier to learn and the children can appreciate this. Another complication in Proto-Germanic that we have lost in modern English is that nouns used to be inflective to indicate case. This means a little was added onto the end of the word. There used to be a "nominative case", used for to grammatically determine the subject. Now we know the subject by word order.

By Middle English, we were already left with the two forms of the nouns – singular and plural or masculine and feminine. The other distinction had been dropped. We can be grateful for those who, along the road of history, helped to simplify our language. Many things in language have been dropped over the years in this manner.

October 7, 2004

Oral Presentation of the Noun

Prologue

The children in this lesson are about 6 years old. We use a group of 6 or 7 for this lesson. Older children don't like this lesson; too silly for them. Younger kids will play long because they know there is something 'funny' going on. Be playful.

Make sure the majority of your cards from the filler boxes are nouns to make it interesting. Also include some examples of other colors, like lock, for example.

Remember we said most parts of speech start with an oral command; that is what follows. We'll call together our group of children who've just come in from the primary level and begin:

Begin

What's your name? (Emily) What's your name. (Flor) We each have names don't we. If we go over here by my office door and say 'Emily', what happens? Would you come over here Emily? Why did you come (because you called my name).

Let's go back and join our other friends. How about this. Does it have a name. Yes, it's a chair. What's that? Yes, it's a door. These things all seem to have names also, don't they?

Let's play a little game. Please go around the classroom, carefully and quietly so as to not disturb the others. Who can be the first one to find something that doesn't have a name?

(children find some things but teacher debunks their efforts - providing a name for each)

Who's going to be the first to find something without a name?. You couldn't find anything? Well, okay let's play another game then. Go around the classroom again and each of you please bring to me ____.

Just go off and bring _____ to me. Don't just stand there, go get me a _____.

No, I did not ask for the plant and I did not ask for the bell. Please bring to me _____.

Why can't you bring _____ to me? (you didn't name anything) Well, that's correct, I didn't ask for anything in particular.

Eliza, would you please bring me a cube. Vicki, would you please bring me a book. Flor, would you please bring me a bead-bar. Emily, would you please bring me a chart.

What did you bring me? A cube. How did you know to bring a cube. (because you told me the name of the thing to bring) Okay, thank you. (repeat each time for each child)

End

Epilogue

If someone tells you that you have not told them what to bring, keep that one with you and let the others go. Don't spoil the fun for the others.

The two games are variations of each other. They serve as the oral introduction to the noun. These are two ways of impressing on the children that everything has a name. It's very different from giving the definition of a noun.

This is also a good place to tell a little story about nouns. William the Conqueror, for example, gives a story to explain his name. The Egyptians gave everyone a public name and a private name. The private name was kept secret – though it was their real name. Egyptians believed that if someone else knew the real name, it would give them power over that person. This is why they kept the private name a secret and used their public name with others instead.

Follow-up Activity

After the oral introduction and story, there is a card activity

that we might go directly into with two or three of the children in the group – picking up the others the next time. For this activity, gather up about twenty cards from various filler boxes. We also need a black card on which is written the name 'noun'. We'll also use the grammar symbols.

Begin

I have a collection of cards here. You're going to read the words on these cards. If the word is the name of something, we'll form a column of them here on the table. If it's not the name of something, we'll put the card in pile to the side.

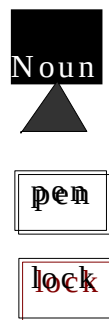
(children go through the stack per above)

Now, would one of you read your list and let's make sure each one is a name.

(children read and verify that each one is a name of something)

Do you remember what symbol we use with words that are a name of something. Yes, a **black triangle**. **Would you like to put the symbol at the top of our column.**

Words that are name of people, places or things are called nouns. Would you like to place this noun card at the top of our column?



back

:
:

But what about these words. Let's check again to make sure they are not people, places or things.

(children recheck non-noun list)

End

Epilogue

Stay away from words that are interjections or pronouns since the children have not had them at all.

More Follow-up

A few days later there are extensions to this work that can be picked up on:

- One of them is to gather the same children again and do an oral review of nouns by asking them to think of nouns in a certain grouping or category. For example, let's think of words that are food. Each child offers an example in turns.
- On another day, another extension would be to gather the same children up again and tell them, "Today we're going to make little lists of nouns under specific groupings. On the top of your paper, you're going to write nouns, then under that, "vegetables" (for example), and then make your list. (each child chooses their own category). When you make your list, use your very best handwriting because when you're done, we're going to put the lists together and make a little book of nouns. This book will include each one of your lists." (This is a good exercise to introduce the idea of a group project - where someone does a cover page, someone punches holes in the paper or even better, the group decides how to bind the pages, etc.)
- Another exercise worth mentioning, especially for those who are

having trouble with hand-writing, is to make lists for nouns using the movable alphabets.

October 8, 2004

Articles - Grammar Box II

Material

Filler box 2a, grammar symbols **(light blue triangle)** and grammar box II.

Prologue

Note that numbering of the grammar boxes refers to the number of compartments in the boxes (number of parts of speech). Grammar box two starts off with two parts of speech: nouns and articles

This is done with a small group of children (2-3). We begin with a little listening exercise as our oral introduction:

Begin

Judy, if I wanted you to bring me the million cube, would I say, "would you bring me million cube?" No, we need the word 'the' before million. So we have these little words in front of nouns. (repeat as needed to get the idea across)

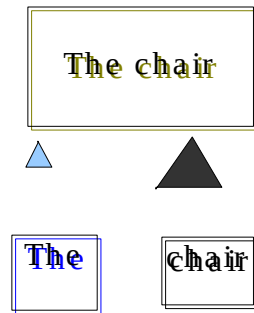
We have some material now that we're going to work on to learn about these little words that come before nouns.

In here are the cards we'll use to fill our grammar box. The big slips from the filler box go here in the grammar box.

(place phrase card on the table at top to form a new column, building toward you)

Can you read these two words? (point to phrase card that says 'the chair'). Can you find those two words in the bottom boxes. (student finds the two cards that match the phrase card)

Can you find the grammar symbols for those words? Good.



(each time we finish with a phrase card, the symbols go back into the symbols box and the phrase and noun cards go to the right of the grammar box to be displayed. The article card goes back into the box each time. (since there are only 3 articles)

What's the next phrase? (a shoe) Can you find the cards for that phrase. Good. Can you find the symbols for the words also?

(after a few have been done and the idea is established...)

Do you know what kind of word this is? (point to the noun) Yes, it's a noun.

Would you like to see what this word looks like? (pull the brown cover slip from underneath the first couple nouns - it displays 'noun').

This other word also has a name. It's called an article. Would you like to see what that word looks like? (again expose the word 'article' in the grammar box)

End

Epilogue

Our goal is for the children to work all the way through the filler box of nouns. Along the way, ask **“can you please point to the noun.” (or article), as a second period lesson. As a third period, we point and ask “what part of speech is this?”**

October 8, 2004

Definite and Indefinite Articles

Material

Filler box 2b, grammar symbols.

Prologue

In this filler box we have a packet of article cards and noun cards, equal in number (that is important). We are trying to build our workspace to have two columns of:

label (e.g. Definite article)

symbol (e.g. From grammar symbols)

list of articles or nouns

Begin

Can you read this. Chair, yes, Do you know what part of speech that is? Yes, a noun. I'll put this card here. (place at top right column)

How about this word? Yes, that's 'the.' Do you know what part of speech that is? Yes, it's an article. I'll put this card here (place at top left column)

(let the child take over)

I want you to put down a noun card and then decide which article you want to use with that noun. (place brown article card and black noun card at top of table horizontally in left column)

(repeat with other nouns. Child chooses an article for each noun and segregates the two columns by definite (the) and indefinite (a/an) articles.)

the horse

an institute

the hotel	a fireman
the bird	a horse
:	:

(sometimes toward the end, we're required to switch an article from one noun to another noun in order to complete all examples.)

Do you remember the symbols for grammar?

Let's **place the grammar symbols at the top of each column** instead of for each word.

What part of speech are these here?

Yes, nouns. I have a little label for nouns I'll place here at the top of the noun column.

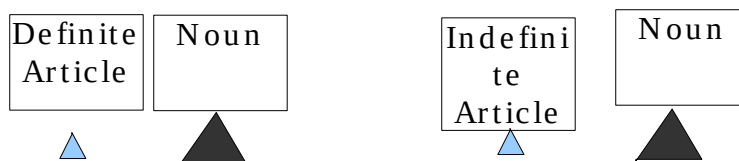
What part of speech are these here? Yes, articles.

These are **definite articles because it identifies one particular thing**. "The horse, the bird."

I have a label for definite articles too. I'll place it here at the top of the definite article column.

What part of speech are these here? Yes, articles again. But these are called **indefinite articles because it identifies any one of a particular thing** - not a definite thing but any one of those things from a group of them.

"A horse, a bird." I have a label for indefinite articles too. I'll place here at the top of the indefinite article column.





End

Epilogue

The definite article 'the' comes from the demonstrative adjective "that." The indefinite articles 'a' and 'an' both come from the word 'one'. One country out of all the countries of the world - a country. Today we use the word 'an' only in front of words that begin with a vowel or a vowel sound.

To put materials away, gather nouns into one pile and rubber-band them. Articles can be randomized, rubber-banded and returned to the filler box. The white cards are also in the same filler box - two that say noun, one saying indefinite article and a third one saying definite article.

Extension

Have the children write their own lists with nouns matched up with indefinite and definite articles. They choose the nouns. Particularly for children who need writing practice, it's *important to remember these type of exercises that write words*.

October 8, 2004

Classification of Nouns

Singular and Plural

Material

Filler box 2c, two stacks of noun cards (one singular and one plural) and some objects from the environment to demonstrate the use of singular and plural. There are also two white cards in the box that say 'singular' and 'plural' (they are left in the box initially).

Prologue

This lesson looks at the singular and plural aspect of nouns. We begin with a little introduction using objects from the environment.

This is a great activity for two children. One child chooses one card and reads it, placing it at top of table. (nail) The second child finds the same word when there are more than one (nails). The oral introduction follows:

Begin

What is this. Yes, it's a skittle. What are these? Skittles again. What is this? Yes, it's a bead-bar. What are these? Yes, they are bead-bars. What is this? A pencil, yes. What are these? Yes, they are pencils.

Would I say skittles for this (hold up one skittle)?

(repeat this question for pencils and others)

We're going to make some lists of words. (take of rubber bands off singular nouns)

All of these words that we use when we just have one of something, we call them **singular**. There is only a single one of that thing. And

it's the singular form of the noun. Here's that word singular. (pull 'singular' from the filler box) Would you put it at the top of the column of singular nouns?

(take of rubber bands off plural nouns)

All these words here, we use when there are more than one of a thing; we call it **plural**. It's the plural form of the noun. Here's that word 'plural'. (pull label from the filler box) Would you put it on the top of the column for plural nouns?

Singular	Plural
Bone	Bones
Airplane	Airplanes
:	:
:	:

Now you can finish the rest of the nouns in the box and then make your own lists.

End

Epilogue

Besides singular and plural nouns, we are also working on spelling here. In each set of nouns, give a few cards to get the children started, but leave them plenty to explore for themselves.

You can also make some little booklets that correspond to the set of nouns for each of these rules . The children can then use the booklets as a reading activity. Either the cards or the booklets can be used for dictation: "I'll give you the singular and you write the plural."

For those that have difficulty writing, they can use the movable alphabet. In that case, they can make the plural ending in a different color. Any variety of activities that one can think of to help them practice writing and spelling these words will help spelling skills.

All of the nouns used here end with a consonant. Each one ends with -s and is printed in red. There should be several sets of nouns that can be used in the classroom. The various sets might include:

- a set of words that ends in e, plural adds -s
- a set of words that ends in sh, ch, x or z, plural adds -es
- a set of words that ends in o, plural adds -s
- a set of words that ends in o, plural adds -es
- a set of words that ends in f, plural changes f to v and adds -es (halves)
- a set of words that ends in fe, plural changes f to v and adds -s after the original e
- a set of words that ends in f or ff, plural adds -s (staffs)
- a set of words that ends in y, plural changes y to i and adds -es (pennies)
- a set of words that ends in y, plural adds -s (toys)
- words where plural adds -en or -ren (children)
- words where an internal change in singular (mouse – mice)
- words where singular and plural are identical (deer)
- compound words where plural is formed by adding s to last noun (rainbows)
- compound words where plural formed by adding -s to the first noun (passersby)

October 12, 2004

Gender

Material

Filler box 2d. There are multiple sets (g1 is set one for gender cards). There is a 3rd set of cards called 'common gender.' 'Common gender' is meant to be a term for the young – not yet distinguished by gender. So a complete round would be man, woman and child – for example – using the two sets of cards labeled g1 and g1-cg.



Prologue

In the classroom, you may have gone on to other grammar boxes. Every once in a while, return to nouns and go over another classification of nouns. This is the only way to get through all of the material we need to cover in just a few years.

By the age of 8, the children should have been introduced to all of the grammar boxes and all the different aspects of speech. So, this requires a lot of parallel work.

Begin

Calling All Boys

(Call together all of the boys that are new to class.)

(Call together all of the girls that are new to class.)

Introduce Gender

When I called boys here, we call boys the masculine form of a noun.

Girls, all of you came when I called the girls. Girls is the feminine form of the noun. Women, would also be a feminine form for a noun.

Filler Box

Today, we'll work with nouns and lists again. This time we'll look at masculine and feminine nouns.

Label Columns

So, feminine and masculine – I have those two words to place at the top of our columns.

We'll give Danielle these words. Elisa, you have these words.

(give two stacks of cards out – one to each child)

Separate & Part-Counterpart

(Elisa chooses man) Is that the feminine or masculine form (answers masculine).

Danielle, what would be the feminine form of that word (answers woman).

(place cards into respective columns – under masculine or feminine)

(repeat as above cow-bull, lion-lioness, switch turns each time)



We have something that is referred to as the common gender. It refers to the young of each that is not distinguished as masculine or feminine – it only refers to the young.

Here is the set of cards for this. Can we add a third column using these cards?

(build a 3rd column with correspondences across rows as well)

End

Epilogue

Invite the children to use the cards on their own. We used g1 that included masculine and feminine. There is a second set with g2 on them that are merely more examples of masculine and feminine. The common gender cards are also coded on the back as g1-cg for common gender; these cards are used with g1 cards only.

October 12, 2004

Proper and Common

Material

Clear box labeled classification of nouns (not a filler box) generated in each environment. The coding on the back of the cards is 'N-CI-1' for noun classification – first set. When we pick these up, we pick them up in their separate piles. So, they are also returned in two separate stacks.



Prologue

With the children, you are again going to call the boys together who are new to the class in a group. And then call the girls who are new to the class to form another group. Then walk a bit away from these two groups and call one of the girls by her specific name – Vicki. (Don't call a person who has a name which is also the name of another person in the group.)

Walk a few steps away again and call one of the boys.

Begin

Calling All Boys

(walk a few steps away from the group of boys and girls)

Vicki – would you come here please?

(walk a few steps away)

Eric, would you come here please?

Name Calling

Why did only Eric come when I called? (That's his name)

But when I called boys, the whole group of boys came. When I asked for the girls, this whole group came. How come, when I called Vicki, only Vicki came?

We have names – nouns – that are shared by several different places or things or people. Like boys or girls. These are two nouns that are shared by many people.

Is Vicki, in this class, a noun that is shared by several people? No, it's her particular name. She owns it. What about Eric? In this class, is Eric a name that's shared? Or is it a name that belongs to just one person? Eric owns that name. It refers to one person.

What about country? Does that noun belong to one or to many? Yes, to many. How about Poland? Does that name belong to one country or to many? Yes, to only one particular country. Only one country is called Poland.

How about Delaware? Does that name belong to one or to many? Yes, to one. What about states? States belong to many, yes.

Introduce Proper

Nouns that belong to one special place or one special person are called proper nouns. The word 'proper' comes from the Latin word 'proprius', meaning 'one's own.' It is one's own name – a proper noun.

The nouns that are shared by many, like 'states' and 'boys' are called common nouns.

Label Columns

In this box labeled classification of nouns, we have two stacks of nouns – one with a brown card on top that says 'common' and the other with a brown card on top that says 'proper.' So, our heading cards will say common and proper. Within our cards is an assortment of common and proper nouns, all mixed together.

Mix & Classify

Who would like to sort them out. (choose 2 at a time)

(children take turns drawing a card from their stack and place each card in the correct column – either common or proper.

End

Epilogue

Suggest the children repeat with these cards, as well as do a writing assignment using your own nouns. Point out that proper nouns begin with capital letters and let the children know if they need help with the capital letters, to ask. This provides an entry into working on the capital letters as well. It can be useful to have a set of letters that show what the lower and upper case letters look like. This is as opposed to displaying them up on a wall, which is not nearly as usable. Also, looking at a map or atlas will give them many more opportunities to see and use proper nouns.

October 12, 2004

Concrete and Abstract

Material

Objects in the room and general environment are used in the introduction.

In the box labeled 'classification of nouns', there are two more sets of cards labeled concrete and abstract. These noun cards are all abstract. **We must mix these with our common noun cards used in the “Common and Proper Nouns” lessons.**



Prologue

All work with grammar boxes typically begin with an oral introduction.

Begin

Bring Me a Sweater

Could I have 5 volunteers who are new to the class?

Carson, could you please bring a sweater. You may have to search all over the school but please find and bring me a sweater.

(assign each child to find - a cup of coffee, a bell, the million cube,

perfume, etc.)

Carson, what did you bring? Yes, a sweater. I can feel how soft it is.

What did you bring Jasmine? Perfume, yes I can smell it.

Judy, what did you bring. Yes, I can smell and I can taste the coffee.

Emily, what did you bring? Yes, I can see the million cube - it's so large.

Bring Me Happiness

Now, I have something else for you to bring.

Jasmine, please bring me goodness.

Carson, bring me youth.

Shilena, please bring me beauty.

Emily, can you please find and bring me happiness. Don't just stand here.

Ah, you have brought me a growing plant, but that is not growth.

You have brought me a figure jumping with happiness but that is not happiness.

(each child brings something and then is rejected)

Introduce Concrete

The first time, you could find things to bring me. We could hear the bell. Smell the coffee and so on. These kind of nouns are called **concrete** nouns.

But the second set of things I asked you to bring me - beauty, youth and so on -you could not bring me. These are things only known to the mind. These are called **abstract** nouns.

Label Columns

Now I have two more heading cards for our columns - one for

concrete and one for abstract. Who would like to look at these cards and categorize them into column?

Mix & Classify

(two children go through two sets of cards and put them into respective columns. These cards are created by mixing the abstract nouns with the common nouns. Then simply split the cards after shuffling or else let them work together from a single stack, taking turns.)

End

Epilogue

Make sure to send the children to get things, for abstract nouns, that cannot be sensed with the 5 senses and on the other hand, make sure that concrete nouns you ask them to retrieve *can* be sensed with the 5 senses.

Be sure to ask them for things in the concrete nouns that will require them to go all over the environment to find them. Then emphasize the sensual aspect of those items. With the second set (abstract) of nouns, they will be prepared to search all over – and ask them to go on and look around. They will bring things growing, for example, but will not be able to bring you 'growth.'

So this provides two more categories for nouns – concrete and abstract. This presentation comes a little later than some of the other categories of nouns. Concrete and abstract is harder to distinguish than masculine and feminine, so allowances must be made for the individual children as what is appropriate and when.

October 12, 2004

Material and Collective

Material

A stack of nouns and two heading cards: material and collective.



Prologue

These are just two new categories that are unrelated – as opposed to others like masculine and feminine – which mutually exclude each other.

Begin

Introduce Collective and Material

We're going to talk about two new kinds of nouns today: collective and material nouns.

Collective nouns signify a group or a collection. Some are single words while some are phrases. This is not merely plural but rather something like army – it is singular but collective.

Material nouns are those that refer literally to materials.

Label Columns

Here is a stack of noun cards. (lay brown heading cards in two columns)

Mix & Classify

Work together to separate them by collective and material nouns.

(black noun cards are laid in their correct row – collective or material)

(children draw: Air – material, Chain of mountains – collective, group – collective, pride of lion – collective, gold – material, water – material; and so on.)

I wonder if you'd like to make your own list of collective or material nouns?

End

Epilogue

An exaltation of Larks, by James Lipton, is an excellent book for work with collective nouns. It includes historical terms and current terms.

Like the Concrete and Abstract lesson, it should come a bit later than some others – perhaps at 7 or 7 ½ years old.

October 12, 2004

Classification of Abstract Nouns

Material

Classification of nouns box with the abstract nouns. There is also a chart for the classification of nouns that has the headings we've been working with.



state	action	quality
slavery	increase	beauty
friendship	growth	goodness

Begin

Introduce Quality, Action & State

Abstract nouns can be separated into groups, like we have seen that other nouns can be separated into groups. Abstract nouns fall into one of three groups.

Some abstract nouns are something called a **quality** – or an essential nature; beauty is an example of a quality.

The second group is an **action**; an action noun refers to some kind of movement. Growth is an example of an abstract action noun.

The third type is **state**; these abstract nouns refer to the conditions or circumstances in which someone or something exists. For example, slavery, is an example of an abstract state noun.

Label Columns

I have three cards with the headings Quality, Action and State. And we have our abstract noun cards.

Mix & Classify

How about kindness. Yes, quality.

What about beauty? Yes, quality.

How about increase? Yes, it's an action.

Friendship? Yes, it's a state. Manhood? State.

These are the only cards we have. Maybe you can think of other cards you'd like to add to make columns with these three categories.

End

Epilogue

Remember to encourage the children to discuss what they think and why they think one column is right or wrong for a given noun. The children can use this chart with the same noun cards or new ones they can make.

There are also some additional grammar symbols to show the children at the appropriate moment while doing this work. We can symbolize abstract nouns by superimposing a blue circle onto the black triangle.

Dr. Montessori used a symbol for a spiritual noun as well. This symbol was a gold circle on a black triangle. For any words that use spiritual context like mother-earth or Buddha.

For proper nouns, she used a gold triangle at the tip-top of a black triangle. These symbols come in the extra symbols box – except for the gold triangle. We may have to cut some of the symbols in order to put them together to form more highly refined symbols.



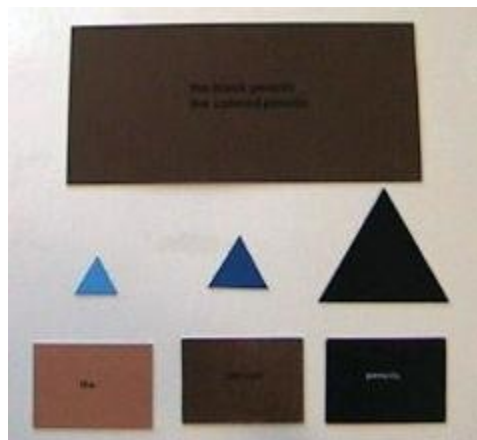
October 13, 2004

Adjectives - Grammar Box III

Function of Adjectives

Material

Filler box 3a, grammar symbols (**dark blue triangle**) and grammar box.



Prologue

This work runs parallel to the early noun classifications that we do.

In the primary class function of words lessons, the children have been introduced to the adjective there. The teacher had a lesson that wrote an article and noun combination and asked the child to retrieve a horse; with the additional adjectival information, the child is able to bring the correct instance of the object.

We're going to take the impression built in the primary and build on it in a different way. We will again begin with an oral

introduction. We call together the children who are new to the class – a group of 6-8 children.

No matter what they bring in the introduction, you don't want it. Until finally, someone asks, “what kind do you want”? **Make sure to remember what you've already rejected and be sure to ask for something that has several possibilities.**

This grammar box presentation sets the pattern for the rest of the grammar box work. This presentation needs to be clearly written up and illustrated; this pattern will be the reference point for other write-up. Make sure to get wording for questions and sequence clearly.

Begin

Bring Me

We're going to play a new game today.

Would you please bring me a book? Would you bring me a bead?
Would you please bring me a cube? Would you bring me an inset?

What did you bring? You brought me a cube. But I don't want a green cube.

What did you bring? You brought me a book. But I don't want a notebook.

What did you bring? You brought me a bead. But I don't want a black bead.

What did you bring? You brought me an inset. But I don't want a square inset.

I want a pink bead. I want a black book. I'd like a plastic box. I would like a triangular inset.

What did you bring to me? How did you know to bring that one? (you told me to get a pink bead)

(repeat same for other 3 children. Dismiss all but 2-3 children; include them another day)

Make Phrase

Now I'm going to show you the next grammar box(retrieve filler box 3a, grammar symbols and grammar box and setup at a table)

We'll fill the grammar box with the filler cards as we did last time we worked with grammar box.



We begin by putting this card there. (place phrase card at top)

Can you read this? (the red book)

Can you find each of those little words and make the phrase with new cards?

(there is a phrase card “a red book” and pupil chooses 3 cards that make that phrase; she builds it up below the phrase card)



Is that the same word order? (yes). Can you get what this says? Can you go and get what this says?

Can you read the second phrase? (the black book)

Can you find each of those little words and make the phrase with new cards?

(pupil again chooses 3 cards that make the phrase; placed below of the phrase card)

Get What It Says

Can you get what this says? Can you go and get what this says?

Which Word & Symbolize

Which word told you what I wanted to get? (book)

Can you put a grammar symbol over your word card? (places black triangle symbol)

Which word told you whether it was a specific one or one of many? (the)

Can you put a grammar symbol over your word card? (places small

light blue triangle)

Which word told you which one to get? (black)

Can you put a grammar symbol over your word card ? (small medium blue triangle)



(repeat until all phrases on this card have been done)

(next card)

Can you read the phrase? (the clear water)

Can you find the little words that make up that phrase? (pupil finds the word cards and builds the phrase underneath the original phrase card)

Now can you go and get what that says? (she gets a glass of water)

Now can you read the next card here (point to adjective stack of cards)? (colored)

Can you go and get what that card says? (pupil goes to get colored water)

Which word told you what I wanted? (points to 'water')

Can you find the symbol for that?

What part of speech is that? (noun) Would you like to see that word noun? (yes) There it is (remove slip that hides 'noun').

Which word told you whether I wanted a specific one or one of many? ('the')

Can you find the symbol for that?

What part of speech is that? (article) Would you like to see that word article? (yes) There it is (uncovers the slip that says 'article.')



Introduce Adjective

What's the word that told you which one I wanted? (points to 'colored')

This part of speech is called an adjective. Red is an adjective and yellow is an adjective. Would you like to see that word adjective? (yes) There it is ('adjective')



Now as you work with this grammar box you can keep these (parts of speech) cards up.

End

Epilogue

Rather than giving a definition, we allow the child to experience an adjective. This way the child can build up their own understanding instead of only adopting an explanation of someone else.

At the end of the lesson, review the parts of speech the child knows as you demonstrate which word did what; uncover the names (e.g., noun) as you review each one. At the end, for the new part of speech, introduce it as a new part of speech. Use second-period repetition in this lesson and third-period repetition a while later to review the parts of speech.

When we're done the large card goes on the bottom of the box. The stacks of cards are rubber-banded and placed in the inner boxes. Cover slips go on top.

October 13, 2004

Command Cards and Classifications

Material

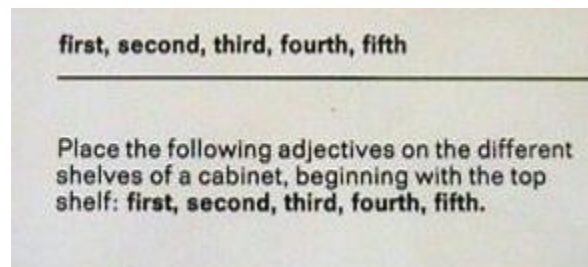
Command cards for adjectives. Adjective Classification chart.

Prologue

Most of the parts of speech have command cards that can be introduced to the children after they've had experience with the grammar boxes. This extends their work with parts of speech. In some cases, they increase their vocabulary as well.

Begin

Here we have a command card printed here. These words at the top are these cards (point to separate stack of small cards)



Can you read what the command says? Can you do that now?

First, second, third, fourth and fifth. (each of the small brown cards will now be placed on a remote shelf)



These words: first second and third, are called ordinal numbers. Do you think twentieth would be an ordinal number? Can you think of another ordinal number?

As you work with these adjective commands, we find there are different names we use to describe the different kind of adjectives. If you want to know those names, just come and ask me.

End

Epilogue

The adjective command cards give the opportunity to introduce many of the classifications of adjectives - depending on which card and command is done.

There are adjectives referred to as **quantitative** - referring to number. Ordinal numbers are one kind of quantitative adjective. The words few, many, none and some - are examples of **indefinite adjectives**. The **definite adjectives, sometimes called the cardinal numbers**, are the numbers one, two, three, four and so on. There are **possessive adjectives**. "Pass around the red counters saying, this is my counter. Whose is that counter? Is it your counter? And this one? This one is his." There are **interrogative adjectives**. "Whose books are those?" The filler boxes have descriptive adjectives such as yellow color and black book.

There are also **qualitative adjectives**. There are no examples so we have to create them. These are adjectives that gives information about the subject of a sentence- though the adjective itself comes after the verb. "The flowers smell sweet."

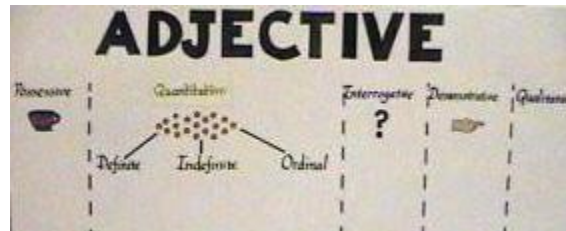
With each of the command cards, the adjectives are printed on brown cards. Sometimes these cards are used to carry out the command. Other times, with other command cards, the printed word cards will be set out in the order in which they are used in the command - to help the child remember the order of what you're to do. It focuses on that part of speech, to help organize the student's thoughts and what she has to do.

All command cards are color-coded and text-coded, for example, "adj.C4",

for adjective – command – 4. With this box and with many of the command cards, there are a few cards, that instead of a C, they have an E – because they are more experimental in nature (that is, scientific experiments) than they are commands. Encourage the children to save these for toward the end since they will likely need help with some of the terminology.

Once they have much experience with the command cards and they know the classifications of adjectives, there is an **adjective classification chart** (much like the noun classification chart) that can be introduced. Filler boxes only have descriptive adjectives so to use the chart, draw from the command cards for a greater variety of adjective types. Also, the children can make their own. The work charts are kept in the chart box.

Dr. Montessori had a special symbol for the *possessive adjective that looked like a light blue triangular shield*. It has rounded corners. It has the same shade of blue as the article but is a bit larger. These should be used instead of the adjective symbols if possible.



October 25, 2004

Comparison of Adjectives

Material

Red Rods, Pink Tower or Color Tablets. Filler boxes 3F and 3G are used, not with grammar box but for comparison of adjectives.

Prologue

Borrow red rods from a primary classroom for the oral introduction or you could use the pink tower. The children may have done this in primary.

It is a small (2-3) group presentation.

Begin

I would like you to bring me one of the red rods that is sort of a middle length among the group.

You have brought me a long rod. Can you please bring me one that's longer than this one?

Yes, this one is longer than the first. (compare them by holding them up)

Now, can you please bring me one that's even longer than this one? (child does so)

Yes, this one is even longer than the last one. (compare them by holding them up)

Now can you bring the longest rod (third child)?

Yes, you have brought the longest rod of all.

(repeat long, longer, longest scenario until the idea is clear for the child)

Now we're going to call this a short rod. **(same one which we began with)**

Can you please bring a rod that is shorter than this one?

Yes, you have brought a rod that is shorter than mine.

Can you (second child) bring another rod that is shorter than this one?

Yes, it is certainly shorter, another rod that is shorter.

Now, can you (third child) please bring me the shortest rod? (child does so)

Yes, thank you - you have brought the shortest rod.

(repeat short, shorter, shortest scenario until the idea is clear for the child)

End

Epilogue

If using the color tablets, you ask for darker and darkest, lighter and lightest. It's important to ask for the comparative. We can have many that are longer or shorter. We provide this impression. In contrast, there is only one that is superlative - the longest and shortest. This is also part of the impression we are providing.

There is no superlative if there are only two of something; you can only use the comparative. There must be at least three of something when we use the superlative.

Very often, the superlative is used incorrectly for the reasons above. If there are two, we cannot use the superlative.

October 25, 2004

Filler Box 3F

Material

Filler Box 3F. The root is on a red-brown card, suffix -er is on light brown, -est is on dark brown. Place the suffixes with the root -tall to form each of the forms. Cards for “more” and “most” are on pink cards.



The names are on white cards – positive, comparative and superlative – and **place them at the top of each column. At the very top, there is a white card that says “Comparison of Adjectives”**



Begin

We can have someone that's tall. “John is tall.”

(place “tall” in positive column)

We can also have someone that is taller. Barb is taller than John.

What's added to that word tall to make it taller? Yes, -er and what do

we call that? Yes, its a suffix.

(place “tall” and “er” as its suffix in the comparative column)

But we can also have someone who is tallest of all. What's added to that word to make tallest? That's right -est. And that's also a suffix.

(place “tall” and “est” as its suffix in the superlative column)



We say that tall is the positive form of the adjective, taller is the comparative form of the adjective and tallest is the superlative form of the adjective.

This is how we do the comparison of adjectives.

Introduce Use of More

We can have something that is smooth. What do we add to make the comparative smoother? We can also have something that is smoother than all others. How can we form the superlative.

(place cards in the columns as you speak)

We can have something interesting. But do we say 'interestinger'? No, **we say more interesting**. I happen to have that word more right here?

(Place “more”, on the pink card, into the comparative column before “interesting”)

How about this? Flor wrote the 'interestingest' of all. Can we say that? No, **we can say the most interesting**. So here the positive is interesting, the comparative is more interesting and the superlative is "most interesting".

(Place "most", on the pink card, into the superlative column before "interesting")



(repeat using beautiful, short,, etc.)

So we see that comparative and superlative are sometimes formed by adding a suffix but in other cases they are formed using the words more and most.

End

Epilogue

Pick up the separate piles of identical words. I have beautiful 3 times; each one will go into 3 separate piles. The adverbs all go into one pile (more), the -er go together into another stack and -est go into their own stack. The white cards are also banded together.

The children can continue with other examples. If the child has had adverbs, we can point out that more and most are adverbs.

October 25, 2004

Filler Box 3G

Material

Filler box 3G. Positive, comparative and superlative. The suffixes are printed on the same card as the adjectives. The root and suffixes are on the same card now. (Possibly show the “Noun Family” chart to show adjective use.)

Prologue

All of the grammar boxes are presented in the first year. Then all these follow-up exercises on different aspects such as the use of “more” with adjectives, follow.

Second set **3G brings in examples where the positive form changes - bad, worse, and worst - for example.** Adverbs are still printed on pink cards. Positives are in a first stack, comparatives in a second stack and superlatives in a third stack, as before.

Begin

(each of 3 children take a stack of cards)

1st turn- positive child places the first adjective - rough - into a column

Second child places the comparative into a column

third child places superlative that matches



2nd turn – positive child places second example -little
second child places comparative – less
third child places superlative – least



(repeat until cards are exhausted)

End

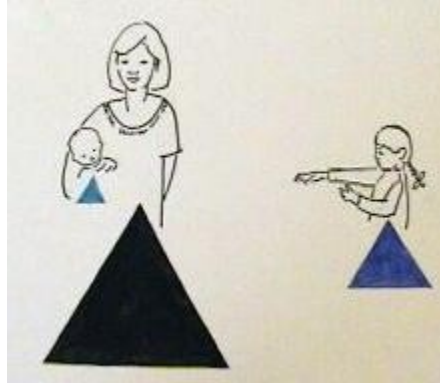
Epilogue

Children can also do this as a written activity on paper. They can make 3 columns on their paper and make their own lists.

They could also make a list of adjectives and nouns where they apply the positive, comparative and superlative – matching up adjectives with nouns appropriately.

They can also make a list of adjectives and then write after the adjective what they know about it. For example, rougher is a descriptive adjective in comparative form.

Chart “Noun Family” can also be introduced, showing that almost always the article and noun go together. There could be an adjective with them or there might not be one. (the adjective is put to the side a bit on the chart). (The exception is for proper names).



October 25, 2004

Verbs - Grammar Box IV

Prologue

The next central part of speech is the verb. We've talked about the significance of the noun - how people had to name their environment. We talked about how Dr. Montessori used the pyramid to symbolize nouns and how for the verb, she used a red ball - because it can roll around - symbolizing movement and activity. The pyramid is static unless we move it. But the verb, moves until something stops it.

The word verb comes from the Latin word verbum. It means "the word." In other words, it is the chief word in a sentence. Without it, there is no sentence.

What is important to realize is that in talking or writing, the verb is the voice of the speaker - always connected to the 'I'. In the sentence, "It is sunny and warm today" - it is 'I' who am saying it is sunny and warm. I am stating such and such. It is this connection between the speaker and what is being said that is important to understand.

We'll see with the verb there are many different aspects that the children need to learn about - just as we saw with the noun. The work with the verb goes on for a long time. We come back to it again and again, introducing different aspects along the way.

After introducing verb grammar box and probably verb command cards, you'd go on to the other grammar boxes - then in parallel to some of the other grammar boxes, you'd come back to introduce other aspects of verbs, such as tenses of verbs. This is not something new for them but rather we're making them aware of the

different tenses and how they are formed.

October 25, 2004

Oral Introduction and Grammar Box

Material

Grammar Box IV, grammar symbols (**red circle**). “Verb shines on the noun family” chart.

Prologue

As with earlier grammar boxes, start off with an oral introduction.

Begin

Remember we talked about this before – a pyramid. Maria Montessori used this pyramid to refer to a certain part of speech – nouns.

Today, we're going to talk about another part of speech.

(let the ball fall to the floor and bounce)

...one that Maria Montessori used a red ball to symbolize. Because the red ball rolls all over. It represents action, movement – it keeps going until it runs out of energy or something stops it.

That's the part of speech we'll work with today – the one that has to do with movement and activity.

Elisa, I have a new grammar box to show today. If you can carry this box to the table, I'll get the filler box. And we also need the grammar symbols. Can you also get that?

We've worked with other grammar boxes right?

Remember what we do with our cards. We use the filler cards to fill our grammar box. I always shuffle them to make sure they're really mixed up.

(First red card is drawn) **Can you read this sentence?** “Open the book” **Can you find the little word cards that make that sentence?** (Eliza goes through lower compartments to find cards) **Can you do what this says?** (Eliza takes and opens a book.)

Set it right there on the table. Can you read the second sentence.
“Shut the Book” **Is there a word in this sentence that is different?** (shut) Can you find that word? (finds word and places it below)

Can you do what it says.

Which word told you what object? Can you find the symbol for that word? *Which part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word noun?*

Which word told you one specific or one of many? Yes, can you find the symbol for that one? *Which part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word article?*

Which word told you what to do? Can you find the symbol for that word? *We call this part of speech a verb. Would you like to see that word verb?*

Shall we do another one?

(Order is:

First sentence: Reads it, forms it and does it. Read second sentence: Reads it, forms it, and does it. Then do questioning and place symbols. Each thing is returned between sentences)

Layout:

Open lid

Box itself

Sentence drawn from stack

Symbols

Sentence pieced together from lower compartments in the box.

Epilogue

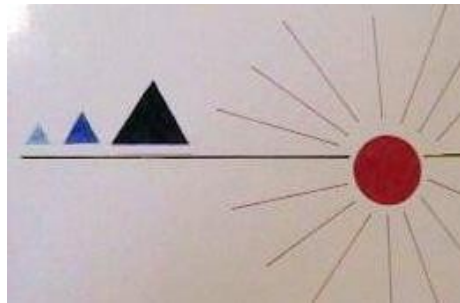
You can set the large red cards aside to show they are done. Everything else is put away before a second is done.

You can do several sentences before you introduce the new part of speech – adding the bold italic verbiage above. We are doing an informal 3-period lesson. **Check in with them once in a while to make sure that they are learning the names of the parts of**

speech.

We want the children to really begin to listen to our language. Does it sound right. Can you do what it says? It is the ear for language that needs to be developed. What we accept is what sounds right normally. This includes order and so on.

There is also a **chart to show “Verb shines on the Noun family”** The verb gives energy to the noun family – that's the interpretation where the red circle radiates onto the other symbols shown at left.



Two Permutations

At some point, two additional things must be taken care of. These are permutations.

The children might be working with this filler box using the sentence 'lock the door.' The first permutation is to take the verb away – simply pick it up and take it away and then ask the child to read what's left - “the book.” “Can you do that? Why Not”? I took away the action verb. There is nothing to do. This makes an impression of the first permutation.

Second is to change the order of the words, in particular, move the verb to the end. “The door lock”. “Can you do what it says? No. Does it make sense? Yes, it sort of does. But does it give you an action to do”? In fact, the parts of speech have changed.

October 25, 2004

Verb Command Cards and Synonyms

Material

Command cards, setup in two red boxes – open top. At end of the second box, they are coded experiments. These are left for last. Otherwise, the two boxes are the same.

Prologue

Some of them give the opportunity to introduce synonyms. Words that mean much the same thing but have slight differences in meaning. This differs from prior command cards.

With the command cards, we need to be prepared to demonstrate what the command cards mean, first, and then give the children a turn. They may not know how to carry out the verbs they will encounter.

Introduce this to a small group of children.

Begin

Let's start with this one. (Verbs are at the top in bold print on the command card and the verbs are isolated onto small red cards as well that are placed below the command card)

These cards are going to help you remember the order in which you will perform this command. (Set out small red cards in the order in which they are used in the command card. They are set to the right of the command card and then put away once the action begins.)

Command card says:

“Tear a large piece of paper into tiny bits. Blow steadily upon the table until the bits of paper are on the floor. Pick them up and put them back on the table. Puff three times upon them and see if they all fall on the floor. Gather the pieces up and throw them away.”

What words do you have? (help child perform actions if unsure how to proceed)

Introducing Synonyms

(Next example is same but uses verbs hurl and toss. Discuss, with the child, the two verbs and their slight difference in meaning after the command is carried out).

End

Epilogue

For synonyms, on another day, have the child look up the words in the dictionary to see the slight difference in meaning. To (throw) propel through the air with a swift movement of the arm versus to (hurl) throw forcefully. To (toss) throw or be thrown to and fro or to throw lightly. Tell the child, "When you write your stories, now you can choose exactly which word you want to use, to tell exactly what you want to say."

As the children are carrying these actions out, we have the beginning of dramatic arts. We can also see if the child is reading well. We have vocabulary enrichment here as well (some words we'll need to demonstrate their meaning)

Children should be able to work through all of the command cards and this is important. We discuss synonyms when this is appropriate.

Extension

At a later time, have the child do the command again and write his own definition for each of the verbs. Then have the child compare his definition to the dictionary definition. This provides a language composition exercise along with this.

October 26, 2004

The Other Grammar Boxes and Command Cards

Preposition - Grammar Box V

Material

Grammar Box V. Grammar symbols (**green crescent**).

Prologue

We established procedures with the adjective. Make sure the adjective is written up completely and illustrated completely. This is where we establish procedures. Going on the other grammar boxes include only what is different.

All grammar boxes are introduced in the first year of lower elementary. Parallel facets of what has been presented run in parallel to this.

Grammar box V is the preposition. Depending on how much experience the children have had with function of words, you may not need to do an oral introduction here. If it is needed, it involves giving commands to the children – such as stand by the window or crouch under the table – activities involving a preposition.

Begin

I have a new grammar box today. We also need the grammar symbols; let's get them.

Remember with our grammar boxes, the first thing we do is fill our grammar boxes.

(filler cards are placed in the grammar box)

(Large purple cards are placed at top of box)

Can you read the first sentence and find the little word cards for that sentence?

(example is “lay the pen with the pencil”)

(child constructs the sentence one word at a time. She rises to get a pen and pencil, etc.)

Alright, how about the second sentence.
(lay the pen behind the pencil)

Is there a word that's different? Can you find that word that's different?

Now can you do what it says? (child does all here)

Can you read the third sentence?
(lay the pen beside the pencil)

Which words told you the objects? (noun) Can you find the symbol for that?

Which words told you one specific or one of many? (article) Can you find the symbols?

Which words told you the action to do? (verb) Can you find the symbol?

Which word told you the relationship between the pen and pencil?
(Beside) Can you find the symbol for that?

**(repeat pattern above with new cards from the grammar box)
(The last time, we ask "Would you like to see the word for that"
(preposition))**

... Which word told you the relationship between cylinder and prism.
Can you find the symbol for that word?

This part of speech we call a preposition. Under is also a preposition. Would you like to see that word preposition? Now as you work, you can keep those names uncovered.

End

Epilogue

If children don't remember symbols, just show them.
Somewhere we need the symbols illustrated. This could be all in one place or under each write-up.

The preposition is giving a relationship. There is nothing wrong with giving the words that are used for this – besides and so on. The objects are the same in the sentences - except for the

preposition itself.

Permutations for Prepositions

The first is to take the preposition out of the sentence. Read what is left. "Place the prism the cylinder." Can you do what that says? Would you know what to do? No. This is a discovery.

Second is to put both prepositions at the same time. "Place the prism beneath upon the cylinder." Can we do this? Again, a discovery for the child. It is contradictory.

Third permutation is leaving the prepositional phrase together but move it around in the sentence. We are starting with "Place the prism upon the cylinder." At beginning, "Upon the cylinder place the prism." That works! Again, a discovery. "Place upon the cylinder the prism." Again, this works and more possibilities can be tried.

Last permutation is no longer keeping the prepositional phrase together, switching the order of the words - "Place the cylinder the prism upon." or "Upon place the cylinder the prism." Now we've lost sense of meaning. "Place the upon cylinder the prism." And so on.

At some point, have a discussion about prepositional phrases, what it is - "upon the cylinder." 'Cylinder' is the object of the preposition. It's the object that is governed by the preposition. The children should be familiar with what a prepositional phrase is.

Prepositional phrases can come any time after this grammar box is used. Encourage the child to use all of the cards in this filler box. Using all filler boxes is usually required only if they need it to crystalize the concepts presented.

There are also preposition command cards done like other command cards. For example, some of them call for cooperation like "go and stand in the middle of the room. Call two children and tell them to stand near you. Now one of them has to stand next to you on the right. The other stands to your left. Now tell the children to stand far away from you." This calls for group activity.

October 26, 2004

Adverb - Grammar Box VI

Material

Grammar box VI. Grammar symbols (**small orange circle**).
Filler box VIA.

Prologue

Generally there is no oral introduction to the adverb.

Begin

I have a new grammar box to show you today. I'll carry the filler box.
You know what to do with the filler cards right? (filler cards go into
grammar box, large cards are place at top compartment.)

Here is our first card "Rise silently from your seat."

(child forms the sentence with small cards, one per word and
performs the action).

Second sentence "Rise noisily from your seat." (child does so)

Is there a word there that is different? Can you find that word?
(noisily)

(repeat filler card phrases until idea of adverb usage is clear)

Which word told you the object? (seat) Can you find the symbol? What
part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word noun?

Which word told you what kind of seat? (your) Can you find the
symbol? What part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word
adjective?

Which word told you the action to do? (rise) Can you find the symbol?
What part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word verb?

Which word told you the relationship? (from) Can you find the symbol?
What part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word
preposition?

Which word told you how to rise? (noisily) Can you find the symbol?
We call this part of speech an adverb. Would you like to see that word
adverb? (remove slip) There it is.

End

Epilogue

Being consistent is what will enable the children to know
what to do.

Permutations for Adverbs

First is to take the adverb out of the sentence. "Walk to the
window." (versus walk slowly to the window) Can you do that? Yes, no
problem.

Place both in the sentence. "Walk slowly rapidly to the
window." Can this make sense. No, there is a contradiction. The child
discovers this.

"Walk rapidly to the window" can be changed to put adverb
to beginning of the sentence. "Rapidly walk to the window." Does this
work? Yes. "Slowly walk to the window." The child discovers this also
works.

Then take the adverb and place it at the end of the sentence.
"Walk to the window rapidly." This also works.

There are command cards here done in the same way as
others.

October 26, 2004

Pronoun - Grammar Box VII

Material

Green Grammar box VII. Grammar symbols (**purple triangle**), pronoun chart. Command cards as before.

Prologue

Here we definitely need an oral introduction. The children have not had pronouns yet at all. Sometimes, this requires more work than one might guess.

Grammar boxes almost always have 2-3 children present at the lesson. **Introduce the symbol early. Later, toward the end, introduce the name of this part of speech.**

Begin

Eric is lecturing this morning. Eric is doing language presentations. Eric is presenting grammar boxes. Why are you starting to chuckle Elisa?!

What is it I keep repeating that sounds funny? (Eric) We don't usually talk that way, do we?

If I said, Elisa, would Elisa come here please? Now what sounds funny?

We have little words that we use instead of repeating our names over and over again.

I am going to give you a presentation. Would *you* please come and sit here? These little words *I* and *you* replace our names when we speak normally.

(repeat until the idea is solid for the child. get them involved using their names for fun)

- - - -

I have a new grammar box for you today. I'll bring the filler box and

you take the grammar box.

(first thing is to put filler cards in the grammar box VII, large green cards at top)

Can you read the **first half** of this card? (there's more than one sentence normally here)

(**we no longer carry out an action** for this one. The child forms the sentences...)

"The children gave their mother a surprise. The children wrote a letter to their mother."

Can you read the second part of the card?

"The children gave their mother a surprise. **They** wrote **her** a letter."

Are there words that are different? Can you find those words and switch them?

(child finds new words and places replaced words to the upper right)

Which words tell you the objects, people or things involved? (points to children, mother and surprise) Can you find the symbols?

Which words here told you one specific or one of many? (The, a, a) Can you find the symbols"?

Which word describes mother? Can you find the symbol?

Which words told you the actions involved? Can you find the symbols?

Which words took the place of children and mother (they and her). This is the symbol we use for those words.

(introduce the new purple triangle)

Can you read the first half of this card? (new card)

“The book fell on the floor. Mary put the book back on the table”

Now let's read the second half of the card.

“The book fell on the floor. **She** put **it** back on the table”

Can you find the words that are different? (child points to she and it and replaces for the new words to change the sentence she has constructed)

Let's place the replaced words to the upper right of our workspace.

(Keep hands off the table for grammar box exercises! Give no help)

Which words told you the objects? Can you find the symbols? What part of speech is that? Would you like to see that word noun?

Which words told you one specific or one of many? Can you find the symbols? What part of speech do we call that? Would you like to see that word article?

Which words told you the actions? Can you find the symbols? What part of speech do we call that? Would you like to see that word verb?

Which words told you how to do the putting? (back) Can you find the symbols? What part of speech do we call that? (adverb) Would you like to see that word a adverb?

Which words told you the relationship between the book and floor and the book and table? (on) Can you find the symbols? What part of speech do we call that? (preposition) Would you like to see that word preposition?

Which words took the place of Mary and the book. (she took the place of Mary and it took the place of the book) Can you find the symbols for those words? (this had already been introduced with the first child). **We call this part of speech the pronoun.** Would you like to see that word pronoun? (uncover the column) There it is.

Now as you go on to work with the other cards, you can work with these names uncovered.

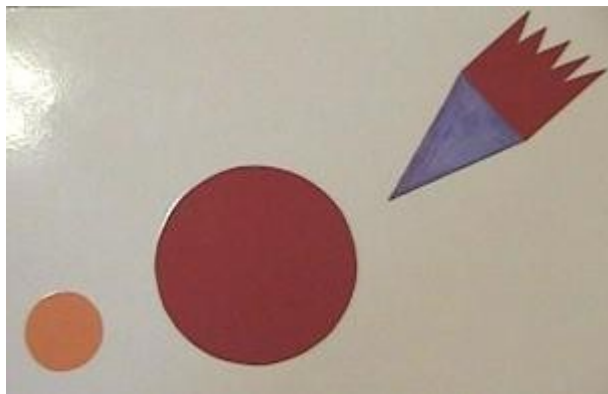
End

Epilogue

By this point, you would not be doing the questioning for every slip (part of speech). We do it here to practice doing it. **If you draw a part of speech during exams - do the questioning. Practice it.** But realize there are certain cards that are easier to do than other cards. You are always in control of which big card goes on top. As you practice, use this choice.

In the classroom with the children, always ask the question for the new part of speech. Otherwise you may say, "Can you symbolize all the words you know"? Then you'd introduce the new symbol.

At some point later on, after some experience, the children should see the chart that shows the pronoun attached to the verb, as a lead-in to pronouns and verbs. There is a special relationship between pronouns and verbs: we allude to forms agreement of the verb work here.



October 26, 2004

Conjunction - Grammar Box VIII

Material

Yellow grammar box VIII. Grammar symbols (adding a pink hyphen). Command cards as before.

Prologue

There is no oral introduction with the conjunction. Only new thing is the name conjunction – since the children have hopefully had the symbol in the primary level.

There is classification of conjunctions which can be introduced with the command cards. For more precise wording, see previous grammar box lessons.

Begin

Can you read the first line across? “Put away the pen. Put away the pencil.”

Can you find the word cards for these sentences?

Can you read the second line on this card? “Put away the pen and the pencil.”

Is there something different on this sentence? Can you make the changes necessary for your sentence to match?

Can you read the third line? “Put away the pen or the pencil.” Is there a word that is different there? Can you make that change to your sentence?

“Put away neither the pen nor the pencil.” Can you make the changes necessary again?

(never symbolize until the end of a card)

All right, which words tell you the objects or things here? Can you find the symbols for them? What part of speech are these? (nouns) Would you like to see that word noun?

Which words tell you one specific or one of many? (the) Etc.

Which word tells you the action here? (put) Etc.

Which word tells you how to do the putting? (away) Etc.

Which words join together the two sentences we had in the beginning and made it into one sentence? (and)

Can you find the symbol for that? **(pink hyphen)**

This part of speech we call conjunction. Would you like to see that word conjunction? Right there.

Neither-nor is a conjunction. And is a conjunction. Or is a conjunction.

End

Epilogue

One permutation might be to take the conjunction(s) out of the sentence and read what is left. "Put away the pen the pencil." Can you do what it says? Maybe, but it does not sound right does it? Ask the child what exactly it means. Let them discover it is not the normal manner of speaking. Command cards are used in the same manner as all other command cards.

There is a classification of conjunctions that can be introduced along with the command card work. Some are called coordinating conjunction - and - for example. In the command cards, you will also find a subordinating conjunction - if - for example. "You

will hear this if you are silent.” Here, if is a subordinate conjunction – not simply joining two part of equal value but it introduces a subordinate clause.

October 26, 2004

Interjection - Grammar Box IX

Material

Grammar box IX. Grammar symbols (gold exclamation point). There are no command cards for this.

Prologue

No oral introduction for this.

Begin

(fill grammar box as usual). There is something a little different. There's only one line on the card.

We start off reading these - but not just reading.

“Hey, where do you think you are going!?” (loudly, with enthusiasm and expression)

Can you find the little word cards for this sentence?

Which words give you the actions? (do, think, go) Can you find the symbols for them?

Which word here modified or described the going? (where) Can you find the symbol?

Which words take the place of names of nouns (you) Can you find the symbols?

Which word here gave us the feeling or beginning expression for our sentence? (Hey) This is the symbol we use for this part of speech. (gold exclamation point)

(repeat until idea is clear before introducing the new part of speech)

... What word gave us the feeling in our sentence? Can you find the

symbols?

We call this part of speech an **interjection**.

Would you like to see that word interjection? (remove slip cover)

There it is!

End

Epilogue

What is different is the way we read the sentence. The symbol and the word interjection must be introduced. **The new part of speech is always last. Otherwise, begin with noun or verb if possible** when we order our questioning through the parts of speech as they are reviewed. Usually, follow with adverbs if there is a verb. Otherwise there is no mandatory order.

October 26, 2004

Concluding Notes for Grammar Boxes

Start the grammar boxes early. They are a piece of material that the children can begin working with almost immediately in the first year of elementary class. Begin right away. The children should have had experience with function of words in the primary level, that should provide a foundation for this work.

The children should be through the grammar boxes by age eight. Even if you have children coming into the classroom who are not fluent readers, you can still introduce the grammar boxes to them.

The grammar boxes help reading to develop. Perhaps you can pair children who are better readers with one who is more tentative. Sometimes children will come to the teacher for virtually every word on the card for help. You need to tell them in this case, sight-readers will learn to read through those words. Sometimes, you need to help them with virtually every word but avoid if possible; don't leave them out in any case.

Getting the grammar boxes introduced early gives a foundation for the classification of the parts of speech. It gives a foundation for the other grammar work. We can't go on to tenses and forms of the verb until they've had the pronoun grammar box.

The grammar box work should be connected to their written composition work as well. From time to time, as the children are writing a story, poem, etc., have them write it out skipping a line in between each line of writing and then have them draw the grammar symbols above each word – that they can identify. This tells you what they know and what they don't know.

This is also beginning work on style.

The grammar boxes are group work. This is the psychological characteristic for this age. Working together with material like this is a way to get a group working without requiring an output at the end – such as a report. So often, teachers think of group work as a project where there must be a product deliverable. Most children are not ready for that but are always ready for sharing knowledge and skills in this kind of work.

Work with the grammar boxes needs to proceed in parallel to all of the other areas in language – such as word study,

logical analysis, literature, written composition, history of language. Because this material is so attractive and concrete, we tend to forget some of the other areas we must initiate and shepherd along.

Practice each and every grammar box. They are worthy of individual attention – even though they are very similar in general.

October 27, 2004

Verb Usage in Time and Circumstance

Personal Pronouns by Person, Singular & Plural

Material

Five charts: I-chart (first), You-chart (second) but you have to hide the group part of the picture lower corner, with the hand), He-chart (use second chart but uncover the “he” in the corner), She-chart (third), We-chart (fourth), You-chart (fifth), They (same as fifth, You plural, chart). Box of cards (labeled personal pronouns) with 5 white cards: singular, plural, first person, second person and third person. Seven red cards with the personal pronouns, I, you , he, she, we, you and they.

Prologue

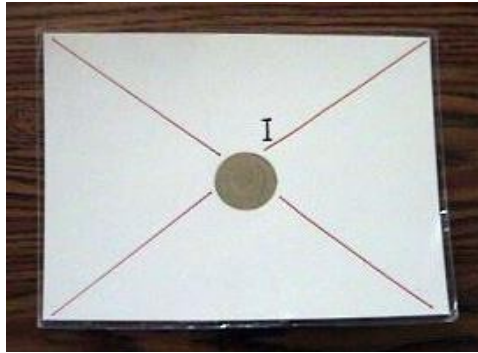
Personal pronouns have to be introduced before tenses can be done Take about 3 children with you for this presentation.

Begin

Flora, what are you doing? You are writing. Yes, you are writing. She is writing.

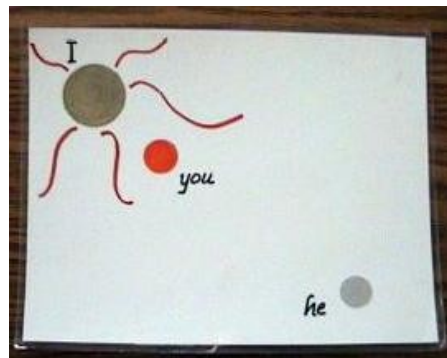
We have something called personal pronouns. I, you, he, she, we, they. These are personal pronouns.

(present first chart “I”)



We have some charts. I am the person speaking. I am speaking to you.

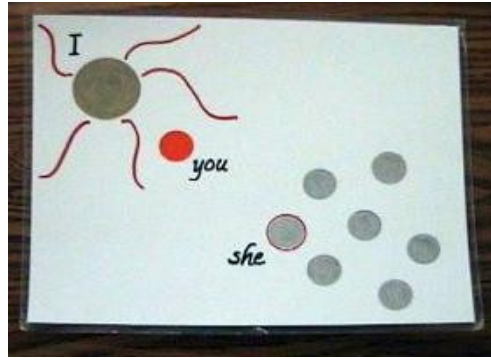
(present chart II “you” singular, covering “he” portion in lower right corner)



You is just one person. I can speak to just one of you. You are very busy. I can speak to one of you about just one person;

he is typing. **(emphasis on “he” - uncover the corner of second (you) chart)**

(present chart III “she”)

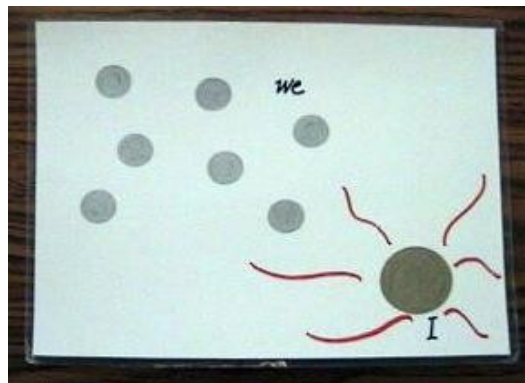


I can also speak to you about one person out of a whole group. She is wearing a yellow top today. She - one person out of a whole group.

Do you remember when we did nouns and we did singular and plural nouns. Well these are the singular personal pronouns.

I, is first person singular. You, is second person singular. He (point to "you" chart) and she (point to "she" chart) is third person singular.

(present chart IV "we")



But personal pronouns can also be plural (change chart). We, is a whole lot of us. We - a whole group of us. We are listening.

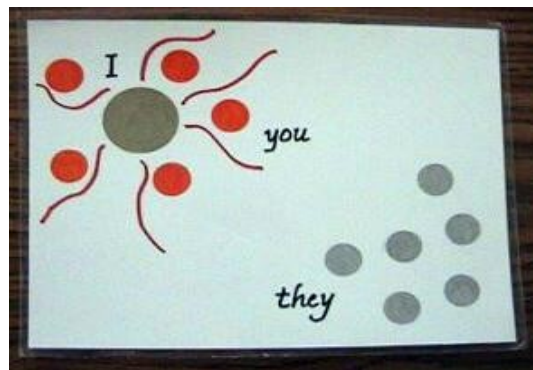
We is the first person plural. I can talk to the whole group of you. **(point to chart V).**

(present fourth chart “you” -plural)

You, is the second person plural. You look more rested today. I can talk to all of you (circle group on the chart) about a whole different group.

They - they will be lucky to have you as their classmates next year. 'You' is second person plural. And 'they' is the third person plural.

(present fourth chart “they” -plural (same as you plural))



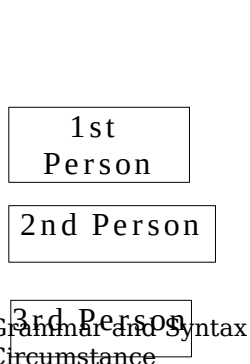
These are our personal pronouns.

Follow-up Activity

I have a little box labeled “personal pronouns.” So, if you 'd like to repeat these words, you can use these cards. I have one that says singular and one that says plural.

I'll put these white cards for singular and plural at the top of the table. I have three more white cards that say, first person, second person and third person.

This is how we set down our cards with personal pronouns.



I - I is first person singular. (set card for this)

You is the second person singular. (set card for this)

She is the third person singular. (set card for this)

He is also third person singular. (set card for this)

We is the first person plural (set card for this)

You (a group) is second person plural (set card for this) and

They, is the third person plural. (set card for this)

	Singular	Plural
1st Person	I	We
2nd Person	You	You
3rd Person	She He	They

(For some second period repetition...)

Now, I'll give this card to that table. I'll give this card to this group
(pass out each cards)

Who has second person plural? Okay, can you put it where it goes up here on the table?

(make sure when you hand out any plural card that you give it to a group to illustrate the plural sense.)

Who has third person singular - feminine form? Okay, can you put it where it goes up here on the table?

Who has second person singular? Okay, can you put it where it goes up here on the table?

(continue for all cases – singular by plural, first, second and third persons.)

End

Epilogue

This could also be done orally or in writing dictation. For example, “Please write third person singular masculine form.” Also, you could give “they” and they would write third person plural.

Having introduced personal pronouns, you can move on to tenses of the verb.

October 27, 2004

Introduction to the Tenses of the Verb

Prologue

This is one of the aspects you would come back to while moving in parallel with other things.

As we start to talk about tenses of the verb, it's important to give the idea that the action of the verb is a measure of time. So tense of the verb can be thought of as a grammatical measure.

We've talked about verbs as being action. We call them action words. But even back in primary class, hopefully, we were careful to give the children such as: think. Those are actions but can I see you doing it? No. We cannot see all actions. So we must include some of these as well as others that are more clearly an action.

If we have a sentence like "Robert drinks a glass of water", at a certain moment the action completes, though the glass remains. The action is over and done. There are certain actions that go on constantly. The earth turns on its axis; this does not stop, apparently. It goes on constantly.

Other actions are not constant. They are temporary. They last only while the action is in progress. You type your paper. At some point, it will be finished.

The first tense we start with is present tense - the time now. We could say - "I draw a line on my paper." Would it take long to finish this? No, not long. I can also have a sentence like, "Emily takes all the materials off of all of the shelves." Is she done quickly? No. It's still happens now, but it will take a long time. So it is a feeling for the time indicated by the verb that we try to convey to the children.

With each tense we will begin with listening. The oral introduction is a listening exercise. We'll develop a sense being indicated by the tense we're presenting.

Present tense is generally easiest to understand. The second tense we look at is past tense. This is something over and done. The children have informally been introduced to the past tense already in the primary classroom using questioning activities.

"Please go there", "What are you doing"? (going). "What did you just

do"? (went) Past tense is the second tense.

While present time is going on, we can also look to the future. This is time that has not come yet. We shall finish lectures by 3pm today. "You will get off early, this afternoon." This is time that has yet to come. This is the third part of our examination.

We will also examine auxiliary verbs – or helping verbs – at least by the upper elementary years. In the history of English, originally there was only past tense and present tense. It was in Middle English, that other tenses began to be added in to the language. This is why all additional tenses are constructed with the use of auxiliary verbs. It was in Middle English that the future tense was established with the use of shall and will. In Old English, the word that is translated as shall – meant – obliged to. The word for will translated as – will to. So, until recently, shall and will meant obligation and desire respectively, even though they were being used to indicate the future tense.

When we get to the perfect (or compound) tenses, we need to help the children make the distinction between the simple past and the present perfect. The simple past tense refers to time that is completely over and done with. You slept last night, for example. The sleeping is finished. The present perfect tense is used for time that is now in the past but in some way is connected to the present moment. I have spoken about verb tenses this morning, for example. This is in the past but it is also connected to the present moment – a feeling of incompleteness or an on-going meaning. Later today, we can say, I spoke about verb tenses this morning – this is the simple past. We need to help the child make these distinctions.

Each time, we'll give the children examples and have them listen. We'll do as much of this as needed until they catch on. There are materials for repetition but the most important aspect is the listening. The oral introduction should go on as long as it needs to, for the children to develop this feel for time in language and the tenses involved. It is the listening activity that enables them to distinguish between the tenses. This is our goal – not just conjugating verbs – but to develop this sense.

Before we introduce the future tense and the compound tense, we will introduce several auxiliary verbs – to have, and to be. We'll show the children how these two verbs are conjugated. And we'll help the children to realize that auxiliary verbs represent a development in the history of our language. Old English had a different kind of construction than modern English.

Today we might say, “He has broken his arm.” Old English would have had “broken” inflected to agree with arm. So it would have been, “He possessed a broken arm.” It would have been broken the adjective versus a present perfect – has broken. So, now participles are considered part of the verb – though they retain characteristics of an adjective.

October 27, 2004

Simple Tenses: Present

Material

Once the children are able to think of sentences like that, we have a red envelope labeled "Present Tense."

Layout on table:

	SINGULAR	PLURAL
FIRST	I love (place card)	we love (place card)
SECOND	you love (place card)	you love (place card)
THIRD	he /she loves (place card)	they love (place card)

Purpose

We are trying to help the child say exactly what they mean to say - to be impossible to be misunderstood in their speech and written communication. The material give the child to practice with each of the tenses - both simple and compound.

Prerequisites

Must have done personal pronouns.

Prologue

Use the oral introduction to begin.

Begin

We're going to think of sentences that refers to the time right now. For example, Eric writes his notes. Carson looks outside the window. The wind blows. All of these are present tense. Can you think of any?

Let's see what we have in this envelope. I have a white card that says, "present tense." I have two other white cards that say, "singular" and "plural." I have three more that say, "first person", "second person" and "third person." (these cards establish the layout)

In this envelope we have the verb – to love – in the present tense. So we also have the personal pronouns. Let's see how we would set out the verb to love.

Where is there a variation? Yes, in the third person singular – she loves.

	Present Tense	
	Singular	Plural
1st Person	I Love	We Love
2nd Person	You Love	You Love
3rd Person	He/She Loves	They Love

Let's think of another verb – how about jump. First person singular would be I jump, second person singular would be you jump, third plural would be she (or he) jumps – there's that variation again. I wonder how many verbs have that variation for third person singular? (continue plural forms)

What verbs can you think of that has that variation?

End

Epilogue

First time you are guiding. Get the children doing the present tense on their own with their own verbs.

October 27, 2004

Simple Tenses: Past

Prologue

In the English language, the past tense is formed in two different ways. So here we get into a classification on how the past is formed. We have two kinds of verbs – weak and strong – otherwise called regular and irregular verbs. For the older children, we can go into some of the history surrounding regular and irregular verbs.

Remember we talked about English developing from Proto-Indo-European language. Back then, all of the verbs belonged to the group that we now call strong verbs. If I say to you “I sing” this is present tense. But I wanted the past tense, I would say “I sang.” The vowel changes and this is how the past tense was formed in Proto-Indo-European. The vowel in the stem of the verb changed to form the past tense. These verbs go back to Proto-Indo-European.

As we trace down to Proto-Germanic, there are still many strong (irregular) verbs and they form the past tense by changing the vowel in the stem; but in Proto-Germanic, there were also other verbs invented. These formed the past tense by adding a suffix – ed. I walk (present), I walked (past tense) – we add that suffix -ed. These verbs are called weak verbs or regular verbs.

So from Proto-Germanic onward, we have two kinds of verbs. As we come down to modern English, which of these two kinds is in the majority? It is the regular or weak form. In fact, there are only about 100 irregular (strong) verbs left in modern English. This is an opportunity for the children: find the 100 irregular verbs.

As our language has evolved, some verbs that used to be irregular verbs have been changed into regular (weak) verbs. For example, the verb to help has a present tense of “I help.” Its past tense used to be formed as, “I healp.” Now we expressed the past tense as, “I helped.” This is an example of a verb that used to be irregular and is now regular.

When new verbs are added to our language, are they added as weak or as strong (irregular). They are added as regular – computerized, televised. We tend to add new verbs as regular or weak verbs. This is another reason regular verbs are in the majority now.

To give the children an activity with the past tense, we have material. In our environment, the material is in 3 envelopes labeled “weak verbs”, “strong verbs”, and “extra verbs.” In both weak and strong envelopes, there are two charts: a chart for present tense and a chart for past tense. They each have a slit that allows verbs on strips – to slide into the slits.

In the regular envelope, we also have some regular verbs. The same is said for the irregular envelope. In the “extra” envelopes, we have some of each.

There are two different ways these can be presented, depending on the age of the children. Present weak and strong verbs already sorted. Or, present for older children both mixed up and let them categorize them in the exercises.

After experience with the present tense, on another day we go into simple past tense. Use the oral introduction to begin.

Begin

I drank a cup of coffee. I'm not doing it now am I? It's over and done now. You wrote your paper. Now it's over and done. It was in the past. Last night, I read the newspaper. Is that going on now? No. It's over with.

Can you think of a sentence like this? A sentence that happened in the past?

(take examples from the children until they readily come up with examples, responding...)

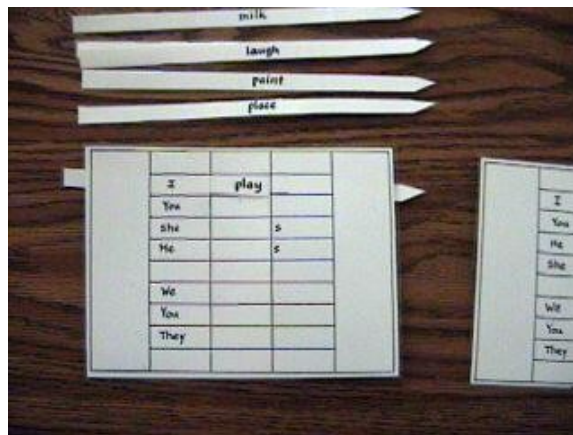
Yes, that is completely in the past. It's not going on now, is it?

- - - -

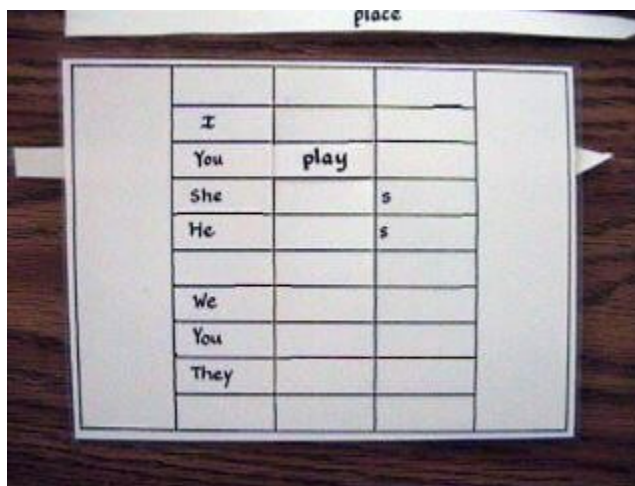
Today, we're going to look at some verbs with the little charts we have in these envelopes. Let's start with regular verbs.

This is the chart we use for present tense (labeled on the back). And let's pick a verb. We'll choose “play” (written on a little strip – it slides

in through those slits and lines up into a grid). Now, we'll read what it says.

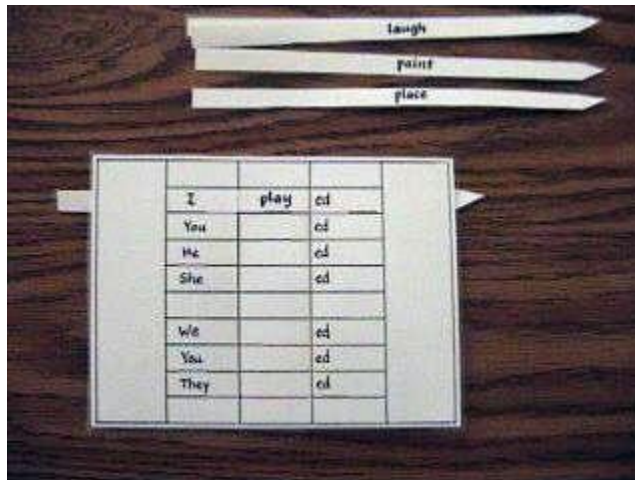


I play, you play, she plays, he plays, we play, you play, they play. (slip moves down the slit as we say each form)



So that is “to play” in the present tense.

Now let's try the past tense for “to play” (slide in slip into slit)



I played, you played, he played, she played, we played, you played, they played.

Does this sound like the past tense of the verb? Yeah.

This is called a weak verb. That's the kind of verb it is – a weak verb. You can try some of the others if you'd like.

We also have this envelope marked “strong verb”. I have my two charts for present tense and past tense, and I have my strips here.

Let's take the verb - “to drive.” Let's slide it into the present tense chart and see what it says”

I drive, you drive, he drives, she drives, we drive, you drive, they drive.

I			
You			
She		s	
He		s	
We			
You			
They	drive		

Does that sound like present tense? Yeah, that's how we form the present tense of "to drive"

Now let's see how we form the past tense for "to drive" (turn the slip over)

I	drove		
You			
He			
She			
We			
You			
They			

(I drive – oops, is that past tense? No, I forgot to turn over my slip! - optional)

I drove, you drove, he drove, she drove, we drove, you drove, they drove. Is this sounding like past tense?

Maybe you'd like to try some other strong verbs to make your own tenses.

You can also use the “extra” verbs to sort them between strong and weak verbs.

End

Epilogue

Keep early examples clear cut to establish the patterns.

A way to present this for older children is to let them sort between strong and weak verbs using the chart – trying combining charts and slips. Try a weak verb with a strong verb chart or vice versa. The children will see what does and does not work.

They then continue to work classifying weak and strong verbs. Perhaps mix up all the verbs and let them classify them.

They can use these activities with writing: writing the present tense first and then the past tense. They could use colored pencils or inks to show the ending or stem changes. You could dictate to them verbs or children can dictate to each other; this is an important variation since it aids spelling. You could give the past tense and ask the child to write the present tense – or vice versa.



October 27, 2004

Auxiliary Verbs

Prerequisites

This is before future and compound tenses since we need auxiliary verbs.

Prologue

We have a verb packet for the verb “to have” and one for “to be.” We begin with “to have”. The packet says “Verb – to have – infinitive. Inside the packet, there is another jacket that says “indicative mood.” We will talk about this another day. Again, inside, there is another packet that says “active voice”. This is for another day.

But on the very inmost level of packets, we have 6 little packets; we choose one that says “present tense” and the one that says “past tense.”

Begin

We've talked about present tense haven't we. I have a packet here that says present tense. Let's see what's in here:

(lay out the cards in the familiar 3 rows x 2 columns:

I have, you have, he has, she has, we have, you have, they have. This is how we form the present tense of the verb “to have.”

Let's look at this envelope labeled “past tense”

I had, you had, he had, she had, we had, you had, they had. This is the past tense of the verb “to have.”

Table layout:

Packet Present (red)

I have we have
you have you have
he has they have
she has

Packet Past (red)

I had we had
you had you had
he had they had
she had

(do the same exercise with the verb “to be”)

(open successive packets, infinite, indicative, active - and take out the present and past packets among the six - for “to be.”)

Let's set out the present tense of the verb “to be” (do so - saying each one)

Let's look at the past tense (do so - saying each one)

Packet Present (red)

I am we are
you are you are
he is they are
she is

Packet Past (red)

I was we were
you were you were
he was they were
she was

Now we can mix up these cards and mix them up - then sorting them to form the present tense and past tense again.

To have and to be are verbs that are sometimes used as **helping verbs** - they help other verbs and are used with them.

I wonder if there are other verbs that are used as auxiliary verb? We'll have to be on the lookout for more.

End

Epilogue

These are all words the children have been using. They aren't new words but we are helping them realize what tenses are and to bring awareness of that to their use of those words.

October 27, 2004

Simple Tenses: Future

Begin

Let's see if we can think of sentences like this. This afternoon, I shall go to the grocery store. Is that happening now? No, it hasn't happened yet, has it.

Let's see - "tonight, you will watch a movie." Is that happening now? No, it is some time in the future that it will happen.

This weekend you will take a break from homework. Is it happening now? No, it's not in the past nor now in the present. We're speaking of something that will happen later.

Can you think of a sentence like that? (take several examples)

"We will eat lots of Halloween candy after we trick-or-treat."

"I will again go to school tomorrow."

-- - Once children can readily come up with examples - - -

The verb "to eat", if we use it in the present tense, what do we say? Yes, we eat. How many words will we use for the verb? Yes, just one.

In the past tense, how many words will we use for the verb? We ate. Just one again but it's a different form for the verb stem. So we'll say this verb is a strong verb. But we said "we will eat candy."

"will" in that case is another one of those auxiliary verbs - it's a helping verb. We use it along with "to eat" to show it will happen later.

-- Use packets --

(sort down into packets – infinitive, indicative, active voice – take the present, past and future packet among the 6 present)

(choose three children)

Vicky, can you lay out the present tense of “to love.”

Femina, can you lay out the past tense of “to love”

Priyanka, can you lay out the future tense of “to love”

(use will or shall as a helping verb for future)

End

Epilogue

Find English Verb Conjugations. This provides standard conjugation. Vincent F. Hopper is the author; get this book for the classroom.

New tense are always added to the right on table layouts. Old tenses are presented on the left. Note the use of shall and will per form below; this can be soft-peddled but is considered standard by some authorities.

Present			Past		Future	
Singular	Plural	Singular	Plural	Singular	Plural	
1 st I love	we love	1 st I loved	we loved	1 st I shall love	we shall love	
2 nd you love	you love		2 nd you loved	you loved	2 nd you will love	
you will love						
3 rd (s)he loves	they love		3 rd (s)he loved	they loved	3 rd (s)he will love	
they will love						

October 28, 2004

Compound Tenses: Present

Material

Language packets. Lowest level packet is present perfect.

Prologue

Here we will do compound tenses. After introducing the simple future tense, we want to go back to the two packets of auxiliary verbs – to have and to be – set out the present tense, past tense and simple future tenses. They would have worked with the future tense using the auxiliary verbs.

Recall we said that originally English had only 2 tenses. Others have been introduced using auxiliary verbs – or helping verbs. We'll see today, with compound tenses, that they are formed with the present, past and future tense of the auxiliary verb plus the past participle of the main verb.

English now has 6 main tenses: the 3 simple tenses, present perfect, past perfect and future perfect. We want to help the children sense the difference between the simple past and the present perfect – which is also a past-related tense.

We begin with an oral introduction.

Begin

We begin by thinking of sentences using the present perfect tense:

I have driven to the institute four times this week. Carol has walked here four times.

I have lectured to you for 3 days already.

Can you think of sentences like this – in what we call the present perfect tense?

He has walked to school everyday this year. I have fed my dogs every day this week.

(let children make and analyze some examples)

(once the children are coming up with sentences with you, go to verb packet)

(go through packets infinitive, indicative and active voice, and inside we have...)

Shilena, you set up the present tense in a column to the far left.
(columns sing. & plural)

Eliza, you get the past tense - set it out to the right of Shilena's

Carol, you get the future tense - set it out to the right of Eliza's

Debbie, you get the present perfect tense - set it out to the right of Carol's

Layout of Four Grids:

I love-we love; have loved	I loved-we loved;	I shall love-we shall love;	I have loved-we
you love-you love; you have loved	you loved-you loved;	you will love-you will love;	you have loved-
he loves-they love; they have loved	he loved-they loved;	he will love-they will love;	he has loved-
she loves;	she loved;	she will love;	she has loved

Now, what if we collected and combined all these cards?

(mix them up, classify them again by tense and then put them away)

End

Epilogue

Present perfect is on one day. Mix them up sort them out and then put them away. On another day, we begin with the next tense. Follow-up work can include dictation. Pick another verb besides love. Dictate by verb, person (plus gender), tense. Dictate orally or in writing.

October 28, 2004

Compound Tenses: Past

Prologue

Auxiliary verb forms must be very solid before going on into past perfect.

Begin

Remember the other day, we learned about present perfect tense? Today we'll learn about the past perfect tense.

I had driven home before I remembered I was supposed to go to the bank.

Carol had walked to the store before the bus came.

Can you think of a sentence that uses this tense? (accept some examples)

How many words are we using each time for the verb? (two)

What kind of words are they? (first word is the auxiliary in the past tense)

Yes, and we use the past tense of the auxiliary verb along with the past participle.

(return to the verb packet, set aside infinitive, indicative, open up active voice)

(open the first four tenses the children have done and array as in last exercise)

Who would like to add the past perfect tense to the right of present perfect?

(child comes up and constructs the verb grid - using love as usual)

What if we collected and combined all these cards? (mix them up, classify them again by tense and then put them away)

Epilogue

Past perfect tense is used to refer to any event that was terminated or completed, prior to some definite time in the past.

October 28, 2004

Compound Tenses: Future

Begin

We have another tense to learn about today – the future perfect.

I shall have driven to the institute five times this week if I drive tomorrow.

You will have made 9 albums by March if you get all your work done.

I shall have worked very hard by March.

(return to the verb packet, set aside infinitive, indicative, open up active voice)

(open the first five tenses the children have done and array as in last exercise)

Who would like to add the future perfect tense to the right of past perfect?

(child comes up and constructs the verb grid – using love as usual)

What if we collected and combined all these cards?

(mix them up, classify them again by tense and then put them away)

End

Epilogue

Future perfect is used to indicate something will be completed before some definite time in the future. Do dictation as described in previous tense work.

There is coding on the back of the packet cards. Present is coded as 1S for first simple, past is 2S, future is 3S, 1C is first compound tense, 2C is past perfect and 3C is future perfect. When we make verb packets, code the cards according to this system.

Our goal with the children is to help them hear tenses. In the classroom have 3 or 4 verb packets like this: to walk, to speak and so on.

Upper elementary children may get into conditional tenses. Another activity for them is to write a story in present tense and then to rewrite it in past tense - for example.

October 28, 2004

Infinitives and Moods

Material

On the outside of each of the language packets, we have this word infinitive.

Prologue

The children are toward the end of the lower elementary level by the time we present this. Subjunctive is normally left for upper elementary children.

There is added coding on the cards: I1s is indicative first person simple. I precedes the coding for all indicative. Use II to precede subjunctive forms.

One way of making things more interesting is to separate the subject and verb forms. Children can then mix and match them.

Begin

The infinitive is a form of the verb. It is not distinguished by person or tense like the others however. It give us the general name of the verb: to walk, to think, to see. Almost always the infinitive uses that word "to" prior to the action of the verb. When infinitives are used in a sentence, they usually function as a noun.

Moods – the second packet in says, "indicative mood" - is the changes in the mood of the form; it shows the various ways in which the action or state is thought of by the speaker. **There are 3 different moods: indicative, imperative and subjunctive.**

Indicative mood makes a statement that indicates or asks a question. All tenses presented so far have been in the indicative mood.

The **imperative mood** is an expression of will or a command. Sometimes it is advice. It can even be a request or a warning. Simple imperative is like: stop, run, think, wake up. "Leave the room" is in the simple imperative mood. Children often enjoy imperative. With verb tenses, the form of the verb does not change. With the logical (sentence) analysis work, we'll see sentences in the

imperative where often times the subject is missing; you is often implied.

The **subjunctive mood** describes a contingency or the expression of desire. “If I were free now I would take a nap.” “If I were” describes a contingency. The gist of using subjunctive is that the speaker does not fully control what will occur; he may state a preference or possibility, but cannot control them.

End

October 28, 2004

Negative Form of the Verb

Prologue

This is generally easy to present to the children. They easily understand negation of a verb.

Begin

She did not stop at the bank. (pause)

I do not love him. (helping verb is “to do” and not is an adverb technically)

(make more examples)

Can you think of a sentence like this?

(accept children's examples)

Now we have a packet to explore (packet “infinitive – indicative mood negative form”)

(build columns as in previous lessons.)

**Negative
Form**

I do not love	We do not love
You do not love	You do not love
He/She does not love	They do not love

(mix and match as previous lessons)

End

Epilogue

For negative, there are two packets. The second is for the verb “to love” indicative mood, negative form - with each word on a separate card. We can make additional ones like this for added practice. Code it NI1S for example (indicative, first person, simple, negative). NII would be for negative subjunctive.

December 6, 2004

Logical Analysis

Introduction

The grammar work we have already done has had to do mainly with parts of speech - single words and their functions. All of that work built up the foundation established with Function of Words.

The grammar boxes in the elementary class give the children a way of classifying and organizing the impressions that they received in the primary class. We help them organize these impressions more consciously than they are able to do in the first plane of development. This is why the grammar boxes are constructed as they are - with all of the separate compartments to help clarify the different functions for the children.

Another aspect to grammar work we need to consider, regardless of parts of speech or analysis work, is that we are predominantly doing this work to help the children **think clearly, write clearly and express themselves clearly**. So all of this work is not pure grammar but is done for a larger purpose. It helps as we do this work in the classroom, if rather than thinking of it as teaching grammar or syntax, we keep in mind that it is connected to thought. And we want to help make those thoughts clear.

The aspect of language we'll look at now is called logical analysis. Analysis is a Greek work that means "resolving into parts." In grammar, it means the breaking up of a sentence into its component parts. The difference between this work and the grammar box and parts of speech work is that now, at least sometimes, we're going to have groups of words together, phrases that stay together and that have a function as a group of words. In parts of speech, we usually deal with single words.

The logical analysis work is an aid to what is called syntax - the arrangement of words together. Syntax shows the relationship in which certain groups of words stand to other groups of words. **This logical arrangement is necessary in English. English is not an inflective language**; meaning English does not have small endings added onto words to indicate that a given word is the subject, for example. Latin and Japanese is inflective. But in English, it is the order of the words that determine subject, verb, direct object and so

forth. The order and correct syntax gives meaning in English. In an inflective language, word order only provides style; functionality is not effected by order.

The order in which words are placed in a sentence also matters in terms of the style of English. It determines whether we find writing attractive or unattractive, appealing or not, whether it is clear or not, logical or not. Sometimes you can read a sentence and see it makes sense but the meaning is still not totally clear; it could mean this or it could mean that.

This is why Dr. Montessori talked about logical analysis at the second plane of development. In English, it's the arrangement of words, one group to another, that makes logical meaning. You could have a sentence, for example, like: "The mother baked a cake and the little girl ate it." We have a series of actions and the second one is dependent on the first one. If we turned the two parts around (the little girl ate it and the mother baked a cake) we lose our meaning.

With logical analysis work, we're going to build on the reading analysis work that was part of the primary class. It's important we keep these two ideas separate; in primary there is reading analysis, analysis of words relating to one-another in order to help the child read. Both the function of word work and the sentence analysis work is done for reading. This is why it's so vital the child complete this work in the primary class. It lays the foundation for presentations in the elementary class. But **in the elementary classroom, we are focusing on the thinking part of writing skills, meaning and communication.**

In thinking about the grammar box work, the first couple grammar boxes begin with phrases – not sentences. A phrase is a group of words connected together which makes sense but it is not a complete idea or make complete sense. It's only when we get to the verb grammar box IV that we begin working with sentences.

The primary analysis work, where we always start off by asking for the action of the sentence, is an important foundation for what we'll do in elementary. With logical analysis **in the elementary class, we also show the children the place of the action word** in the context of the totality of the sentence – and the relationship that all other words have to that action word. That is the significance of the second chart used in primary, where the action is in the middle and other word functions are arrayed around it. If the children have completed primary language work, they should have no trouble picking up with elementary class work – finding the action to begin.

We begin with simple sentences. Simple sentences are those that have 1 finite verb. Any part of the verb can be used as the predicate. So, there is always a subject and a tense involved. The children have already been using these kind of sentences in the verb grammar box. They should have already made a study of agreement between person and the special parts of the verb used to form the tense, root and endings. We would not start this work until the child has done at least the verb grammar box. If tenses of the verb is not done already, it should be done in parallel to this work since it ties things together for the student.

In the primary class, in what Dr. Montessori called total reading, the children have used movable arrows and disks and charts, which have questions on them and help the child know which part of the sentence goes where. The children first find the action word, but we don't name that part of the sentence to begin; it's just the action word(s).

We will begin to introduce the names of the parts of the sentence in the elementary class. We'll start with the first division in the sentence - the action. Then we'll find who did the action. Then we find on whom or what the action was done. That is to say, we look for predicate, subject and the direct object. Then we'll add in other parts of the language, gradually giving more and more information. There are some additions to some of the verbs and nouns we use in the sentence. So we'll do the same kind of dividing up of sentences as in primary, but we'll look at those adjuncts to the verb to help the children realize that they have the function of adverbs. We're going to look at the adjuncts to the noun and help the children realize they have the function either of an adjective or of another noun. Another thing we'll help the children realize is that in a sentence, the subject and predicate are essential. A sentence might have other parts but it does not necessarily have to.

Some of the sentences we do with the children should be taken from good literature. One might take sentences from a book you read to them or from one of their books. One can also encourage the children to take sentences from books and examine them. **It has been found very effective in the classroom to write sentences about the children.** This gets them involved and encourages them to write sentences like that. What we don't want to do is to make lists of sentences for different presentations and tell them that they can use those sentences; if it is a command card sort of activity, it loses its fun. Teachers often worry about how the child can write sentences when the child only knows a limited number of parts. If a

child writes a long involved sentence with pieces they don't know fully about, we can address (comment, analyze) what they know and set aside the parts they don't know for a future lesson.

December 6,2004

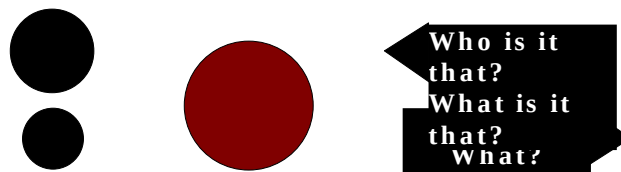
Simple Sentences

Purpose

All of this analysis is for the child to begin to think and express himself logically. A simple sentence has one independent proposition - therefore one finite verb.

Material

First wooden box of analysis material used in the primary level; there are **no names on the arrows - only questions**. A tray with a roll of narrow adding machine paper (about 2 inch), scissors and a lead pencil. Initial layout:



Prologue

In elementary classrooms, we use rolls of paper, not strips - since we are then not limited by the length of what we write. Do a number of examples with sentence parts face down on the analysis materials; then introduce the names for those sentence parts and then let them continue to work with the names face-up. Begin with arrow questions face-up. **Be sure child comes to understand action, predicate, subject and direct object.**

Begin

Carrie, we'll have a new lessons today. (open the box). We're going to start with some of these pieces (2 black circles, 1 red circle and 2 arrows).

We're going to set them like this each time we begin. Can you give me a sentence?

"Carrie drives a car." (write the sentence on a strip of paper)

What is the first thing we look for? Yes, we **find the action first.**
What is the action? Drives - yes.

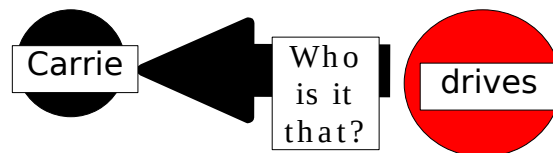
First,
we find
the
action.

(cut out action from the strip of paper, place the **action on the red ball**)

Who is it that drives? Carrie

(cut out subject from the strip of paper, place it on the subject circle)

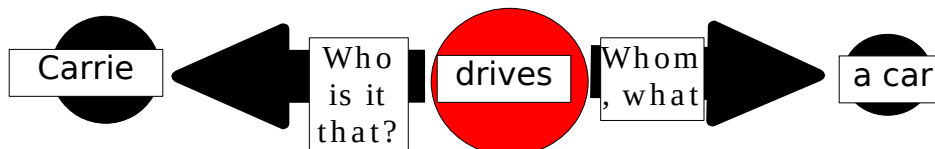
Secondly
, Who is
it or
what is it
that
acts?



Use the statement we have built up so far "Carrie drives" and then use the questions on the arrows "What of whom"

Now we ask - Carrie drives whom or **Carrie drives what.** A car, right?

(cut out direct object from the strip of paper, place it on the direct object circle)



Expose Arrows

(repeat several more examples with arrows and red ball face down)
(after repetition with arrows down, proceed ...)

There's a name for this **part of the sentence we call the action.**
It's called the predicate. Would you like to see that word? There it

is – predicate (turn over the red circle)

There's a name for this part also. It's called the **subject**. Would you like to see that word? There it is – subject (**turn over the subject arrow**)

There's a name for this part. It's called the **direct object**. Would you like to see that word? There it is – direct object (**turn over the direct object arrow**)

Epilogue

Give as much or as little help as is needed. Sometimes you write the sentence and they do the whole thing.

December 6,2004

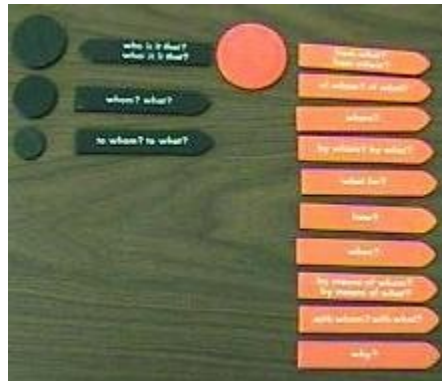
Simple Sentences with Extensions

Material

First box at the elementary level – includes orange arrows and indirect object arrow. Delay introduction until they are required by the analysis example.

Prologue

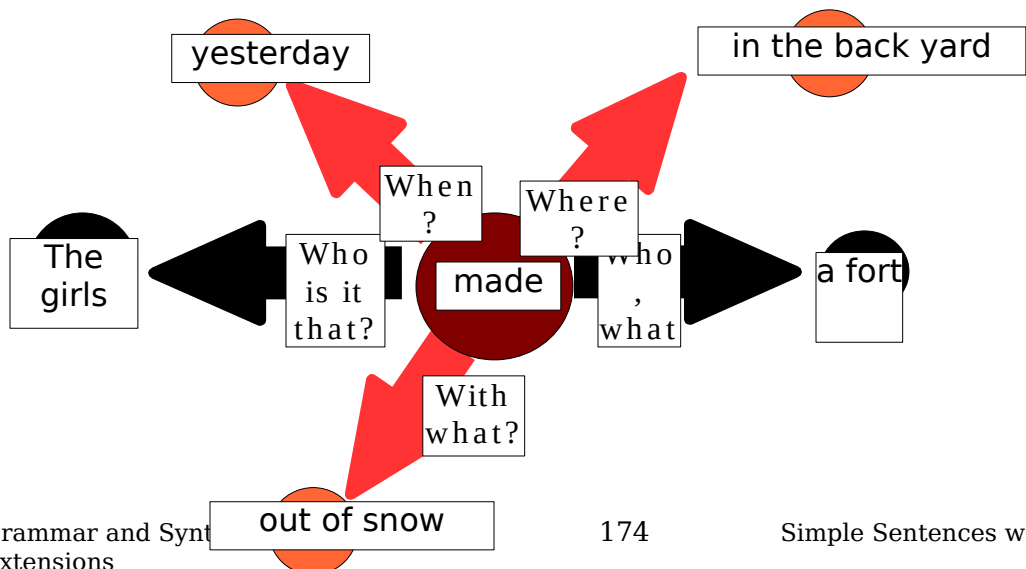
As we go on, we add more elements to the sentences. Here, we add orange arrows and circles.



Initial setup.

Begin

Here's a new sentence: **"The girls made a fort yesterday out of**



snow in the yard."

What is the action? Made. (place "made" on red circle)
Who is it that made? The girls. (place "The girls" on subject circle)
The girls made what? A fort. (place "a fort" on direct object circle)

But there's more to our sentence. So today, we're going to bring out new materials.

(set up **orange arrows and circles**)

The girls made a fort - with what, with whom?

Here we have a fit: out of snow

Arrow questions: Where? Again we have a fit - In the yard.

By means of whom, by means of what? That doesn't fit.

The girls made a fort how? Doesn't fit.

The girls made a fort when? Yesterday.

Our sentence used 3 of these orange arrows. Do you think they say

anything on the other side of the arrows?

Expose Arrows

Our **orange arrow** saying “with who, with what” says:
“accompaniment”

How about **when** - it says **“time.”**

How about the arrow with **“where”** - it says **place on the other side.**

All of these orange parts are called **adverbial extensions**, of place, and adverbial extension of time – for example.

Let's do another example. Begin by setting out the material in our setup.

How about this sentence:

“The children rolled together a lot of snow for a snowman on Tuesday.”

What's the action? Rolled.

The children rolled what? A lot of snow. (follow top arrow to ask - what)

To whom or what – does not make sense.

The children rolled a lot of snow, why? Does not fit.

The children rolled a lot of snow, for what? For a snowman.

The children rolled a lot of snow for a snowman, when? On Tuesday.

(continue – others don't work)

The children rolled a lot of snow for a snowman, how? Together.

What parts of the sentences do we have here?

(predicate, subject and adverbial extensions - we want them to turn arrows up over time - how much they give and how much you help them depends on their point of development)

(after much practice with extensions)

Indirect Object

Present indirect object only after quite some time building sentences without an indirect object.

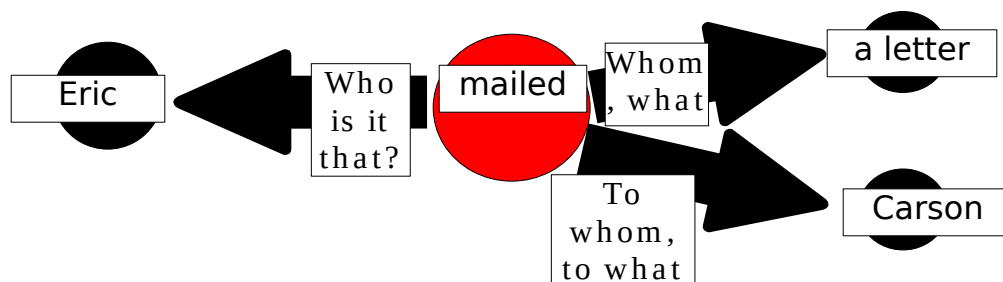
Note that there is never an indirect object without a direct object. Generally, American grammarians say in a sentence like, "The children gave a birthday surprise to their father", that 'father' is not an indirect object here - it's a prepositional phrase 'to their father.' Most English books say it's a prepositional phrase if there is the word 'to.' As a teacher, we should never write a sentence like this; the limitation in our material is that there is nothing else to do with it except call it an indirect object. Put the indirect object before the direct object to avoid encountering this issue.

At the upper elementary ages, we can admit the complexity and follow grammar books.

Begin

How about the sentence, "Eric mailed Carson a letter"?

(use same questions: what is the action, who is it that ___, Whom or what is it that is ___?)



(when 'Carson' is encountered, bring out the indirect object arrow from the box)

I have another arrow here that might work for that. It has a new question, "to what, to whom."

There's a name for this part. It's called an **indirect object**. Would you like to see that word? There it is – direct object (**turn over the indirect object arrow**)

Epilogue

We first asked for our action (red ball), the subject (top arrow, left side of predicate circle pointing left) and the direct object (second arrow, under the subject arrow, same left side but pointing right). Then we selected the third black arrow (also pointing right) and lastly all of the orange arrows. If a black arrow doesn't fit, put it back and then proceed with the orange arrows. Each time, *reread the sentence formed up to now and then add the arrow prompt at the end – in order prompt the child to find the correct analysis*. Make sure the 3 orange arrows at the top are not the ones used in the sentence; we want to go through the whole list and put those we don't use back into the box. Once the sentence has been diagrammed, ask what parts of the sentence are in the sentence.

You don't have to give the term adverbial extension on the first lessons. But bring it in while they are working at some point soon after. What is most important is to **get the child debating about the parts of speech** – based on their thinking through the parts, function and words in their understanding.

Make sure to give a variety of sentences, from literature, poems, the children themselves and so on. Be sure to include examples that don't have a direct object – the region straight to the right of the red ball verb will be left empty in that case!

Straight to the left of the red ball verb is always the subject. Straight right from the red ball verb is always the

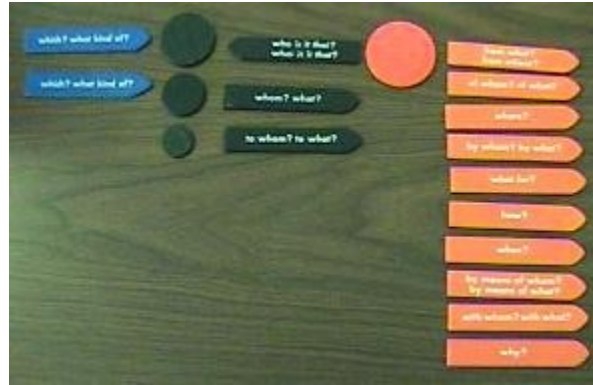
direct object. If there is an indirect object, it always goes directly above or below the direct object - on the right side of the red ball, neither above nor below. The adverbial extensions all go out from the red ball toward its top and bottom - not from its sides.

When **adjectives modify the subject**, the blue arrows hang off of the black subject circle, and **the adjectives appear at the end of the blue arrow**, cut off from the paper strip and **placed over a blue triangle**. For these **regular adjectives**, the **blue triangle is used**.

For an appositive (a noun of opposition or noun repeater - all can be used to describe adjectives hanging off of the subject), the black triangle is used. The **black triangle is only used when the subject is restated** - an appositive; it remains a noun in effect and this is why it is black.

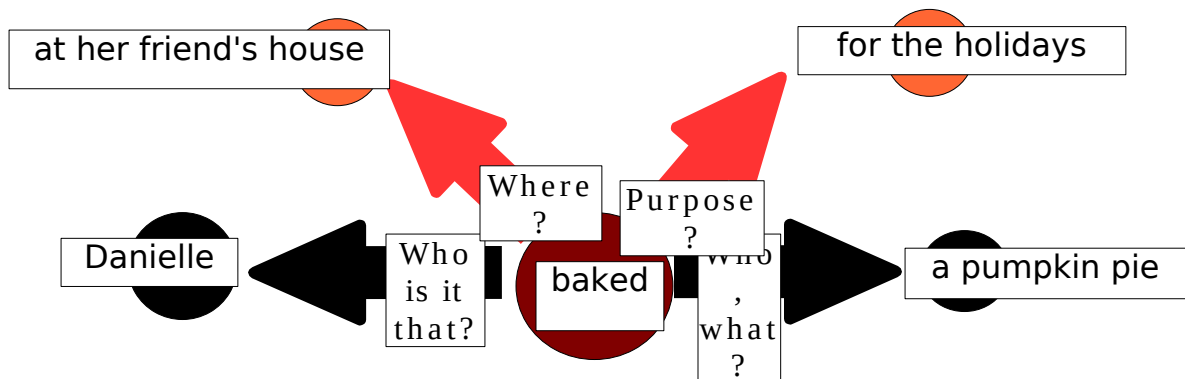
Extension

In our box, **we also have blue arrows**. The questions are like “which, what kind of”. The phrase “on a cold day” would use such an arrow. We cut the word 'cold' out and place it onto the orange adverbial extension, we have the blue arrow coming down from it.



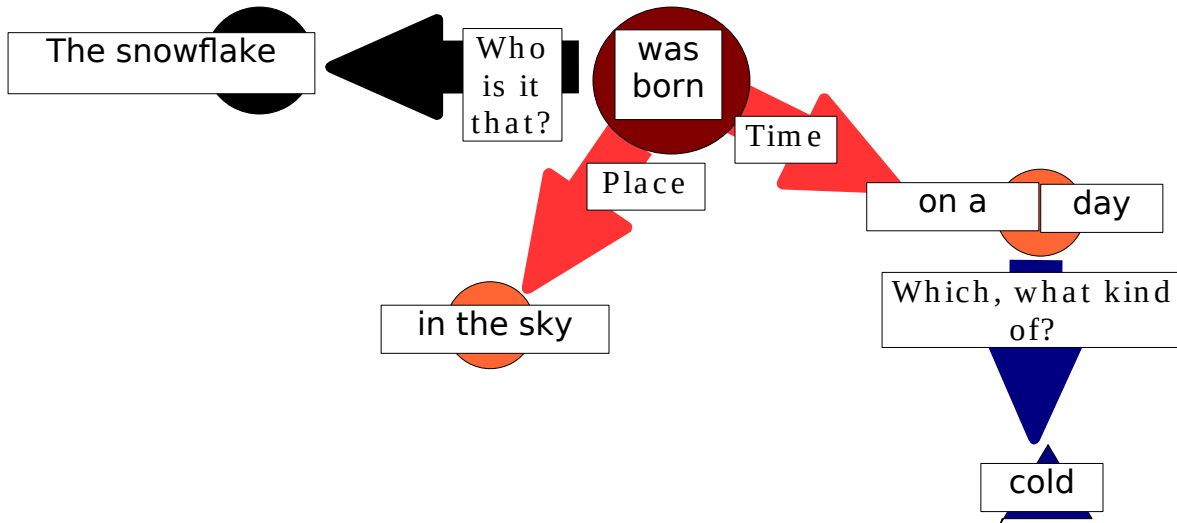
initial layout with both blue and orange arrows

For example, “Danielle baked pumpkin pie at her friend's house for the holidays.”



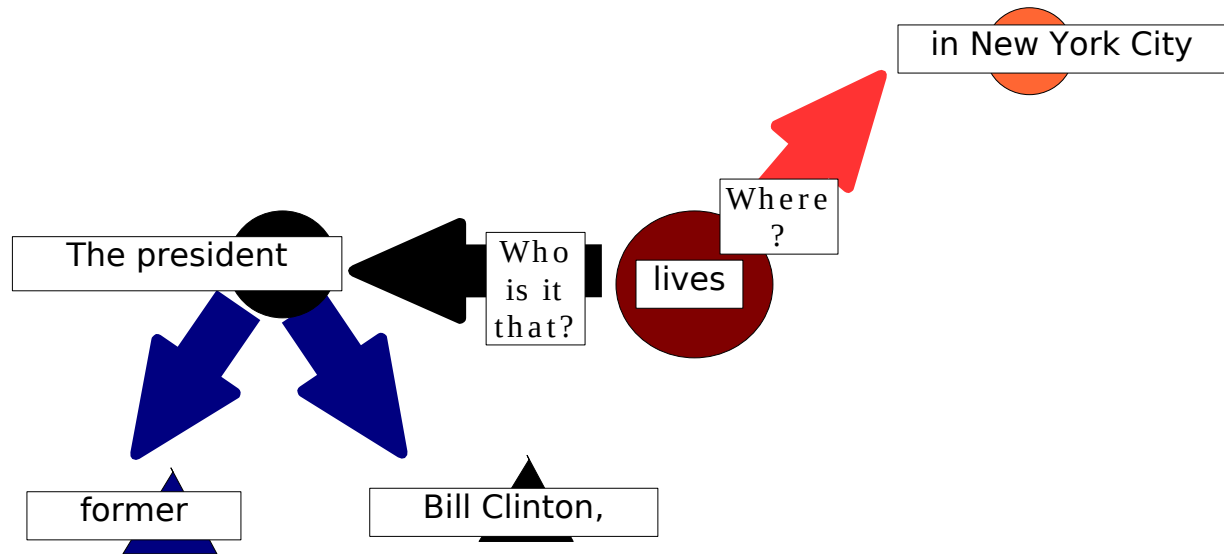
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When an adjective modifies a noun in our adverbial extension, we can split it off using a blue triangle and blue arrow. For example, “The snowflake was born in the sky on a cold day.” We call the adjective 'cold' an attributive adjective since it describes 'day.'



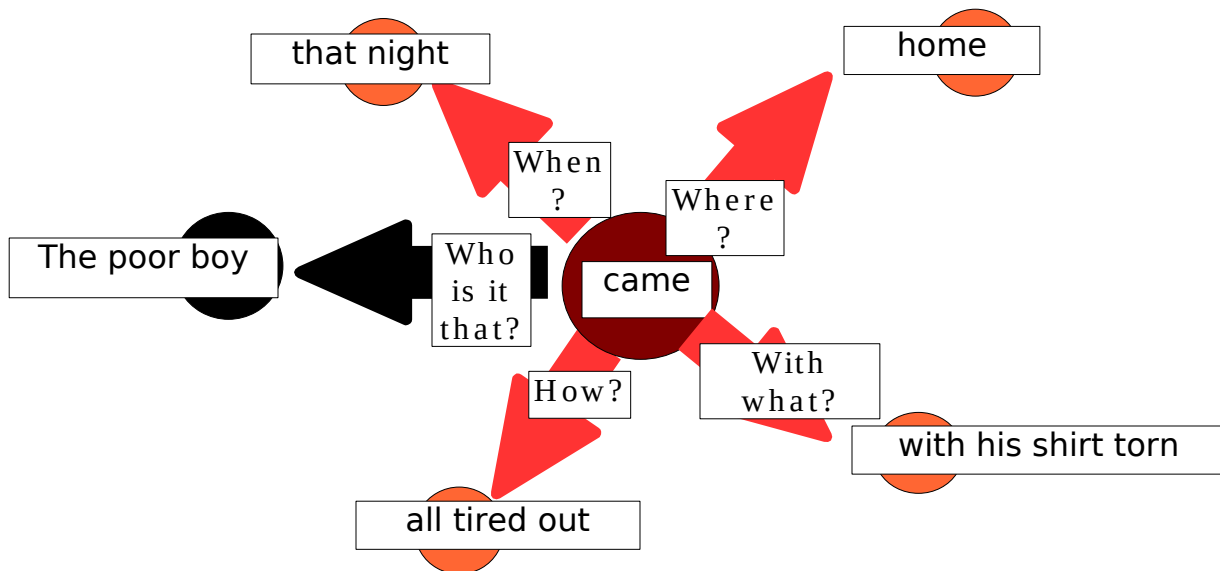
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“The former president, Bill Clinton lives in New York City.” In this sentence, we also have an adjective 'former', which can be split off from the adverbial extension as an attributive. But 'Bill Clinton' is a special modifier since it restates the subject; we call it an appositive and use a special black triangle to show it is the subject restated.



===

"The poor boy came home that night all tired out with his shirt torn."



December 6, 2004

Second Stage - Analysis Chart A

Material

Analysis Chart A

PREDICATE The verb or verb and predicate complement	who is it that? what is it that? SUBJECT
whom? what? Direct object	to whom? to what? Indirect object
by whom? by what? Agent	of whom? of what? Possessive, Material
when? Time	where? Place
from what? from where? Source	how? Manner
why? Cause	what for? Purpose
by means of whom? by means of what? Instrument	with whom? with what? Accompaniment
Attributive	Noun of direct address

Prologue

This second stage uses **Analysis Chart A** instead of the arrows, etc. On this chart are the same questions that appear on the arrows. Once the child is comfortable working with that first box of material, as a means of extending his work and introducing variety, one should introduce this chart. This work is done in a less regimented and more conversational style, since some of this is review at this point.

The child should be able to write his own sentences. For example, "My son loves his car very much." They would do it like this:

Begin

My son - that's the subject (**cut paper strip, place on the chart's rectangle**)

loves - that's the predicate (cut paper strip, and place on the chart's

rectangle)

his car – that's the direct object (cut paper strip, place on the chart's rectangle)

and so on.

Epilogue

When we see they don't use the chart very much any more, we're ready for the next stage – the second box of analysis material. On the arrows in the new box, there are no questions – only the names. This is similar to using blank math fact charts.

The overall sequence across stages: box of arrows, analysis chart A and then second box of arrows.

Final Step

We work on paper now. “We went to Amsterdam in November.”

What part of the sentence is we? (subject). (write: we = subject)

What is went? (predicate) (write: went = predicate)

What is “to Amsterdam”? (adverbial extension-place)
(write: to Amsterdam = adverbial extension of Place)

What is “in November”? (adverbial extension-time) (write: in November = adverbial extension of Time)

Epilogue

The child writes the sentence and then write the cues at right underneath. Another thing to mention is verbals: **infinitives, gerunds or participles**. These are **verb forms that are used as other parts of speech** such as a noun – and therefore can be used as

other parts of a sentence. We should do some work with the children on these.

A participle is a verb form with characteristics of both an adjective and a verb. When it is used as a verbal, it means we can find these used as adjectives. For example, in the sentence, "We are reading *an interesting* book", interesting is a **participle, a verb form, being used as an adjective**. Infinitives are the general form of the verb and are used with "to." **Infinitives used as verbals are sometimes used as direct objects** as in: "He likes to travel." Sometimes they are used as the subject of a sentence: "To draw, was her ambition." Make a sentence like this, use the analysis materials to analyze the sentence and then point the child to this. **Gerunds are verb forms used as nouns**: "Painting is Jenny's hobby." These can also be used as a direct object: "Jenny enjoys painting."

December 7, 2004

Verbal and Nominal Predicates

Material

Either the first box of arrows or analysis chart A, plus our tray with the roll of paper, pencil and scissors.

Prologue

The predicate is more than the verb. A **linking verb** would be 'is.' But the predicate would be "is tall." Linking verbs take either a **predicate adjective** or a **predicate nominative**, in order to complete the linking verb. "is tall" is a predicate adjective. "Sue is a doctor" introduces a predicate nominative – a noun-like piece of information about the subject. A predicate adjective is sometimes called a **subject compliment**.

Note that predicate adjectives and predicate nominatives are both nominal predicates. This is another aspect of simple sentences to do at some point while the children are working with this material. We begin with a listening activity.

Begin

"The child reads." Hmm. Listen to that sentence again (repeat it)

Let's listen to another sentence like that. "The dog barks." (repeat)

"The bell rings." (repeat)

I'm going to write one of these sentences down on my paper.

Who'd like to analyze it?

: : :

What parts of the sentence do you have now?

Let's listen to more sentences: "Vicki is short." Let's analyze this sentence now.

: : :

In this case “is tall” is the complete predicate.

In sentences like the first example, we have **an action that we can see or hear**. This kind of predicate is a **verbal predicate**.

But we have these other kinds of sentences like: “Emily is tall” where a statement is made but **there is no action we can sense or feel**. This is called a **nominal predicate**.

December 8, 2004

Elliptical Sentences

Prologue

We would have covered complex and compound sentences before going into this more in-depth look at simple sentences. Rarely do we see this term in grammar books; elliptical refers to “...” and it relates here.

Material

First box of analysis material. The tray with paper roll, pencil and scissors.

Age

Toward the end of lower elementary.

Begin

(set up as usual. See paper notes from the several previous days)

The sentence is “Thank you.”

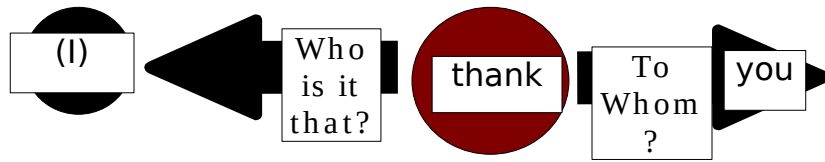
Do we have an action? Yes, thank. (assign with red ball verb)

Let's look at the two black arrows. Whom or what does not work.

To whom, what – that works.

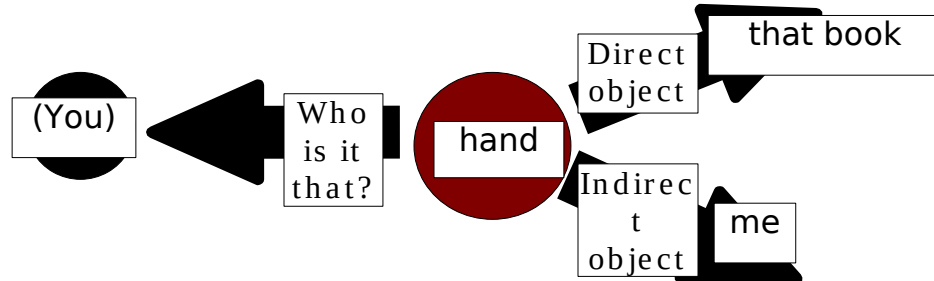
So we have a predicate and a direct object. **No subject, how strange!**

Do you think there is a subject here? Yes, we can imagine that the subject must be the speaker. **So we're going to write 'I' down – even though it wasn't part of our original sentence. I write it in parenthesis because it is understood and omitted in the sentence.**

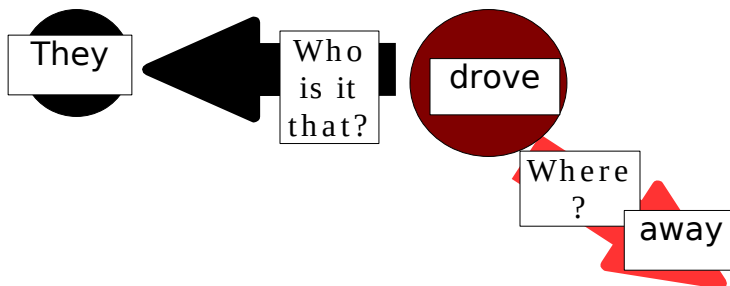


So we see we can have sentences that sometimes are missing parts.
We're going to complete them.

How about "Hand me that book."

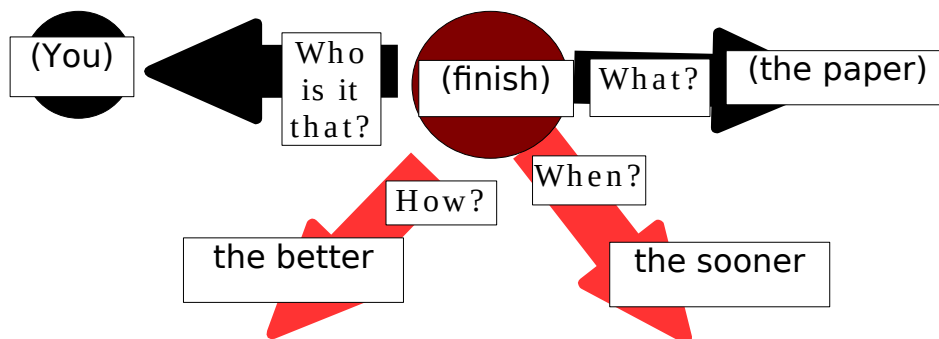


They drove away.

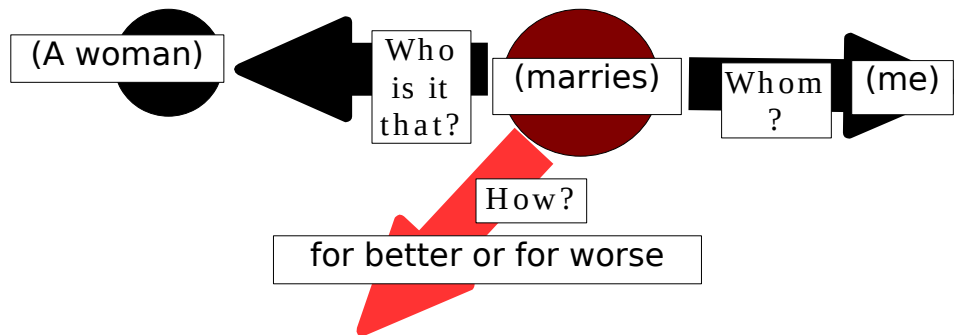


Missing direct object.

The sooner the better.



For better or for worse.



Epilogue

This is the just the same as earlier analysis lessons except there is a great number of possibilities in completing an analysis with elliptical sentences. Have fun with it; the point is to think, discuss and debate – not to get perfect analysis results. **Is the result logical?** That's important. In general, allow the child to make the decisions.

December 8, 2004

Order of Words in Sentences

Prologue

This still relates to simple sentences.

Material

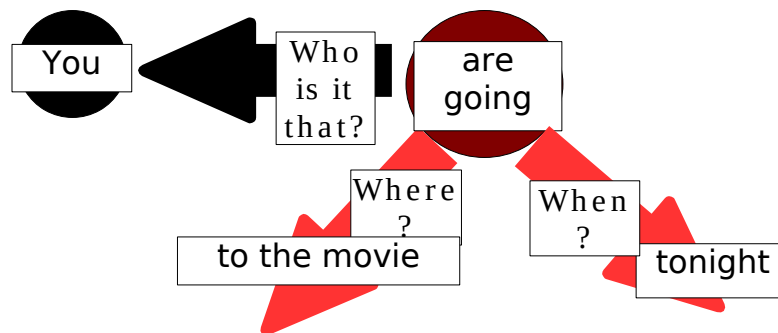
First box of analysis material. The tray with paper roll, pencil and scissors.

Begin

For the most part we've worked with sentences that had a subject, then predicate and then maybe other parts or maybe not. But not all sentences are in that order.

What about: "Are you going to the movies tonight"? (repeat several times)

Let's write that sentence down on our paper.



Let's read the sentence as we have it analyzed. "You are going to the movies tonight."

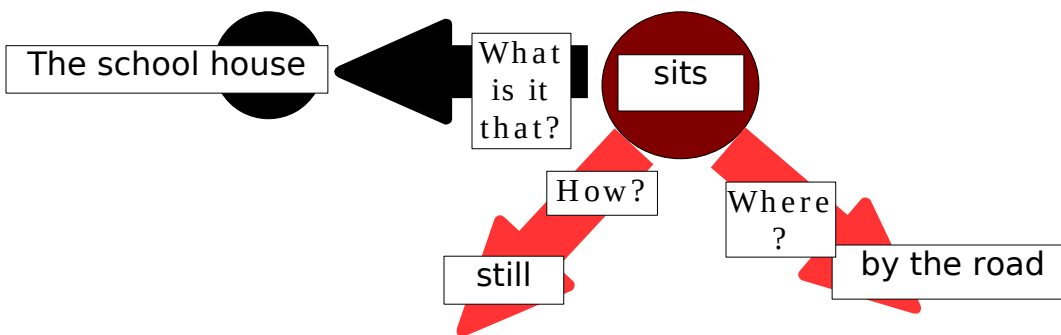
It sounds different!

When we have a sentence that **starts with a subject**, it said to be in

direct order or **grammatical order** or **normal order**. They all mean the same thing.

When you have a sentence that **does not begin with a subject**, we say the sentence is in **inverted order**. So questions are almost always in inverted order.

“Still sits the schoolhouse by the road.” Is this direct or inverted order? Inverted, right? What is the subject? (the schoolhouse) What's the predicate? (sits)



We also have 'still' on a slip and 'by the road' on a slip. Let's see how many ways we can order these.

“The schoolhouse sits still by the road.” This is direct order. Does it make sense? Yes.

“Sits still by the road the schoolhouse.” Does that make sense? Yes, kind of – especially if in a poem. What order is it? Yes, inverted.

“Still by the road, the schoolhouse sits.” Does that make sense? Yes. What order is it? Yes, inverted order.

How about, “By the road, the schoolhouse sits still.” Does it make sense? Yes. What order is it? Inverted, yeah!

No matter how you arrange these four pieces, it still makes

sense - though the meaning may change a bit. We can rearrange other sentences for practice.

Epilogue

A good source of sentences is poetry. Any time a sentence begins with anything but the subject, we say it is in inverted order.

December 8, 2004

Voice of the Verb

Prologue

Active voice is where the subject (person or thing) carries out the action expressed by the verb; the subject is the doer. Most of the time, we use active voice. It is the most direct way of speaking or writing. Passive voice is where the subject is not the one doing the action.

There are certain times we want to use passive voice. We use it when we want to direct the listener's attention to what we consider the most important part of our message. For example, "Penicillin was discovered by Fleming." Since penicillin was emphasized in this context, we'd use the passive voice. Another time to use passive voice is when we're not sure who is doing the action. For example, "They mine coal in West Virginia." That's active voice. In passive voice, we would say, "Coal is mined in West Virginia." We don't specify or de-emphasize the subject in this case - it's not interesting for us.

This is another small group presentation that would come after you've done all of the verb tense work. The reason we did not do this when we did tense - is because it makes most sense to present it along with the analysis work now.

Start off by listening to sentences...

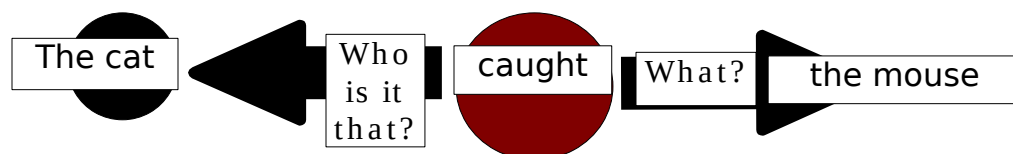
Begin

"The cat caught the mouse." (repeat several times)

What's the action? (caught)

Who did the catching? (the cat)

What was caught? (the mouse)



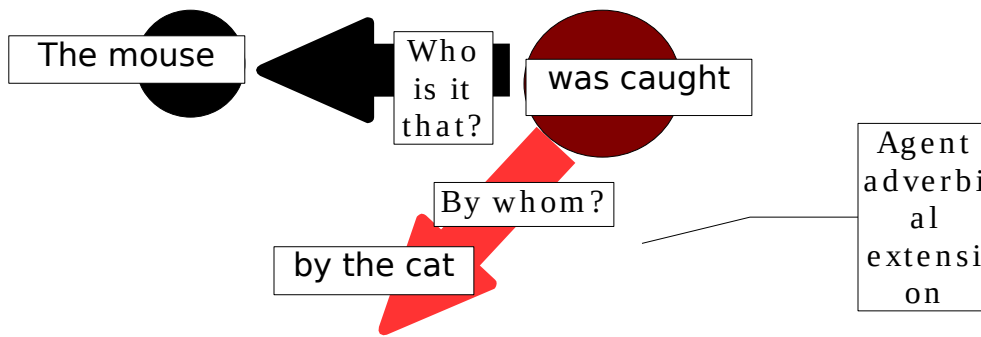
Now listen to this sentence.

“The mouse was caught by the cat.” (repeat several times)

What's the action? (was caught)

Who did the catching? (the cat)

What was caught? (the mouse)



So the same thing happened - it meant the same thing in both sentences.

Let's try two more sentences.

“Two women are painting our house.” (repeat)

What's going on here?

What's the action?

(painting)

Who's painting (the women)

What's being painted? (our house)

Now listen to this sentence. “Our house is being painted by two women.”

What's the action here? (painting)

Who's painting? (the women)

What's being painted? (our house)

Hmm. Interesting, again the meaning is the same. (think of more sentences)

Now – let's write some of these sentences down.

“The cat caught the mouse.” (write it and hand it to one of the children to analyze)

What parts do we have? (we have a subject, predicate and a direct object)

“The mouse was caught by the cat.” (again assign for analysis)

What parts do we have in this sentence? (subject, predicate and adverbial extension)

(repeat many examples, analyzing both of the variations)

“The cat caught the mouse.” This sentence is in the **active voice**. The subject is the agent carrying out the action.

“The mouse was caught by the cat.” Sentences like this are in the **passive voice**. The subject is not carrying out the action of the verb.

Let's do some more sentences and identify which voice they are in: active or passive.

Epilogue

With the children we should continue to do sentences, analyzing them and identifying what voice is used. When we did verb packets (verb tenses), all of those packets we did had a packet which said “active voice.” We have another verb packet; it's the verb “to love”. If you look at the back of the outside you see “pas” for passive. In there is the verb to love in the passive voice for all six tenses. You'd want to bring this out for the children. Let them set out all the tenses like we did the other verb packets.

We also have a chart that can be brought out after this lesson. It has the verb “to love” in all 6 tenses, conjugated on the left side in active voice and on the right side in passive voice. (chart is reddish brown, kept in the chart box). We could have the children do all 6 tenses in active and passive for another verb.

Another fun activity for older children is to write something in active voice and then have the children rewrite it in passive voice. You can do dictation with them also. When they are 8 or 9, they enjoy the challenge of dictation.

Extend - Reflexive

After you've introduced active and passive voice and the children have experience with this, and after you've introduced transitive and intransitive verbs, there is another aspect you can bring in related to this work.

Begin

“Remember that work we did with active and passive voice”?

Listen to this sentence. “The little boy dresses himself.” Or, “The little girl feeds herself.” Let's write one of these sentences down (write on paper)

Who would like to analyze this sentence?

(child analyzes the sentence)

Is this an active or passive voice? Is there something different about this sentence?

We consider this active but this is a special type of sentence because the subject and direct object are the same person.

This is called the **reflexive quality** in a sentence. “Himself” is a **reflexive pronoun**. The action is being reflected back onto the subject.

December 8, 2004

Transitive and Intransitive Verbs

Prologue

We may recall that nominative predicates use linking verbs. Linking verbs are intransitive verbs. Some verbs are both transitive and intransitive. "The child reads." It is intransitive here. If I add the "a book", the verb now becomes transitive. It is in how they are used that determines the verb's classification.

Again, we start with sentences we listen to, that condition the ear. Then we'll analyze them with our logical analysis material.

Begin

"The children made a snowman in the yard." (repeat several times)

Let's write this sentence down and analyze them.

What parts does this sentence have? (subject predicate and direct object)

"The children went to Chicago with their cousin." (repeat several times)

Let's write these sentences down and analyze them. (do analysis - each does one)

This verb 'made' is a **transitive verb** because **the action goes from the subject to the direct object**. A transitive verb always has a direct object. It's as if the door opens and the action goes from the subject to a direct object.



(hold up door pictures open)

The second kind of sentence, where we don't have a direct object - uses an **intransitive verb**. **There is no action that goes from the subject to a direct object.**

It's as if the door stays closed and no action is able to pass from the subject to a direct object.



(hold up door with the pictures closed)

Epilogue

When we present analysis, we put thing back into the box to aid the process of elimination. As the children become experienced, leave the analysis materials out and allow the child to use them as they will.

Once you've introduced transitive and intransitive verbs, you can show the children a special symbol used to identify an intransitive verb – small gold circle centered within the large red circle as well as the symbol for linking verbs – a white triangle centered within a large red circle.

December 9, 2004

Compound Sentences

Prologue

Up to this point in analysis, we've been working with simple sentences. Now we'll go on to compound sentences. **In speaking, pause to emphasize the conjunction.**

A simple sentence has one independent proposition but a **compound sentence has two or more independent propositions.** This means there will be two or more verbs. Each of them will be able to function independently - though they will be put together into a compound sentence.

In contrast, a **complex sentence has one or more independent propositions and also one or more dependent part - called subordinate clauses.** Because they are clauses, they will contain verbs. But because they are dependent clauses (subordinate) they cannot stand on their own as a complete idea.

As the children develop their language, up to about 4 years old, they speak in simple sentences. After 4 or so, they begin to use complex and compound sentences - sometimes run-on sentences. This work helps rectify use of run-on sentences.

As we do with all analysis, we begin with listening.

Age

Starts toward the end of lower elementary.

Material

Tray with a paper roll, pencil and scissors. Box labeled "Compound Sentences" with printed tickets, lower case a, b, c, d, several of each.

Begin

"I hunted carefully everywhere - **and** - at last I found it."

Let's listen to that sentence again. (repeat several times)

Can you repeat that sentence for me?

Let's listen to another sentence like that.

"I tried to get caught up on album reading but I am too far behind."
(repeat)

What do you notice about these sentences and how we say them? (we pause before and after the conjunction). What are you hearing when I say the sentences this way? Aren't you hearing the completeness of each part of the sentence? Could each part stand alone?

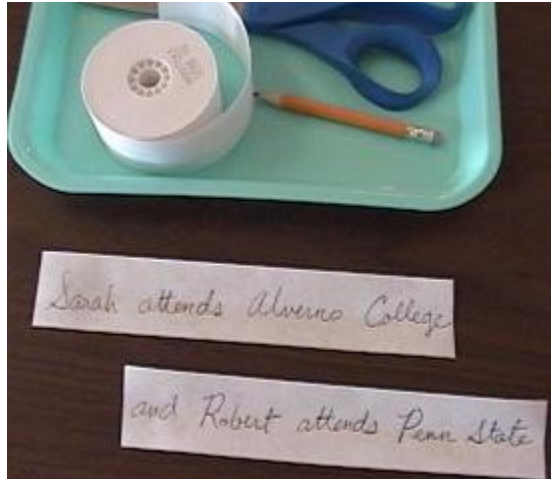
"Sarah attends Alverno College and Robert attends Penn State."
Again, you can hear I pause before and after the word "and" - our conjunction.

Well, let's take this sentence and look more closely. "Sarah attends Alverno College and Robert attends Penn State."

How many verbs do you hear? (2) Do we have two complete sentences? Yes, we do.

I'm going to **write this sentence** down. (write sentence on paper roll)

What's the first sentence we have here? "Sarah attends Alverno College." Alright, let's cut that first part off. (do so - now we have two paper strips - one for each part)



What's the other part? "Robert attends Penn State." Let's cut that one off. (do so)

My two sentences are joined by what word? (and) What kind of word is that? (conjunction)

We call this type of sentence a compound sentence. Both can stand by themselves. We have a little clear box labeled compound sentences. It has tickets labeled a, b, c, d, e.

We're going to **call the first part "part A" and the second part "part B"**. I'm going to **ticket** each part by laying the tickets above their parts (no label over conjunction)

We lay them right across from each other horizontally to show they have equal weight - equal value.



Let's do another.

"The flowers were blooming, the birds were singing and spring was in the air." (repeat)

Who would like to analyze this sentence? (child does so)

how many verbs do we have? (3)

Does that mean we have 3 separate sentences? (yes)

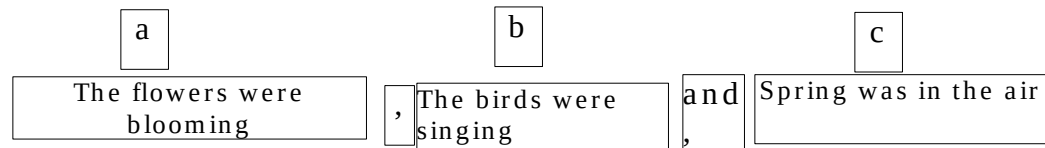
Can you find them? (cut out the first)

What's the second one? (the birds were singing)

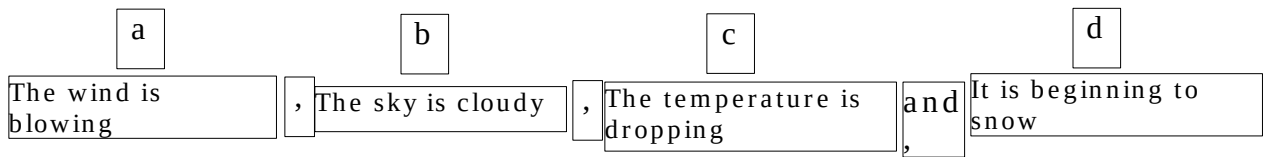
What's the third part? (spring was in the air)

Can that also stand by itself? (yes) (child **cuts out each part plus ',' and 'and'**)

Let's label the three parts. (place 'a' over first, 'b' over second and 'c' over third)



“The wind is blowing, the sky is cloudy, the temperature is dropping and it is beginning to snow.”



Epilogue

We have a little clear box labeled compound sentences. It has tickets labeled a, b, c, d, e. Make sure when you separate parts of the sentence to cut out conjunctions and commas separately.

Besides preparing them for what comes next, this work helps their writing. **We're working on punctuation and composing ideas. Let the children enjoy this work,** though, without too much correction.

Compound sentences are two sentences of equal value joined together by coordinating conjunctions and commas. The **important realization about compound sentences is that each part has equal value** – equal importance. The children have to be able to recognize this aspect before you go on – because complex sentences have a difference twist over and above this. It's important the children are clear on this before going on.

December 9, 2004

Complex Sentences

Age

Introduced in the 6-9 class but carried on throughout elementary.

Prologue

We'll still have **more than one verb** but now we'll deal with sentences where one part is the main part called the **independent part** or principal part. This part will contain a verb but then there will be other parts, other groups of words that are also going to contain verbs and therefore, **there will be other clauses** (since the verb distinguishes a clause from a phrase). But **these other clauses will not be able to stand on their own** logically.

We'll work with different **types of subordinate clauses: noun clauses, adjective clauses and adverbial clauses**. We'll see that the work with simple sentences is laying a crucial foundation for this work. We'll see **relationships 1) between adverbial clauses and adverbial extensions, 2) between an attributive and adjective clauses and 3) between noun clauses and where nouns are typically used** (subject, direct object and indirect object).

Generally, we work with the first box and the chart (first period with variety) and then the second box (second period), culminating with work on paper (3rd period).

An **adjective clause** does the work of an adjective in relationship to some word in some other clause.

An **adverbial clause** does the work of an adverb in relationship to some word in some other clause.

A **noun clause** does the work of a noun in relationship to some word in some other clause.

In every case, the **clause is in relation to some word** in some other clause. As we analyze, it will be **important that the dependent clause is placed vertically downward from that word**.

Material

We'll use a tray with a paper roll, scissors and pencil - plus movable arrows (**two boxes**) and a **chart B ("Principal Clause")**. The **first box of arrows has questions on one side of the arrow and names on the other side** (like the simple sentence material). The **second box of arrows has the names only**. The chart has both questions and names. The work with simple sentences is crucial as a basis for progress here.

PRINCIPAL CLAUSE	
Incidental Clauses	(Parenthetical Clauses)
Subordinate Attributive Clauses	Adjective or Relative Clause
who is it that.....? Subordinate Subject Clause (Subject Clause)	whom? what? Subordinate Object Clause (Object Clause)
when.....? Subordinate Clause of Time (Temporal Clause)	where.....? Subordinate Clause of Place (Locative Clause)
for what purpose? Subordinate Clause of Purpose (Purpose Clause)	why...? for what cause? Subordinate Clause of Cause (Causal Clause)
how...? than what? Subordinate Clause of Manner and Comparison (Mood Clause)	on what condition? Subordinate Clause of Condition (Conditional Clause)
in spite of what? Subordinate Clause of Concession (Concessive Clause)	with what result? Subordinate Clause of Result (Result Clause)

Chart B, Principal Clause

Begin

"When you entered the classroom, what did you see?" (**repeat**)

How many verbs are there? (two) **Does that mean we have a compound sentence?**

(when you entered the classroom does not make sense)

Let's think of another.

"The ring, which I found in the staircase, belongs to Sarah."
(repeat)

How many verbs are there in that sentence? (two) What are they? (found and belongs)

Do we have a compound sentence? (no)

Which words go with 'belongs'? (the ring belongs to Sarah)

Which words go with 'found'? (which I found on the staircase)

Can that part stand by itself? No - the two seem to be a little different, right?

Adjective Clauses

How about this one.

“The first thing that the children needed was some colored pencils.”
(repeat)

How many verbs are there here? (two) What are they? (needed and was)

Do we have a compound sentence? (no)

Which word goes with 'was'? (first thing was some colored pencils)

Can that part stand by itself? (yes)

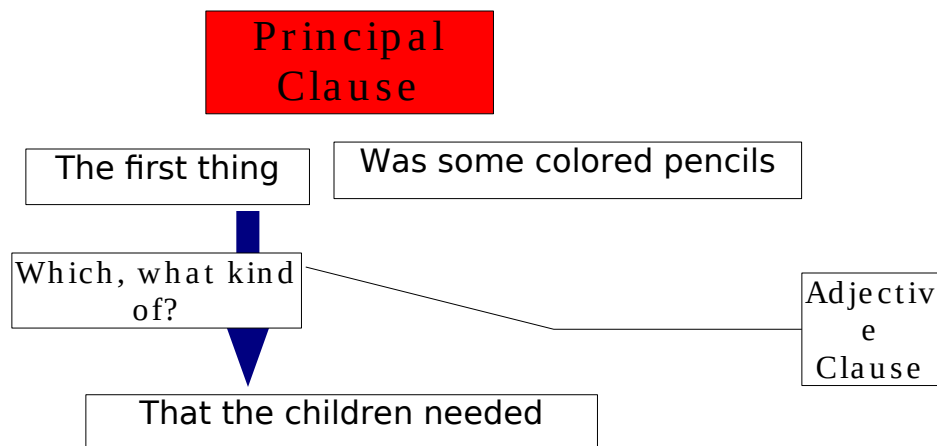
What words go with 'needed'? (that the children needed)

Can that part stand by itself? (no)

Again, it's left hanging isn't it?

Let's **write one of these sentences** down on our paper.

“The first thing that the children needed was some colored pencils.”



How many verbs do we have (2)

Do we have two parts that can stand alone (no)

Which word went with “was”. (first thing that the children needed)

This part that can stand by itself is called the **principal clause**.

But now we have this other part left. I have some blue arrows in my box.

Let's see if we can use this blue arrow to figure out what to do with the rest.

The first thing ... what kind of thing? (that the children needed)

So **this arrow will come down from that word 'thing'**. We call this an **adjective clause**.

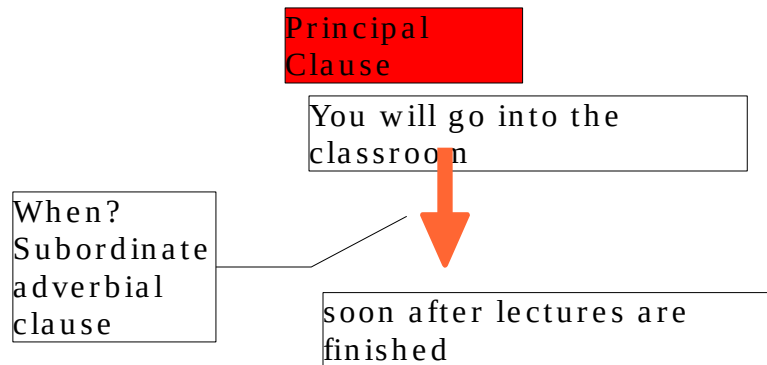
We're now working with complex sentences. We'll find the principal clause and then analyze the other part that is left for how it relates to the principal clause. Those are called **subordinate clauses**.

The gold earring which you found yesterday belongs to Sally.



Adverbial Clause

You will go into the classroom soon after lectures are finished.



How many verbs do we have and what are they? (2 - are finished, will go)

Do we have a compound sentence? (no) **Why not?** ('soon after lectures' cannot stand on its own)

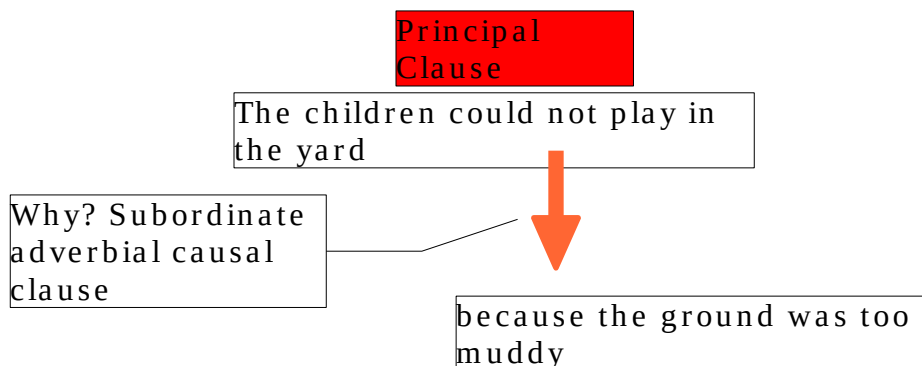
How about this other part 'you will go into the classroom'? (it can stand on its own)

So **we've found the principal part**. Let's find out about the other part using my arrows.

(continue)

===

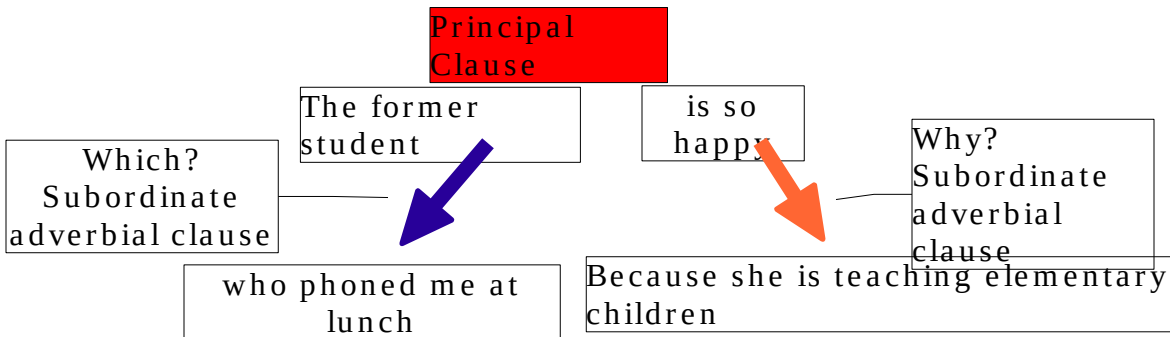
The children could not play in the back yard because the ground was muddy.



NOTE: This example is not a compound sentence since it uses a coordinating conjunction.

===

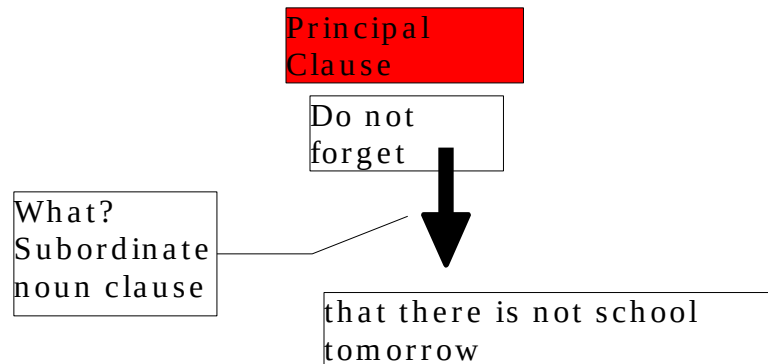
The former student who phoned me at lunch is so happy because she is teaching elementary children.



Noun Clause

Who would like to do our next sentence? How about this sentence:

"Do not forget that there is no school tomorrow."



How many verbs do we have? (2)

What are they? (do not forget and is)

Do you think we have a compound sentence here? (no)

Well let's find the words that go with our verbs. Which go with the first verb?

Do not **forget** -

Is - there is no school tomorrow

That word 'that' identifies dependent clauses. There are certain words that point them out to us.

So we'll make them "do not forget" and "that there is no school tomorrow."

We've got a principal clause - do not forget.

Now we have an arrow. **Can we find a question on an arrow that these parts answer?**

No - none fit.

Well I still have 3 more arrow in my box.

This time our dependent clause is our noun clause.

What kind? (direct object clause)

Yes - **this time our dependent clause is a subordinate noun clause functioning as a direct object.**

(the following outline example is correct - use it consistently for all others)

"She told whoever would listen the good news."

What are our verbs? (told and would listen)

Which words go with the first verb told? (she told the good news)

Which words go with the second verb (whoever would listen)

Do we have a compound sentence here? (no)

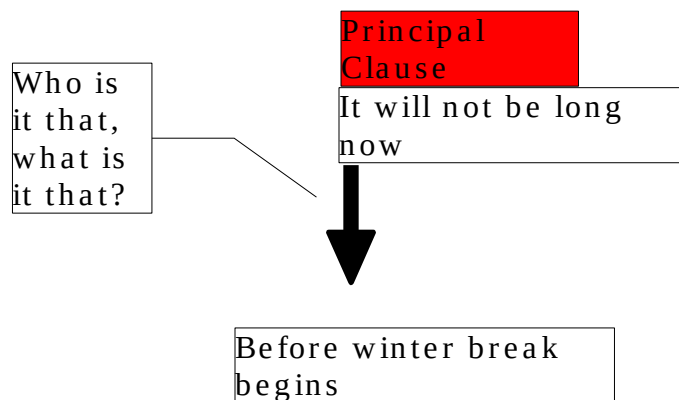
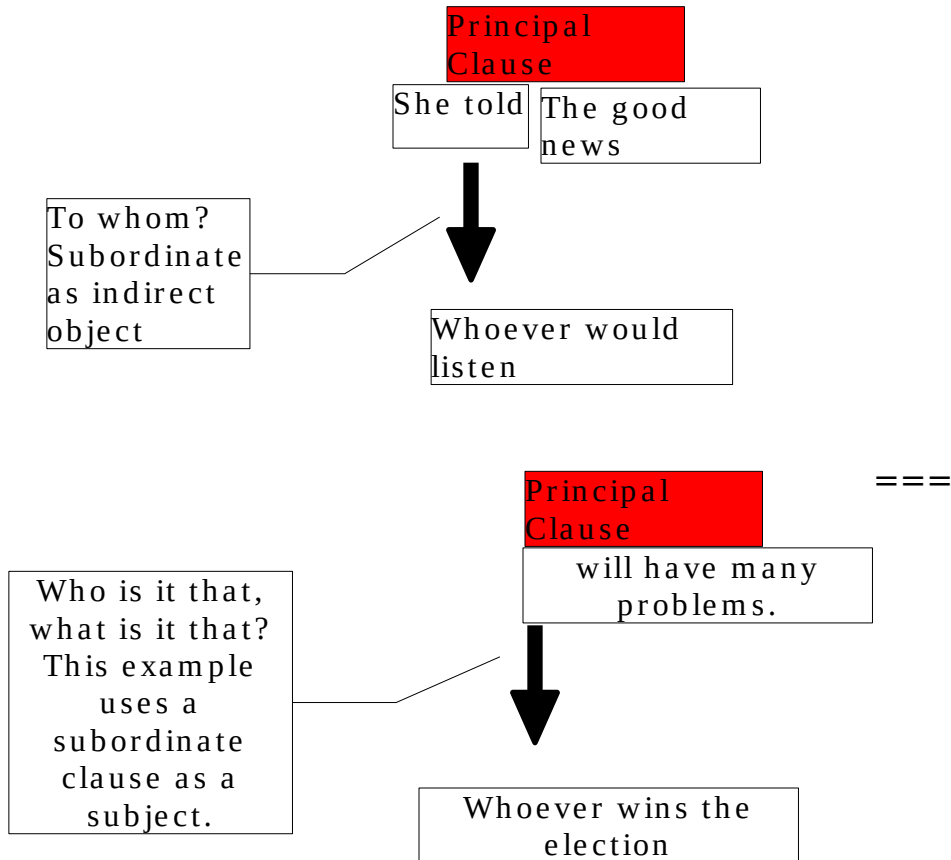
Do we have a part that can stand by itself? (she told the good news)

Okay, we've found the principal clause.

Which arrow can we use? (to whom)

This time we have a subordinate noun clause. What kind? Let's turn the arrow over to see.

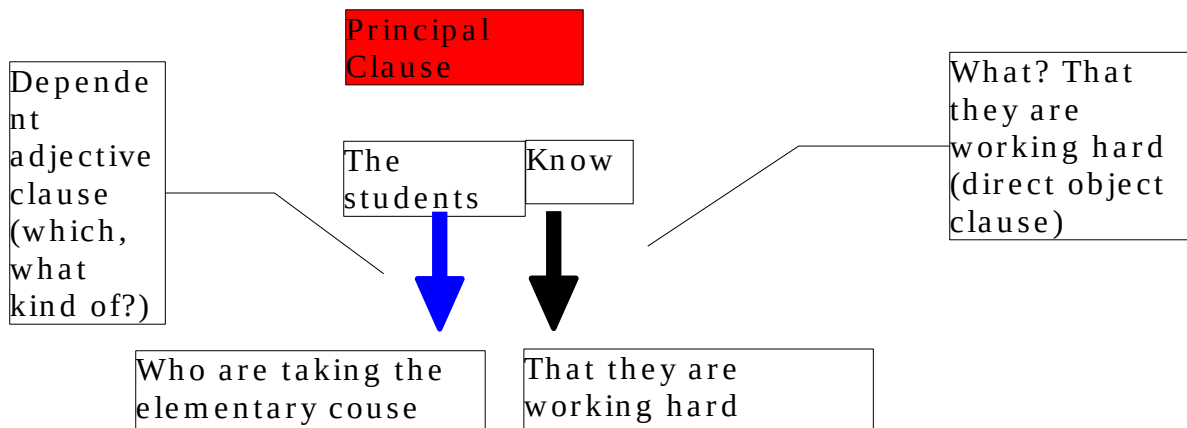
An indirect object subordinate clause.



“It” is an expletive – taking its meaning from something else.
(dependent subject clause)

===

“The students who are taking the elementary course know that they are working hard.”



Epilogue

The introduction is a pretty directed introduction: guide the child to find the part that stands by itself and ticket it (red slip saying principal clause). Start with adjective clauses.

Once the child has learned a type of clause, ask them “What kind of clause it this” and this will prompt her to turn the arrows over to find out.

Introduce adjective clauses first when introducing complex sentences – followed by adverbial clauses – lot of experience with both. Then finish with noun clauses.

Once all of the material has been introduced and the children are comfortable with working with it – introduce analysis chart B (titled “Principal Clause”). All of the questions and names from the arrows are on this chart.

Finally, when they are not dependent on the questions

anymore, introduce the second box of arrows – with the names only. So the pattern is the same as is used with simple sentence material.

Compound sentences are joined together by **coordinating conjunctions** – and, but, or – for example. **Dependent or subordinate clauses** often begin with **subordinating conjunctions** – although, because, since, that – for example.

Dependent or subordinate clauses can also begin with relative adjectives such as 'whose' or relative adverbs such as 'when', and 'where.' And they can start with **relative pronouns – which, who, that (depending on how its used)**. These key words are to be noted as introducing a subordinate clause; the children can develop an awareness of this special character of these kinds of words.

There's another kind of sentence we do not deal with using the materials – using another class of conjunctions. That is correlative sentences, sentences using correlative conjunction pairs – either, or – both, and – neither, nor. These sentences are considered to have two clauses but they are so closely intertwined that one cannot separate them. **“She can both sing and dance.” This is a correlative sentence.**

The New Webster's Grammar Guide is an excellent book for complex sentences (ISBN 0425125572).

December 10, 2004

Complex Sentences - Degrees of Dependence

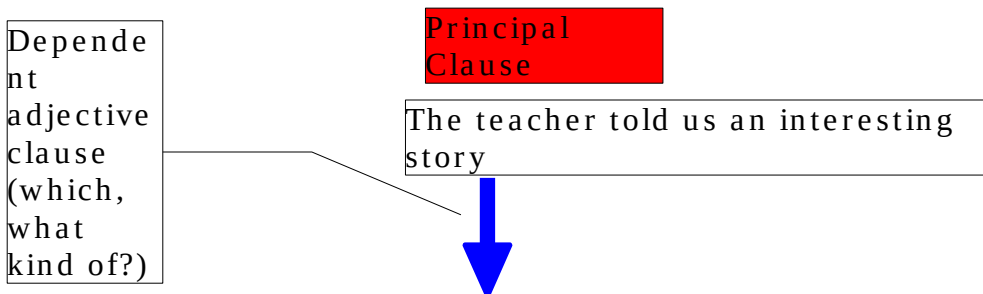
Prologue

Complex sentences can have their dependent clauses arranged by degrees of dependence. So far clauses have been directly dependent from the principal clause. That's not always the case. We'll introduce these here.

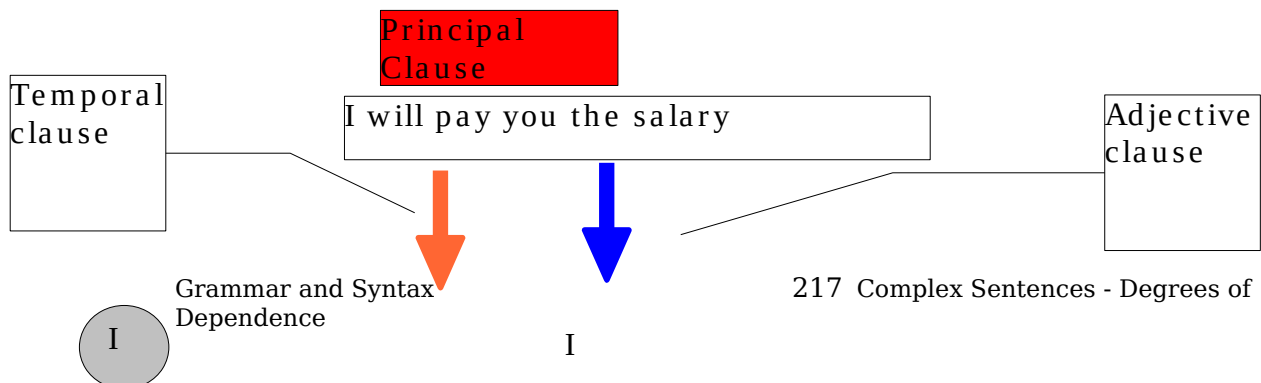
We **introduce a new clear box of disks labeled I and II indicating the degree of dependency**. Disk I is used for those clauses that are “dependent in the first degree” (dependent on the principal clause).

Begin

“The teacher who visited last week told us an interesting story”

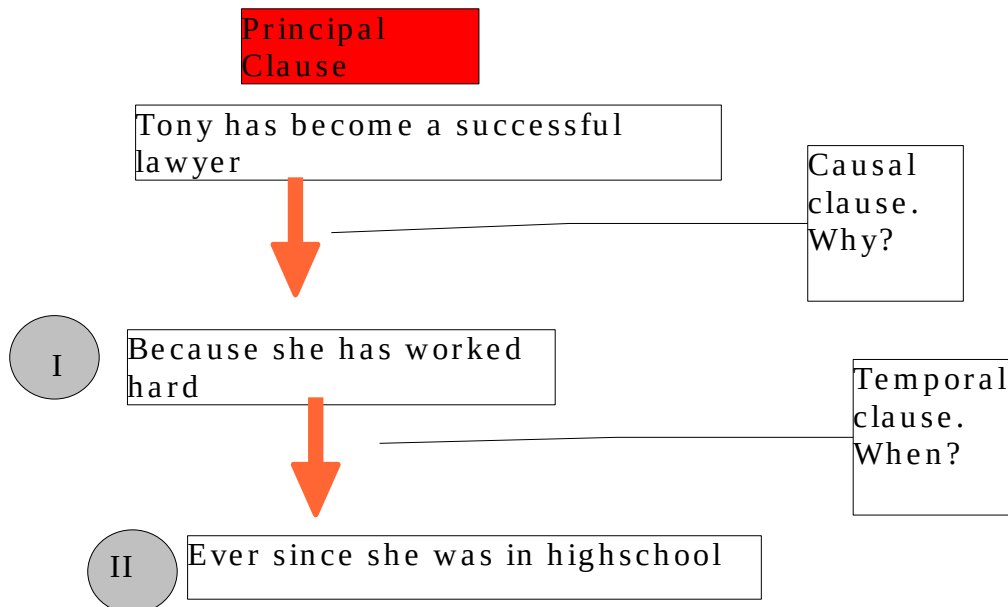


When you have finished the job, I will pay you the salary you have earned.



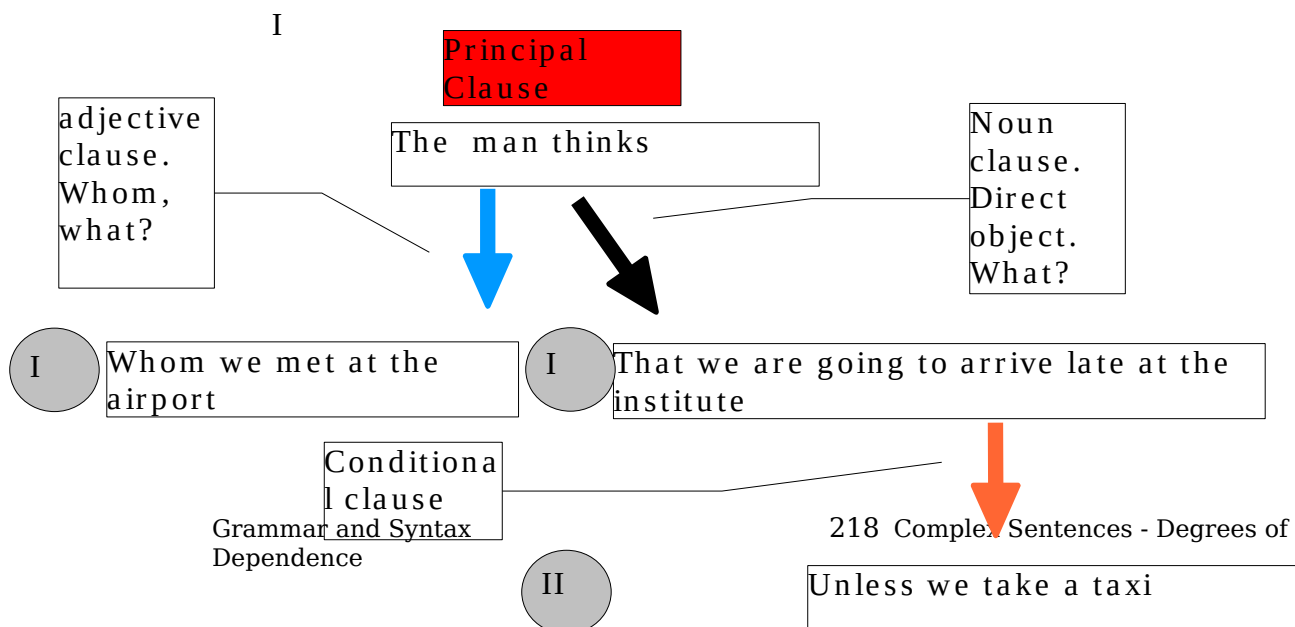
When you finish the job You have earned

Tony has become a successful lawyer because she has worked hard ever since she was in high school.



A clause off the first subordinate clause is called dependent in the second degree - so we place a II next to these clauses.

The man whom we met at the airport thinks that we are going to arrive late at the institute unless we take a taxi.

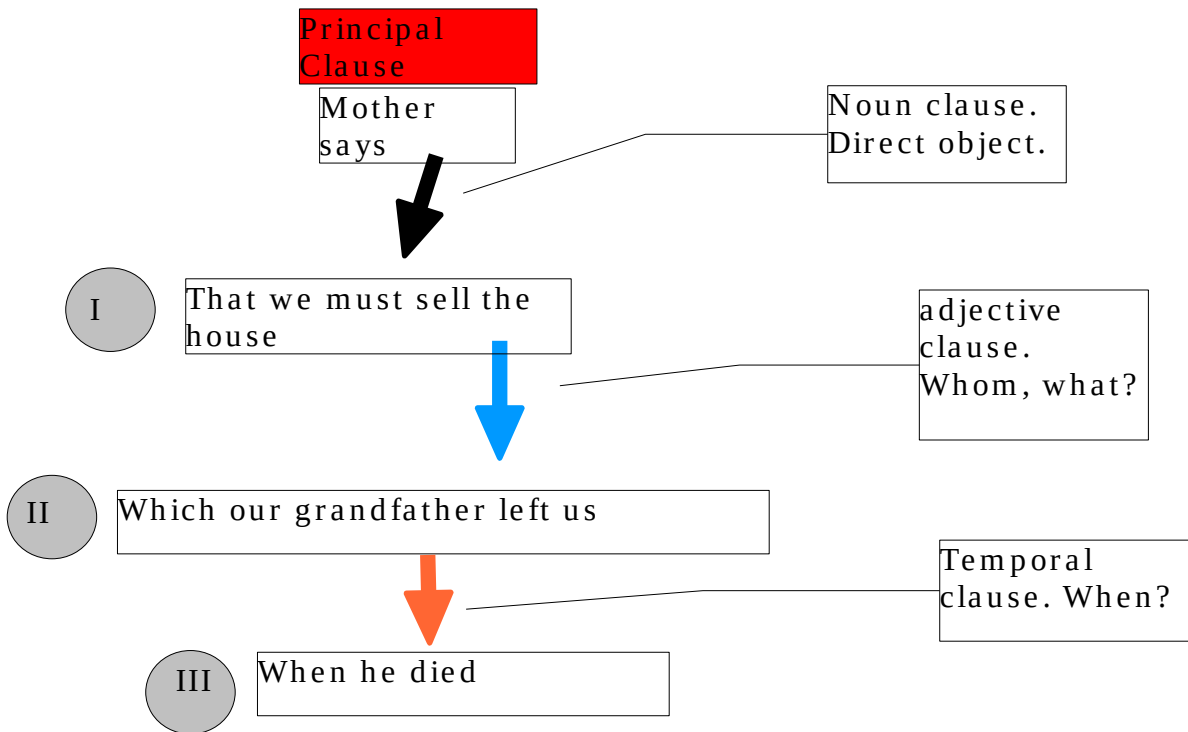


Grammar and Syntax
Dependence

218 Complex Sentences - Degrees of

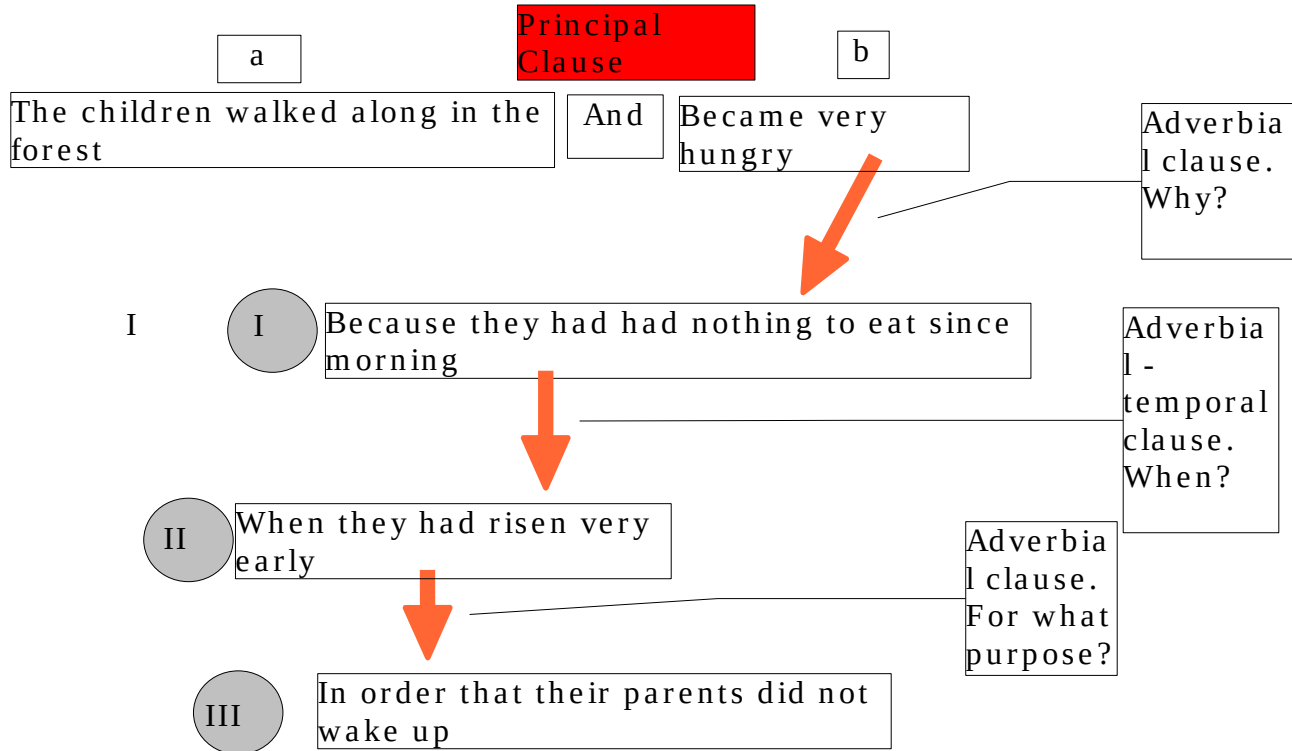
Mother says that we must sell the house which our grandfather left us when he died.

I



The children walked along in the forest and became very hungry because they had had nothing to eat since morning when they had risen very early in order that their parents did not wake up.

NOTE: In this example, the **principal clause is also a compound sentence**.



Epilogue

There is analysis chart C (discussed in the “Montessori Method”). In left column would go the principal and any coordinate clauses that go with it (such as a and b above). In the middle column come clauses that are dependent in the first degree. The last column (far right) is for any clauses dependent below the first degree.

Principal or Co-ordinate (Incidental)	Subordinate and its co-ordinates	Subordinate to Subordinate

This work encourages children to write sentences, using many arrows if possible, but also to choose sentences from good literature. Chart A is for simple sentences, chart B is for complex sentences and chart C is used for complex sentences with degrees of

dependence.

November 17, 2004

Spoken Language

This lecture is in many ways a summing up because we have been talking about spoken language in the classroom and the need to allow the children to talk. We've discussed the need to encourage the child to speak at home - to converse generally. This is very different from hearing language on television. We'll speak generally about spoken language and discuss several specifics about it in the classroom.

What is unique about elementary is that spoken language as opposed to written language requires an ability to think clearly, in the moment. With written language, there is a different time element - it is not in real time - as speaking is. If you are writing something important, you can go back over it, rethink it, revise and tweak - to make sure it says what is intended.

So often in spoken language, what is said is misunderstood. It can be taken in the wrong way and cause trouble and confusion. We need to speak clearly, to use words carefully and to be mindful of the responsibility associated with speaking. Spoken language cannot just be erased as the written word can. One has to think on the spot to express clearly what one wants to say.

Dr. Montessori, when she began her work in 1907, wanted to make sure the children were not in a traditional classroom setting in the Casa dei Bambini. This is one reason she suggested that the room should be set up more like a drawing room - with furniture spread around in comfortable arrangements. Furniture - not rows of desks. She also wanted to ensure that the class was not silent. She envisioned a room where **all were free to speak**. She made the analogy between the classroom sound and the hum of a beehive. She **expressly wanted the sound of people having relationships**, as opposed to adults speaking and children listening.

The children coming into the elementary class should realize that they are coming into the same kind of working environment used for activity, interaction and for work. It should not be a traditional classroom any more than a Casa dei Bambini classroom should be. From the language work in the primary level the children experienced conversations. The children should be participative in conversations with the teacher, with other children and other adults - not by force, but by inclusion. We don't force them into show and tell. We speak to

them, bringing ourselves to their level, allowing them to speak at our level as they are ready to do so. The children should be encouraged but not forced to speak.

We should **encourage the children to speak about what they see** in pictures on the wall, to describe what they see. As well as to help them develop their spoken language, this leads to them being able to write descriptively later on. This is why we vary what is in the environment from time to time.

In the children's house and the elementary **classroom, the tone of voice should be monitored**. They must realize that a tone of voice on the playground is not appropriate in the classroom. Being able to talk freely in the classroom means talking within the limits of not disturbing others and wasting time. This becomes one of the privileges in the classroom. It is the **responsibility of the teacher to make sure the noise level amongst those working together doesn't become too high**. Different people do have different levels of tolerance for noise and we have to be considerate of this and work within some reasonable boundaries.

Dr. Montessori said we should draw attention to the noise level by a soft ringing of a bell. It is to be rung – one time. The children need to know what the bell indicates. They are to stop and to bring their attention to the noise level and this is more effective with a soft ring. Sometimes people turn off or flick the lights off, to get the children's attention. Dr. Montessori said that we should use the same sense that needs attention, to get their attention.

The children in the Casa dei Bambini, through the opportunities that are given to them to talk to others, should have the opportunity to extend their vocabularies but also to become more self-assured. They should become more and more able to express themselves clearly. They get practice doing this. So the children coming into the elementary class should continue with the same opportunities as found in the primary level, for using spoken language – but now with an added dimension.

At the second plane, we're **dealing with the development of the *reasoning* mind. So, all of the language work, whether spoken or written, should have as one of its primary aims the development of the reasoning power of the mind**, the development of the power to think logically, the power to develop an argument – from one reasoned point of view to another. The ability to form reasoned logically held opinion and to be able to give reasons for taking that opinion is what we're after – not colored by emotion – but

perhaps to express it reasonably.

The second plane is the time for exploring society, its work and activity. Part of the language work that goes on in the elementary classroom should be to **help the children gain a command of reasoned language**, so that they become more and more able to communicate with the society within that classroom, to understand the part they play in the life of that society – a part which will become greater and greater as they get older. They also need to understand their responsibility for the judgments of that society and for the part they play there.

The spoken language work in the elementary classroom involves, first of all, a general use – the life of the class itself, the relationship of the children with one another and with adults, in exercising their responsibility toward care of and participation in the environment. The sharing of tasks and work within the classroom will necessitate spoken communication. As the work of the class goes on, so the life of the class evolves. Therefore, spoken language should have its own special role to play in the evolution of that life. As well as that general use of spoken language, there are some specific areas of language work in the elementary class that should help spoken language develop in particular ways; these must be included as well.

One of the most important areas is that of **discussion**. Discussion should be encouraged. As we work with the children in group situations, we can help to **encourage discussion by the questions we ask** the children, eliciting their opinions and being very careful ourselves to give attention and recognition to what each person says. By our encouragement to a child, we can help the other children also learn to listen to and accept what is said. We don't have to agree but we **need to listen and to respect what is said**. That ability to discuss around a presentation of a lesson that we might give, should be a very real part of any presentation that we give. The children need to practice putting forward their own ideas and thoughts about what they experience and learn. We must establish the protocols for discussion to achieve order and the children must understand what that protocol is in order to cooperate and for discussion in general to thrive.

When we prepare our **presentations**, one thing to keep in mind is to ask oneself what opportunity does this presentation provide for discussion by the children. What can they bring to the conversation related to this information? What do they already know and what might they have already experienced related to it, that can be drawn out in discussion. It is in using the words in the child's own

mind, that he will learn to speak best. It is through discussions that the children begin to be able to see that there are other aspects of this subject-matter to explore. It is their questioning that will lead them to see that they can find out more on their own – inside or outside the classroom.

Another important factor about discussion centers on the fact that, in this second plane, it's not so much a question of the child being correct in his answers, as it is being able to give the reasons for his conclusions or impressions. We want to **ask them why they say what they say, how they reached a given conclusion. This moves them through their own thinking process and helps them to express it.** Their thought process may be reasonable even when the conclusion may be incorrect. For our interaction to be effective, discussion is imperative. It must go on in the child's own mind, working out the pros and cons, reasons for and against. The children must have discussions with adults and with the other children. We have to be careful in our work not to revert to the traditional stance where the adult is always correct and the child passively accepts it.

Dr. Montessori wanted us to **set the child's mind working.** The adult's place in this is to act as a catalyst, to ignite the flame of interest in the child's own mind – so the child's mind can set up a discussion process with you and others. This is one reason why group work is so eminently important in the elementary class and why group work above all is how the child learns best in this plane of development.

Another area of spoken language work is that of **reports.** Reports should come at the end of a project or a group task, carried out by a number of children who each bring their own contribution to the final product. The group task is something that is shared, each one's contribution decided on by the children themselves. It should have something to do with what exploration is being done. These contributions are then written up, illustrated, decorated, modeled as appropriate – so the sum total is delivered in the form of a report that can be shared with the rest of the class or with those who have interest – even in other classrooms in the building. A **report can be read aloud to the audience if it's an older group of children or it can be verbally reported using notes** for younger children. Dr. Montessori was adamant that younger children never learn to read by reading aloud. Younger children can use one or two words written down to help them speak – sharing – about their work.

This kind of sharing is a way of stirring up interest in the classroom. Perhaps others watching reporting become interested in

that topic and take it up for themselves – or take up a related topic. This kind of sharing means it is not just the adult providing information to the class. The children themselves have a role in building up the knowledge that the class shares. This is why sharing these reports in some manner is very important. Through this sharing of reports, the child begins to understand her responsibility to society and how and why his usage of language is important. We have to help children understand that these reports cannot be about just anything they decide they want to share. They have to be about interesting relevant topics to the classroom. There are certain children who want to be the center of attention and one way to do this is to be in front of the group; this must be managed. All children must have the opportunity to share. These reports should be the outcome of a serious project and reflect cooperation and collaboration among the children. We have the opportunity to help them build this kind of mutual responsibility to each other and to their reporting audience.

Another area for spoken language is the giving of **speeches**. This is particularly for the 9-12 class. Speeches need to be prepared, thought out and researched, written out and reflected upon. They would be speeches chosen by the children who want to write about a certain topic - chosen for its topical interest or relevance to current events. **Speeches differ from reports in that they are prepared by one child - not a group** as is the case with reports. This is the *main difference between speeches and reports*.

Another area for the 9-12 class derives from the speeches. This is using spoken language in **debates**. The 9-12 year olds can be trained in the art of debating and taught the forum in which a debate is conducted. These debates can take place among a small targeted group or can be offered to the rest of the class. Members of the audience would then have to be guided as to how to listen and appreciate the debate. Speakers need to be prepared, discussions among members of the group take place, each side assembles their respective arguments and reasoning for reaching their conclusions. The idea is to have one side for and one against a given position. Each hopes to convince the judges or audience they are right. Speakers from the floor can participate once they understand the protocol used in debate format. This develops clarity of thought in all involved.

Another area in which spoken language is used is with **poetry**. It is best used by the 9-12 year olds due to the difficulty young ones have in reading aloud. This means poetry needs to be part of the life of the child from early on – hopefully, at home and in the classroom. Listening, memorizing, reading and writing poetry are all

activities for the 6-9 child. This prepares them for advancing in the elementary class. A group of children gather together and for each other, recite from memory or read poems. The poems can be written by the child or by others.

Spoken language also comes into play in **dialogue**. Dialogue can begin with the children's written work. One of the areas of written composition is with dialogue; this can begin with movable alphabets if needs be – one person's dialogue in one color and a second person's in a second color. After practicing in this way, they do a similar thing using colored pencils or inks. We can make up dialogue and then enact it with spoken language. The dialogue can center around other work in the classroom – dialogue from history, for example. This also entails a certain amount of knowledge about the event taking place to which the dialogue refers. For example, two people who lived at the same time in history could discuss an event occurring at that time. The two characters could also be from two different time periods or cultures and so on. So this not only entails spoken language but investigations into history as it relates to how a given individual would *feel* about such things.

Another place for spoken language is **drama**. Drama in the elementary class should develop from a piece of material called the *interpretive reading slips*. These are divided into series. Series I and II are for the primary class. They are not meant to be read aloud. They are for silent reading; the child then interprets and acts out what the card says. This shows he understands what he's read by his ability to act it out. This is one of the big contributors to *reading comprehension* in the Montessori approach. Montessori felt that these slips would be taken from good literature from one's culture. So these slips can be extended. These are not spoken language but there is occasion where one is called upon to speak in acting them out.

At the elementary level, acting, drama, speeches – all develop from this work with the interpretive reading slips. They help the children express from within themselves what they've read. It is preparation for the spoken language part of drama. They are a preamble to the plays and drama to come in the elementary classroom. From this work, the children can begin writing their own plays. If we encourage this, they will begin to write plays. And through this work, they are prepared to act out those roles and give expression to the words of the play. Without any preparation, handing out a script leads to monotone delivery, misunderstanding of context and other under-utilization of capacity. In writing their own plays, children have a vested interest in their performance. They will give

thought to who should play which parts. The children can be involved in all aspects of a production of a play. There are costumes, scenery, props – which all give rise to speaking and reasoning and problem-solving. We can involve other people where expertise is required as needed without stealing the children's thunder.

Dr. Montessori felt that reading aloud is comfortable for children at around the age of 11 or 12 since the brain and the eye have to move ahead of the voice. So we must remain sensitive to this as we dispatch the tasks involved in larger types of productions and projects. Reading out loud is the last stage of reading for elementary children – though we can do one-on-one reading aloud privately, as needed, to assess reading skills. Make sure plays, for example, are written by them – not someone else – to help them ease into verbalizing written dialogue. Remember that plays should encompass all areas of the classroom: botany, history, music – all areas are candidates. They can be fanciful but not limited to fantasy.

November 18,2004

Written Composition

Human beings are not unique in their abilities to communicate through sound and gesture. **It is a trait shared with other animals. However, what is unique is the ability to communicate across vast distances beyond which sound can travel - and across time.** So, human beings can read the thoughts of people long passed or in the present, as well as leave thoughts for people not born. Human beings invented and developed this ability; it is a gift from human beings to human beings. It is the wonder, the uniqueness and importance of this invention that we try to convey to the children through the Great Lesson "Communication in Signs."

Before the time of writing, language was at first strictly spoken and later represented through pictures. A great body of stories and historical accounts were built up in these oral traditions. In some cultures, picture-writing enhanced their oral traditions. They did not replace them though.

The Egyptians still have story-tellers. The Sioux picture-writings did not take the place of their narrators, who handed down their history by memorizing the stories - word for word.

Written language is spoken language made visible. This is the wonder of the sandpaper letters. What we write needs to sound good to our ears. People often read poetry aloud, even when they are alone, so they may truly hear the words as spoken. When stumped by a passage, we tend to reread it with our lips moving and our minds saying the words silently. When we keep in mind that written language is spoken language made visible, we can help the children develop their own writing. They should begin by telling stories orally. They need time to discuss with their friends what they will be writing. Then, they can write. When they come to editing their work, they need to read it aloud to hear it - before they can correct it.

Remember, **elementary children work in groups, so writing can be a collaborative effort.** We need to show the children how to work as a group, how to share out the research, how to bring it together into a product and arrange it for display or publication - how to share the work of presenting to others.

If we keep in mind the place that written language has in the history of humankind and remember for ourselves that we hope to

develop in the children a sense of gratitude to those who developed the written language we use today, then the work is a part of cosmic education rather than a series of rules and exercises to be executed and gotten through. **Writing should be going on everyday, all the time**, in our classrooms.

Our lessons in written language, whether developing punctuation rules, proper spelling or content, should have the same sense of adventure and wonder that the presentation of the story of the flower or the preludes to the winds do. We connect this work to the history of language and the development of writing. The work is given as a series of discoveries and explorations. We as teachers focus on ways in which we can help each individual child become a master of this great tool of written language – so that he too, can clearly communicate his thoughts to others without speaking.

When we write, we are **drawing together many different skills and areas of knowledge, using the creative processes of our minds**. It is a complex task. Children need time and practice to develop their writing. The skills are taught separately in isolation and later applied to the writing. We need to protect their creative efforts. This means we don't take up a story they have written and given to us, and pick it apart over spelling and punctuation. Nor do we take all the words they spelled wrong to construct a spelling list from it. This kills enthusiasm for writing.

So we need to do much education on this topic for parents and administrators. This does not mean we just let the children leave us without knowing how to make a 'clean copy' with good spelling and punctuation.

Work in the Children's House

The child's mind has been prepared. His **vocabulary has been increased from vocabulary enrichment** and other sources. He has encountered stories in the classroom, orally and in written form. He has seen literature there. He's been encouraged to speak, tell his own stories and to participate in conversation.

His **hand has been prepared by pouring, spooning, sandpaper letters** and in other ways. He begins writing via the movable alphabet – first single words, then phrases and then simple stories. Hopefully, he moves on to writing with paper and pencil in the primary classroom. He learns some punctuation and to decorate and

illustrate his work. This work is typically a few sentences.

It is important that the child enters the elementary class with the ability to write. For those in the elementary, writing should be a tool used to explore the universe as well as a way to express themselves. What about content?

Content of Writing in the Elementary

The first thing anyone needs is something to write about. **They need thoughts and ideas and words with which to express those ideas. Written language is a part of cosmic education.** Cosmic education gives the universe to the children – so they have many possibilities for writing.

In the area of **geography**, we talked about making suggestions for topics the children can look into further and then write about. We've seen the work of water and the work of air. Can you imagine stories and reports from those? We have **nomenclature cards** in geography. They can write their own **definitions** for a river and then compare it. Sometimes, their definition is better. They have the command cards in which they write a procedure and conclusion – which can later be compared to the statement card. They can research people in different geographical zones and their lives. They can **write letters to children who live in different parts of the world** through pen-pals and other means.

In **biology**, we also have **command cards**. The children can write brief **essays** about the lives of plants or about what types of plants grow in particular regions. Many students may write about **fantastic stories about the lives of plants and animals**.

In **math and geometry**, we help the children to use **words to describe the steps in various processes**, such as finding the algebraic formula for a binomial square. The lives of the mathematicians or their discoveries is an area to research and write about.

History is a wonderful area for writing. Children can write about various **individuals and groups of people in history**. They can write about historical events, inventions and inventors. History is a great area to **begin writing dramatic work**.

In **music**, children can write **lyrics for songs**. They can write a dialog as a composer from the past is interviewed by someone

from today. The children write the questions and the possible answers – for example.

We should be reading aloud, carefully selected, wonderfully written works of fiction to the children. In language, they can write about the history of language or the history of writing implements as well as writing fiction and poetry.

After the story of “Communication in Signs”, children may take up a **study of the different types of picture-writing**. You can give short stories that intrigue the children and then they may take up further investigation into topics such as the cave paintings. Tell a little story about cave paintings and then toss out questions: “What were they trying to tell each other? Where did they find cave paintings? What did they use to make pictures”? All of these stimulate events for writing.

They can study the **hieroglyphs of the Egyptians** or the paintings of Native Americans. There is the story of the **Rosetta stone** and the translation it provided, that is quite intriguing to children. They might decide to find out more about the tools for writing. The stylus in the classroom with clay is a means of experimenting. They can find out more about papyrus and what is parchment, what is vellum and when were these things used. Who used sealing wax and why. What about printing? Who invented the printing press. How did it change the lives of people and societies in the world. How are modern printing presses different than the first ones?

The story of **writing cannot be separated from geography, biology, history** and art and so on. These stories help to keep alive in the children an interest in their own writing. Your stories and the children's explorations inspire the children to strive toward beautiful writing.

In the 9-12 class, children may become intrigued with the story of a different kind of symbol for communication; the study of **heraldry**. Heraldry is the study of the symbols and colors which were adopted by groups of people or families to represent that group in war or government. Heraldry: An introduction to a Noble Tradition by Michel Pastoureau, is a good source with pictures of coats of arms of the past. Coats of Arms, by Andrew Stewart Jamieson, is another good book; this provides more modern artifacts of heraldry. Many symbols we see are heraldic in origin. Children enjoy finding out about the mottos, symbols and colors and what they represent. The distinguishing colors and patterns were meant to rally the knights in

battle. Team colors and symbols today originated from this past tradition. Another study of this type is the meaning of the colors and woven patterns in Kinte cloth from Africa. They symbolize tribes, passage to adulthood and changes in social position.

It is the stories we tell and then the children's exploration which ignite their imaginations. If we give them tools for writing, they will want to record for themselves and their friends what they have learned. Their excitement carries them along. This is what gets writing going in the classroom.

Making assignments, requiring daily journal writing, required doses of writing will be seen as a drudgery by the children. Soon, all but the most dedicated writers will avoid writing anything more than is required. Inspire them, give them the tools needed and then enjoy writing along with them.

Fictional prose begins with our **reading** good literature to the children. When we select books to read to the children – to read aloud on a regular basis – we need to select a book not solely based on content but also for the beauty and rhythm of the words as well. Do not shy away from books with sophisticated vocabulary; choose those that are just a bit beyond their zone of comfortable understanding and help them with meaning when they need it; this helps build vocabulary. One excellent source of material to read aloud comes from Jim Trelease in the form of an annotated collection of books called The Read Aloud Handbook.

When you read to the children and when you toss out ideas for writing, be sure to **cover the different genre** of literature. Make sure children understand what **science fiction** is. Help them to see what makes a story myth or **legend**. On occasion, encourage them to write their own stories in different genres. Sometimes, when you finish a book, you can throw out the idea of their writing in that genre – science fiction for example. “I wonder if you'd like to write a story in science fiction”?

Elementary children, with their sense of justice and compassion, readily take up the idea of writing from different **perspectives**. We might say, “I wonder what it would have been like to be a slave escaping with Harriet Tubman on the underground railroad”? I wonder if you could write a story as if you were that person.

Read **poetry** to the children. Enjoy reading children's poetry. Shel Silverstien is an excellent author for children's poetry; the book titled A Light in the Attic, for example. Another author is Jeff Moss.

We should not limit ourselves to children's poetry. Langston Hughes is an adult author that is also appropriate. We need to give lessons on writing poetry. We need to learn about and communicate to the children about the different kinds. The first step is just to get children started with playing with words. "Wishes, Lies and Dreams", by Kenneth Koch has lots of good ideas for getting poetry started in the classroom.

If children have gone through the grammar boxes, they can do a **fill-in-the-blank activity**. Choose: 1 noun, 2 adjectives, 3 verbs, 2 adverbs, 1 noun as a synonym to the first. For example, tree, barren, majestic, sway, reach, shines, lovingly, briskly, angiosperm. Now let the child play with this list in a poetic form. Or give the children a topic and let them write anything they want to about this topic for 5 minutes. At the conclusion, they read aloud and the others can repeat anything interesting they heard – not commenting or assessing – but repeating what was orally striking. Limericks, Haiku and other forms are all potentially interesting. Before going into sophisticated forms of poetry, we must go into more involved aspects of poetry such as meter, foot and stanza.

Another form of writing to take up is **drama**. This can be started with interpretive reading cards. Once they have a feel for drama, children can begin to write their own plays. A simple way to start with 6-9 year olds is a narrative play. A narrative play is where a narrator reads everything that happens and what each person says – while the actors pantomime the actions. Once they are writing dialogue, help them to convert to a drama by leaving out "he said", "he replied", etc. and adding in a description of the actions.

Letter writing is another form to be taken up in the elementary class. We should give lessons on the different forms of letters, such as business letters, friendly letters and thank you notes. They should be shown the proper type of stationary to use for the form of a letter. There are plenty of opportunities for the children to write letters. They write letters to set up going-out trips. They write requests to chaperones. They write thank you letters to all involved. They can write business letters requesting information to such places as the Smithsonian Institute or National Embassies. They may write to government officials to express their opinions about current events or to companies to express (di)satisfaction about a product.

Note-taking is also an essential skill for the children to acquire. Begin by reading a short passage from a book. Close it and talk with the children about what is important to remember from the passage. Ask them, "What would you want to tell someone else about

what we just heard?" Get the children to use as few words as possible to convey the sense they intend. If the children do not catch on to this, try reading one sentence from a book and go word by word, through the sentence, asking what words are essential to remember from this particular sentence. Is "the" essential? Have them write the essential words down on a slip of paper as a note. If the slips of paper are small, then the children will be reminded that not everything is to be written down; they can be stored in an envelope for later retrieval. Once they have the notes, show them how to organize them in a logical order. Then have them rewrite the notes using their own words as a guide. This process may take many lessons. It is repeated many times. It is an essential lesson to help them go beyond mere copying and plagiarizing other's work. Children who spend much time behind a TV often write TV thoughts over and over; this is their experience to draw from. They need our ideas and our reading to them to open their minds to other possibilities. If we assign writing assignments as a class, they will grind out TV stories. But if we give them cosmic education so the universe is opened up to them, they have more to draw from when we entice them into believing they also can write.

Increasingly, we find that standardized tests include writing. Many public systems have writing proficiency tests. A writing proficiency test is one in which the children must write to a given prompt or topic. The test is then scored according to content and writing skills. This often convinces teachers to force writing in the classroom everyday. To prevent this, we need to be familiar with expectations and format of the tests. Periodically, once or twice a month, one afternoon put away Montessori materials and projects and explain that this will be a time to help them prepare for a writing test. Tell them exactly what is expected from them on the test. Give them ideas of how to fulfill those expectations. Use the chalk board and write a prompt such as "You are going to move on to another class and will sit next to a new 4th grader. Write them a note to tell them how to succeed in 4th grade". Then together talk about ideas on what kinds of information one could include in the writing. List the words / ideas on the board and then give them time to work and write using those ideas. If revised copies are expected, take time to show them how to do this. Give them a deadline for a final draft if we are delivering a final draft. Don't do this daily or weekly. If it's not done too often, the children are accepting of this - otherwise they will begin to resent the activity. It should remain fun and stimulating.

If we tell the stories in our albums and add little bits to target their interests, if we let the children discuss and explore those interests, and if we read to the children and show our own enthusiasm

for the written word, then the children will eventually want to write. It will be difficult to stop them if they have become enthused. Then we must make sure they have the tools they need to write legibly and clearly.

November 18,2004

Mechanics of Written Language

Tools and Supplies

We must have something to write but it must also be clear. What tools and supplies will we need to enable this? An investigation into the history is a part of the language program – how is a pencil made and what is its history?

Children need pencils and erasers. These supplies may need to be monitored. Ball-point pens were created for convenience but do not allow control of the hand and they should not be in the classroom – the same is to be said for felt-tipped pens, they are for art. Instead have some calligraphy pens. You can invite a guest to teach a small group calligraphy or else you can take a class. One needs colored ink; children will dip the pen into the ink. A pen wipe is also needed that can be made from cotton, layers sewn together with a button, made in the shape of our metal insets.

There needs to be a supply of colored pencils and art supplies available. When talking with an administrator, try to gain control of what paper supplies are ordered for your classroom. Avoid bound composition books for written works. These are popular but there is a problem; if one makes a mistake, it's in there forever since it's bound into the book. Instead, use loose-leaf paper (notebook paper) because, first of all, the children will learn the responsibility to keep their papers collected and in order. Children can use different types of paper for a single project, blank paper for illustrations, graph paper for graphs and so forth; when they bind it together into one work it is complete. This is not as easily done with a bound book. Loose-leaf paper requires you to help the children to organize their work.

Some teachers have two file folders per child; one for finished work and another for unfinished work. Some people have binders for each child with dividers. In addition to notebook-size paper, one needs large paper for mounting projects, colored paper for decorative work and so on. Use of paper needs to be monitored until children have developed habits of conservation. Keep paper recycling and trash bins near your location. Establish that each paper is examined before being discarded. Guide them in ways to save and reuse paper. Perhaps a simple correction can be made instead of

using another page or part can be cut off or hidden. Maybe the unused portion can be saved. Do this until the children understand the value of paper and other supplies.

You will need supplies for binding together booklets. For the 6 year olds, this may be a hole-punch and colored ribbons. Older children can learn more sophisticated book-binding techniques; they need the art supplies and special paper, card stock and poster board, needle and special thread or glues – to do their projects. We need to learn book-binding techniques and other special talents for making materials. We need rolls of paper or scrolls – as a change of pace for the children. They will enjoy special papers and such specialties.

Hand-Writing and Appearance of Work

As the children move into the second plane of development and their characteristics change, we often see a deterioration in their hand-writing. Children are no longer urged by the sensitive period for order and so they may be content to be sloppy. They want to imitate what they think adults are doing as we hurriedly scribble a note to someone. Therefore, we should rekindle their interest in beautiful hand-writing.

One way to do this is to tell stories of hand-writing and books. You might tell a story about the Irish scribes and how they worked each day from sun-up to sun-set, copying books with a pen dipped into ink – since this predated printing presses. Introduce the children to one or two calligraphy hands – such as the Italian hand or the basic round-hand. These are taught with a dipped pen and ink – not a felt-tip or fountain pen. The dipped pen lends not only an historical note but requires total concentration and focus. That is the challenge for them – to do their best. A simpler version is, when writing, to use a light stroke when going up and a heavy stroke when going down. We can use colored pencils for this and it requires the children's care and concentration – and the result of this simple technique is also very nice.

For all written work except rough drafts, you must set a standard for neatness and beauty. Have a regular conference with each child during which you can discuss their cursive writing and whether it needs to be improved. When the children are practicing cursive, they need to be inspired to do their best. The first thing to

know is that we must model proper cursive writing.

When they have practiced a line of cursive, look it over with them and ask the child which one looks best. Have them circle that and ask them to see if they can make another line that looks that good. Pre-printed sheets of cursive are ineffective. We must model for them, so they can see the exact order and shape of the lines, the direction of movement and the stopping and change of direction involved. This is the level of detail needed for them.

If a child brings you a work that they say is their final copy and it is messy, say to them, "This is a good rough draft. Do you need help to make a neater copy"? For some children, they only need a reminder and for others, we need to get involved to show them what we mean. Children's work, beginning in the primary level, should be decorated. This typically means a small colored design down the left-hand margin or similar. A decoration can appear around the title and so on. If children have not been decorating their work in primary, give them an idea of the designs they can use and encourage them to invent their own. The Sailor that Captured the Sea: Storybook of the Celts by Deborah Nourse Lattimore, has decorations, beautiful borders, around every page – for example. This is the idea of what we are trying to convey to them – adornment that enhances the attractiveness. They will be proud of this and willing to exert the effort it takes once they see examples of what they can do.

Written work, non-fiction and fiction, should be illustrated. This too begins in primary. Illustration should be free-hand drawings. Don't allow the children to trace unless they are tracing a map. Dr. Montessori spoke of a mind that sees and a hand that obeys. This skill is achieved by observation and practice.

As the children become more sophisticated, you can teach drawing skills or invite an expert in to do so on occasion. Illustrations should not be confined to just the top of the page. They can appear on the top, sides or interspersed in the text. As we see examples in published books, point that out.

Another facet of decorating written work is illumination. This is another possibility for a guest lecturer on how to illuminate capital letters. Often, these are tiny drawings woven into the first letter of a page and is common in Celtic work. If you know something of this, one way to get children started is to do one capital letter, in isolation on a piece of paper, about 4 or 5 inches in size. Once they understand the idea, they can make the transition to the tiny decorations needed in a written piece. Have sample books in the classroom for them to see

and get started with.

In addition to colored inks in the classroom, have some gold and silver inks that are used just to illuminate letters. These are expensive and are not there for everyday mundane use. They are for some to use and to encourage others to aspire to a higher level of beauty. The history of illumination can be a study for the 6-9 class.

Vocabulary, Spelling and Word Study

Our early work with word study applies to the children's written work. It increases their vocabulary. They become aware that the suffix changes the function of a word – teach and teacher – for example – slow to slowly and so on. You need to have available a number of dictionaries and a thesaurus and to give lessons on how to use these.

Spelling is a part of word study. Make sure you're encouraging dictation exercises. They are central to mastering spelling. Educate parents and administrators about how spelling lags behind vocabulary; it cannot be looked at only in isolation but must be seen in context. We need to make sure that we do not let the children leave us with the idea that spelling does not matter. During their time in the 6-9 classroom, the children should be able to write a clean copy with no spelling or punctuation errors. They need to see this as a goal they want to reach.

The children should each have their own personal dictionary. These can be simple address books with alphabet tabs or they can be blank notebooks to which we add alphabet tabs. When a child asks how to spell a word, we write it into their personal dictionary. Or, if you notice a word in their writing that is frequently misspelled, we can write that word into their dictionary. Then, encourage them to use their own dictionary when they write. They can be used in cursive practice or dictation.

In helping children with spelling, of first importance is to enunciate the word correctly. Say the word with all of the sounds so they can hear it clearly. Help them understand the history of the English language. There is a history specific to spelling. It actually was not until the mid-1700s until the standardized English dictionaries became accepted. At this time, it was thought a sign of intelligence to be able to spell a word in many ways. In current

society, it is a measure of intelligence and education to be able to spell a word properly – one way. The children may find the history amusing.

In addition to word study, we need to teach spelling rules. Have some cards with spelling rules in isolation along with some samples. “I comes before E except after C” for example, is such a rule. We can use “statement cards” and sample spelling books which spread these rules amongst the students in class. Activities are useful such as:

Pattern	a-e	ai	ay	ey	ei
Example	ate	rain	tray	they	eight

Give the pattern and prompt them for the examples – all phonograms that sound the same. This is good exploration for them and increases the experience with words.

Remember that with grammar boxes we looked at singulars and plurals. This is a major part of spelling rules. With the suffixes, help the children become aware of rules related to adding a suffix – whether a vowel is dropped or a consonant is doubled – for two examples.

Homophones sound the same and mean something different: to, too and two. Activities can be built around exploration of what words fall into this category. Young children appreciate this very much; older children may be intrigued with the respective word histories.

Grammar and Syntax

In the United States, at this time, you need to help children understand there are different manners of speech and writing. You can do this without discouraging the everyday speech of the children. This is particularly important if you are teaching in a racially diverse setting. Nevertheless, children need to understand that there is a standard English which they need to master in order to be successful in school and in the job market.

The work we have done in grammar and will do in syntax

applies to the written work of the children and helps them to understand standard English. As a result of their work with grammar and syntax, many children will, on their own, begin to write more involved sentences, using different parts of speech and different sentence structures. This is particularly true if from the beginning, you have had them writing their own sentences to symbolize or analyze – rather than giving them prepared sentences. Some children will need a bit more help. For example, you can remind them of the work with the grammar boxes and suggest they try adding more adjectives to their writing. You can suggest they symbolize something they've written. Help them to recognize sentence structure. This helps them to become conscious of the sentence structure in their own writing. Once they've had the lessons, draw their attention to sentence structure. You might ask, “Is this sentence, simple compound or complex”? Once children have done the verb work with simple tenses, they can begin to look over their own writing and see if the tense is consistent. As a general rule, once you have presented a concept and the children have practiced it with materials, you let them know you expect to see it applied to their writing. Some children need to be made aware the grammar box work and logical analysis applies to their work.

Punctuation

Another aspect of writing we have only briefly mentioned is punctuation. Lessons in punctuation are given in small groups to children who need them. Even if a child is an avid reader, sometimes they need help learning punctuation. Hopefully children coming from the primary level have learned how to write a brief story with capital letters. You give them a lesson on beginning a sentence with a capital and ending it with period.

One way to do this is to copy a paragraph from a book; do not put any capital letters or periods. Then with a small group, take a big dramatic breath and read the whole piece without pausing – to make the point. Discuss with the children what can be done to avoid this. Read the work slowly, pausing dramatically where a sentence ends, helping them to hear the completion of the thought and so the need for a period. And periods are followed by capital letters. You'll need to do this more than once. Encourage the children to read their work aloud to themselves and to listen for where they need a period and where capital letters are needed. When children write, they can

highlight punctuation and capital letters with different colored pencils or inks.

If you teach 6-9 year olds, you will have run-on sentences. We can present examples of them, reading aloud and exaggerating the word 'and.' Once read, challenge the children: "I wonder how I could write this if the word 'and' had never been invented. Let's take out all the words 'and' and see what we can do." Use commas where appropriate and be sure to read the final draft aloud to see how it sounds. At another time, take up when using 'and' enhances the writing – as well as the use of other conjunctions (introduced with the conjunction grammar box and command cards).

Other punctuation can be introduced as the children begin writing more complex pieces. Rules such as when to capitalize words and abbreviations can then be taken up. The comma, parenthesis, semi-colon and the colon can be introduced. Children who have been introduced to the grammar books on the shelves can use these to clarify use of punctuation. Most children enjoy finding errors in a newspapers.

You will need to give many lessons on the structure of a paragraph. These lessons are given when the children begin to write pieces long enough to require paragraphs. It is best to introduce this concept with non-fiction writing. Begin by looking at a few books and noting with the children how the paragraphs appear. Tell them the purpose of a paragraph is to focus the reader's attention on one idea at a time and to provide a mixture of general statements and specific information needed to understand the meaning of that one idea. Read a paragraph from a book and discuss the main idea. Identify the details that are provided in the paragraph. Repeat this process with the next paragraph, discussing how each is different but still part of the theme of the overall work. Encourage children to notice paragraphs as they read. Once the children have the idea of paragraphs, they can use them in their writing. Gather a group of children who have finished taking notes on a topic. Help them sort the notes, putting together ideas that belong together; tell them that when they write they should think of each group of notes as a paragraph. When they write a paragraph, they should write a main or topic sentence that tells what the paragraph is about – and then use the other sentences to tell the details of that main idea. If their report is about Egyptians, they might have a paragraph on clothing, one on chariots, one on hieroglyphics and so on. Over time, they can refine paragraph usage. Help them refine structure: main idea can come first or can come at the end; often there is a transitional sentence

between paragraphs; there are variations of using a single idea; have them look over their work considering paragraph size.

Writing dialog is another area to take up with the children. Start it off by giving a colored movable alphabet to each of two children. Then challenge them: "Let's see if you can have a conversation without saying a single word." They will take turns using the movable alphabet to communicate. Tell them this is called dialog. This can also be done with colored pencils. Dialogs are typically not very long. Later on, introduce dialog phrases such as "He said" or "she replied" along with how to use quotation marks.

Editing

Authors who can write one copy without editing are extraordinarily rare; this is a fact for the children to understand as they are often reluctant to copy and edit their own work. Not every piece of work they compose needs to be edited and done into a final draft. Some of it does though. They need to bring some work to a final clean and beautiful copy. Guide the children in making choices about which ones they will edit and recopy. Make sure to keep records that indicate when the children have done a final copy. Establish in the class that first drafts are done in pencil. This allows the child to erase when needed. In the 9-12 class, have them do a rough draft on the computer using editing tools to move text, check spelling and so on.

Once the child is satisfied with the work in the first draft, they need to know how to edit. This involves the teacher a great deal at first but eventually the children will do this independently. One way to get started is to teach the children simple editing marks. Tell them about the historical use of the term blue pencil. Blue pencils were used by editors to mark copy for corrections. Editing was therefore called "to blue-pencil." Show them some of the symbols: Carrot to insert a word; a squiggle to show reversal of order; a paragraph mark to show paragraph organization.

When you have a small group that has finished their drafts, help them to make a checklist for items to look for as they edit the draft. Spelling, periods, capital usage, verb tenses and so on - depending on what lessons the children have had - are interesting. Encourage them to reread their paper over and over, looking for a single type of correction each time. Encourage them to slowly read aloud to themselves to slow the eye down and help them see what

they will miss otherwise. Meet with them again afterward to look over their edits. Depending on the child, challenge them to find errors they have left. For some children, we need to point them out for them. Normally, we don't do every single point with them; if they've had a lessons, we expect it to be taken care of in the final draft. If they've not had the relevant lessons, we let these errors go. Once the first draft is edited, they can recopy it - making it as beautiful as can be. We want the child to take pride in the whole process - not only in the content. Help them decide how they will put it together into a final form; bound in a booklet, made into a poster, held in scroll form and so on. Let them lay it out without gluing (committing) until you have seen their plan, until they can do this for themselves through experience. There can then be a special time for presenting their work to others. Nine to twelve year olds can read their reports; younger ones can talk about their work and show related objects. If it's a piece of fiction, it can be left on the shelf for others to read over time.

Summing Up

Mario Montessori emphasized that it is the child and his intelligence which is developed - not the language. Language is the vehicle through which development of the child and therefore, the development of the intellect, is expressed and transmitted. Language is a tool through which inventive thought is passed to others.

When we present language to the children as part of cosmic education, we open up to them the possibility of exploring the whole universe and we give them the tools for clearly expressing their own thoughts. The Great Lesson "Communication in Signs" places written language in the context of cosmic education and therefore, in the context of human history. It helps children appreciate the gift we use. It is this approach which will make writing a joy for the child. A general lesson pattern is to introduce the concept (simile or whatever - often with an oral introduction), then let them see it in context of use, and then invite them to apply it to their own work.

January 24, 2005

Literature

Introduction

Literature and the language of literature should be part of the child's heritage from the first moments of life. It is from the environment that a love of learning develops. If parents are conscious of the power of words, children will be surrounded by language, even when the child is just newly born.

The child comes into the world without the ability to speak a language but with the potential for forming a language. He can only form a language if he hears it in the environment around him. Then he has to have the opportunity to try out that language for himself. He will begin to make these sounds and he should be encouraged to do so. We should encourage parents to think of crooning words, lullabies, the rhythm of rhyme - so that these become part of the child's environment, long before the child is aware of language as communication or as enshrined in books.

We need to communicate to the parents the importance of Montessori's ideas regarding remote preparation. The preparation of the environment, preparing the child for something that only later he will become aware of. Then, the parents can understand the importance of early language exposure. We need to be aware and to help parents become aware of the power of the human voice. The words said even to the smallest child should be words of great beauty. When we sit and rock a baby, we should look for something beautiful to say or croon - to the child. This is forming the child's foundation for literature.

Literature began as an oral tradition. It was passed down by the spoken word, long before it was written down. So, it's the human voice that passed down that literature. We want to develop a love for literature in that unconscious absorbent mind. That love will come through what the child has heard.

The small child is interested in sounds, even before he begins to practice making sounds. His interest can be used to introduce him to the sounds of the literature of his people - long before that literature is suitable for the child. Initially, it is the sounds that concern us. If we develop a joy for literature, when the time is right, the young child will be able to identify books and authors that

he likes, just like he can identify colors he likes. We're not surprised when a child says, "Look, there's a blue flower. Blue is my favorite color." In the same way, with the right exposure and foundation, the child will say, "Look, there's my favorite author."

Love of literature starts with rhyme and poetry, lullaby and chant. That's why there has to be beauty in these. It's only when it's beautiful that we respond to the written word – and love it. This is as opposed to the baby-talk manner of communication from parents.

Literature cannot be taught as a separate subject of the curriculum any more than any other area can be. If it is segregated from other subjects, literature becomes dry and dull, limited instead of unlimited. We have to be careful not to require the children to evaluate everything they read – to dissect and answer questions about it. If the children need to learn to write book-reports, we take care of that as an aspect of written language; it will be in that vein and purpose – something required to master – but separate and apart from literature proper. We have to be careful not to try to track everything a child has read and what they've gotten out of it; this discourages interest.

Literature has to do with the human spirit. This is why the child's first introduction to literature should be in the arms of family members – who love her and also love what they are telling her or reading to her. The infant will pick up on that love for the words – just as she feels love between people. Just as we have talked about the young child adapting to family life and taking-on likes and dislikes of that family, the child will take on the same likes and dislikes from what is being sung, read or chanted to him. Parents need to understand this is the case and be conscious of their own affect.

The principle of remote preparation tells us this introduction to literature is also an introduction to history, to the story of the child's own family, the history of songs this family sings, the poetry and sagas they are familiar with. The stories and heritage of that people are being introduced to the young child.

Parents also need to read out loud to the children from the time they come into the world. In the book, The New Read-aloud Handbook, by Jim Trelease, a book that should be in every lending-library for parents, he says that reading aloud should begin as soon as the child comes home from the hospital and that **reading aloud to them should continue into adolescence**. Even a short time of reading aloud to them is good. We are so busy so it's important to realize that even 5 or 10 minutes is helpful. Children in day-care and

toddler classes should also be read out-loud to. It's important to help these teachers realize that this does not mean it must be done in a big group. It should be in a small intimate group or individualized – for young children. It is the voice telling or reading the story that is important – **the sounds enunciated, the music of the language.** The child will absorb if care is taken to expose the child with the utmost care.

Literature cannot be divorced from letters – the building-blocks of language. It depends on letters and it takes its form from language. The delight in literature must begin at birth since this is when the child first comes in contact with the language of his family and his people. Parents often need help in knowing what to read to children. It's not enough to tell them to read to the child – taking realistic stories when they are young and moving to fantasy over time. There are lots of books that look cute but are full of nonsense. There's also a difference between the beauty of intentional nonsense, something by Lewis Carroll, for example – and something that lacks that beauty and is just nonsense. Intentional nonsense will invoke images in the mind. They will call up pictures or help develop the child's picture in his mind – instead of just a series of sounds without psychical imagery. **We want to stir up the child - introducing them to both reality and myth and legend. All of those things are appropriate at the elementary level.**

In the first plane, the child's introduction to literature should bring about a security and a comfort through the poetry, rhymes, lullabies, songs and stories that the child hears. We're not asking the young child to understand these things; they don't have to understand the content initially but still develop a love for the sound. They will understand later when their absorbent minds begin to reason.

We want to encourage the child to share in the literature and culture of his own people – as he begins to read it for himself. In the first 3 years of life, from hearing the language around him, the child makes his own language and practices it. This mother-tongue becomes his instrument for communication. Montessori said that by 2 ½ years old, the child has made that mother-tongue his own; after that, it's a question of expanding and refinement. This is another important reason to read to the children – they are making this acquisition of their language and culture.

The richer the language in the environment, the more variety and music in the language that the child can catch on to, will result in a richer content in the child's own language. Then, that child brings that enrichment into the children's house as well. Hopefully, the home

environment has some beautiful books for the child to look at and enjoy. This is another point for parent education. It is much better to have just a few carefully chosen beautiful books – jewels – rather than to have lots of poor quality books. Especially where money is tight, we need to help parents realize that less of higher quality is better than a great quantity of so-so books.

When the child comes into the children's house, there is often a reading corner or a reading area that should also give the child access to some carefully chosen beautiful books of high quality. This is what will help the child's interest and love of literature grow and develop. This is one reason why it is much better to have individually chosen books rather than sets of books. A set subtly imposes a structure that may impede free exploration. Sometimes we need to clear out what is in a given classroom. Pack up what should not be there and remove it from the environment. Each book that remains must be of high value. There are so many books available, it makes our responsibility greater and greater to choose carefully.

Educated human beings in the not-too distant past relied on a limited collection of books: the Bible and the Classics. Because of paper-back books, the market now is flooded. So we need to cultivate discriminating taste to know what to keep in our environment. We need to be aware of contemporary as well as older literature. Children's librarians and some children's book store staff can be helpful to us in this regard.

In the children's house, children are given the keys to be able to read, to come to what Montessori called total reading. By this she meant comprehending but also to relate to its content and to be able to personally grow from its content – to appreciate what the content communicates. So, when the children are just beginning to read, the teacher needs to make sure the children are given good quality books to read. The children should be able to pick and choose what is of interest.

In Montessori, we take care of the difficulties in reading before we ask the child to pick up a book and read it. We have phonetic object boxes and reading cards, puzzle words and so on that help the child deal with the difficulties in reading our language – so we don't ask them to read to us from a book. In a primary classroom, it's also nice to have some books made by the teacher; young children appreciate this and we can write about things of local importance or relevance.

Along with the children reading for themselves, goes the

teacher reading to the children – extending their language, expanding the story of their people and culture. And later, we bring in stories of other cultures and nations. Reading aloud prepares the child for the study of literature in the elementary classroom.

The children should be allowed to browse through books – to read if interested or just look at pictures. They have the right to start a book and to decide they don't care for that book. In the elementary, **this two-fold approach to literature should continue. The children themselves should be reading and the teacher should be reading to them also.** The teacher's reading aloud should be invitational, not mandatory. Having said that, remember that developing skills is important and if the children are not being read to at home, we must develop those listening skills – then we can make it invitational. We read and periodically stop and ask a question to find out if they are following – in order to assess their listening skills.

What the children read themselves should be left up to their own choice. We can influence their choices by the books we put into the environment. We can also influence their choices through what we read to them. In volume two of The Advanced Montessori Method, Dr. Montessori says that children will listen to anything that is really interesting. She used a variety of readings in Italy – fairy tales, short stories, novels and historical episodes. Much to her surprise, what the children liked best were the readings on Italian history. They also really like Itard's book The Education of the Young Savage of Aveyron. The history they read wasn't commonly thought suitable for young readers. An example is De Luca's book, Makers of Freedom. This book is a scholarly book written for adults. So we need to remember that children often understand and appreciate much more than we give them credit for.

Today, it's easier to read more but to be less cultured than in our grand-parents day. One can be a prolific reader but reading romance novels has a limited return in intellectual benefit.

Reading out loud to the children can take place at various times of the day. It can take place in the afternoon while the children are doing handwork of some type. This should be a time of peace and quiet. Reading during handwork is all right or while reading during cleanup is fine. Get the reading out loud established, then invite them to do design or other handwork. Sometimes the teacher's read out loud just before the children go home but after their jobs are done. At other times, reading out loud is done when the children first come back into the room after lunch or outdoor play.

Another point to keep in mind regarding reading to the children is that you don't have to finish every book that is begun. Sometimes reading to an intriguing place and then inviting the children to complete it on their own is useful.

G. K Chesterton, in his book, "On Reading", said, "The highest use of the great masters of literature is not literary. It is apart from their superb style and even from their emotional inspiration. The first use of good literature is that it prevents a man from being nearly modern. To be nearly modern is to condemn oneself to an ultimate narrowness, just as to spend one's last earthly money on the newest hat is to condemn oneself to the old fashion. The road of the ancient centuries is strewn with dead moderns. Literature, classic and enduring literature does its best work in reminding us perpetually of the whole matter of truth and balancing other and old ideas against the ideas to which we might for a moment be prone." Chesterton lived around the end of the 19th century in the U.K, which explains the use of the hat as a trend that ages poorly.

In another book called, "Earmarks of Literature", by Arthur E. Bostwick, echoes what Chesterton said. He said, "Is there anything about real literature that marks it for what it is? May we learn to recognize the blooded literary stock from the mavericks, the strays of literature. The untrained reader may sometimes error. That is because he does not know where to seek for the marks of identification. In its narrowest sense, the class includes only such writings as have permanent value, due to their form and the treatment of their subject matter, independently of their substance itself."

Literature is diaries, annals, biological writings, tales of exploration – not just stories. We need to give the children a varied diet regarding the books that we introduce them to.

At the **second plane of development, it's necessary to give the child the possibility of using his reason.** We help the child become aware of the thoughts of her ancestors and how they expressed themselves in writing – and anything else about their lives we can learn about. Dr. Montessori said the teacher can use reading to introduce the children to the most varied of subjects. Once they get started in exploring reading themselves, they can go in an unlimited number of directions, guided by that single passion for reading. The child needs to learn how to read – the tool required – plus the strength to use it – to be left free to find out for himself how the tool is used.

Open up a wide variety as possible to the child. Then, make

it possible for the child to pursue further exploration. But leave the choice up to the child. The eye cannot so easily see the mistakes or inappropriateness or degrading of the language that the ear will easily pick up. We are a population that reads more than we've listened to language – so put up with the destruction of our language and lack of beauty in today's language use. We want the child to have the chance to hear language that enriches and to develop an ear for hearing that type of language – to develop a love for language.

Rudyard Kipling, one of the masters of literature, said when he was in Bombay working as a newspaper correspondent and reporter, “It was necessary that every word should tell, carry, weigh and if need were, smell.” He also said that he, “experimented in the weights, colors, perfumes and attributes in words in relation to other words – either as read out loud so they may hold the ear or scattered over the page so they might draw the eye.” He wrote “The Just So Stories” which is meant to be read out loud – though today it is politically incorrect or at the margin – given the language used in his day. **We should read a paragraph out loud to get the idea of what it means to read a book out loud. Kipling said there was no line of his verse or prose which had not been mouthed until the tongue had made it smooth and memory, after many recitals, had mechanically skipped the grosser superfluities.**

If we first **entrance the child with the language that they hear**, then later, as they question and want to know more about some literary effort, their questions will tend to come out of what has really attracted and enthralled them. They will be able to tell why they really liked something they read or why they didn't care for it – without the need for writing a book report. Literature is one of those seeds of culture that Montessori asks us to sow during the elementary years. We're not trying to make literary experts out the children. But are we sowing as many seeds as we can to make literature appealing to the children? If we are, then the children will move on to the third plane with a firm foundation to take on whatever specialty area they're interested in pursuing.

January 25, 2005

Literature in the Montessori Classroom

When talking about **teaching literature**, Dr. Montessori said there were **three main aspects** to remember.

First, literature is related to grammar. Grammar provides the tools for the making of literature. It is the backbone of language, especially true for English which can be so easily written poorly. **Second, literature can be treated from the point of view of the analysis of its style.** **Thirdly, literature has to be treated historically.** It is affected by the tone and manner of the particular period of time in which it was written.

Taking grammar, first of all, since the child first entered the Children's House, he has been exposed to grammar as it effects language. **He was given the names of things** in his environment. We've include names that are similar but somehow different – such as glass and tumbler.

With later exercises, the **child becomes aware of what words do - the function** they perform in the language in relation to to other words in the sentence. As phrases and sentences are transposed, the **order of words** becomes more firmly fixed in his mind. Sentence structure is looked at in the Children's House through exercising we call **Reading Analysis**. In the elementary, we use **Logical Analysis**.

In elementary we deal with **simple, compound and complex sentences**. All of that time, the child has been encouraged and helped to write for and by himself – both factually and inventively.

The **grammar symbols** are used to add another dimension to this work. In early stages, they **make the child aware of certain patterns, of certain order** – to how words are delivered. In an adjectival phrase, we have an article, adjective and noun – small triangle, medium triangle, and large triangle - light blue, dark blue and black, respectively.

A conjunction can join two of those phrases together, though we never find a conjunction between an article and an adjective. The **verb seems to come, for the most part, in the middle** – at the center of a number of words. We don't often find a verb at the end of the sentence; generally other words radiate around the verb. The **noun and the verb seem to hold the two most important places**

in the sentence.

In the elementary class the child begins to **symbolize his own work and can then can begin to look for what patterns the symbols reveal**. Does this writing contain a lot of activity? Is the writing verbal? (Do we see lots of red circles?) Is the writing descriptive? (are there lots of adverbs and adjectives?) Or, is this piece of writing heavy and somber? Does it contain lots of nouns? Are the sentences short and crisp or do they ramble on - or - are they of a complex nature but clear?

Another element which can help develop the child's feel for and understanding of literature is to help him search for the meaning of the words used by the author. We've seen how **words change meaning** over time in a living language, as all are. Villain is an example of this phenomenon where a word's connotation changes completely. We need to help the children realize, when they read literature from the past, that the words used may not mean the same thing they mean today. We should give the children experience of reading something written 100 years ago or something by Shakespeare. In many cases, in order to understand, we need to know something about the environment that forms the context of the writing - the society, author and so on.

In the play "A Mid-Summer's Night's Dream", telling us about the fairy queen, it says this: "The cowslips tall, her pensioners be." Do we know what cowslips are? They are a flower. We have to know how big they grow too! They grow about 9 inches, coming out in about April to bloom; this needs to be known for the first three words to have any meaning for us. Then it says, "... her pensioners be." This makes us think of people who no longer work - living on a pension. This is not the meaning for Shakespeare. He was referring to the gentlemen pensioners of Queen Elizabeth the First. The pensioners formed her body-guard and they were anything but old and retired. They were chosen on their looks, stature and their physiques - though she was married! So, we can see that looking at the environment and society at the time contribute to an author's work.

The study of grammar and words can enhance the children's appreciation of literature and can put them in touch with writers of other times and places. So grammar has to be related to their developing historical sense. This is why Montessori said literature has to be related to grammar.

(Style will be discussed at a later date)

The third aspect follows in the lecture: History of English Literature.

January 25, 2005

History of English Literature

As stated earlier, Dr. Montessori said there were three main aspects to keep in mind when dealing with literature. First, the child will discover that grammar plays a role in the mechanics of written expression; they are intrinsically linked. Second, the child will come to appreciate that style of writing is an important factor in how a work is received and understood.

The **third aspect is the child needs an historical background for his reading**. He needs to have some idea of what the society was like in which the author was living. That means we need to help the children develop an idea about the buildings, clothing, food and so on. If we don't have that historical backdrop, they will interpret according to today's values.

We should try to get some good copies of the early books. For example, find a reproduction of at least part of the Book of Kells. Through our reading to the children, as well as through their own reading, they should develop a sense of history which can be helped through the reading of diaries, letters and historical fiction. For the **upper elementary children, the historical study of literature should also be connected to the evolution and development of our language**.

Literature is one of the expressions of the human spirit. **What needs to come before the history of literature is the history of the people whose literature it belongs to**. The children have to study the basic facts of the life of society first. In this study, the question of books should come up. **The question of books is on the rts**. If the children don't bring up the study about books, we need to bring it up.

We have nothing definitive of the songs or stories of the Britons who were found in Southern England when Julius Caesar arrive in 55 BC. So we cannot begin our study of the history of English literature with anything from the ancient Britons that spoke a Celtic language.

English literature is often thought of as beginning with Chaucer. But this means discounting about 6 centuries of literature before he was even born. Chaucer lived from 1340 AD to 1400 AD. If we were to read a page of Chaucer today, most of us

could probably figure out what it means. But few of us would be able to read anything earlier. If we did, it would seem to be written in a foreign language. This is why so few people know anything about English literature before Chaucer's time. Lately, there has been efforts to provide good translations of earlier work. Another reason for the difficulty in studying the earlier English literature is that it was **recorded in manuscript form** and very few of them survive.

Before the Norman conquest of England in 1066 AD, the Angles, Saxons and Jutes invaded the country from their Germanic homes on the continent of Europe. They brought Jutish - a form of Danish which was used in South-Eastern England, Saxon - a form of German used on Southern England, Friesian - a form of Dutch first seen in language family work - used in the midlands, middle part of the country, and Anglian - used on Northern England and Southern Scotland. This is where we have the study of literature intertwining with the study of history. This is the kind of study appropriate for the upper elementary children - who can study the development of a group of people into a nation.

We could not go into these details about Anglo-Saxons without a study of English history since they have to be fit into a place on the timeline in order to well comprehend the literature. So one would have to initiate a study of the history of England, **building up presentations using History Question charts.** It is the sort of timeline teachers and children construct together. We want the children to know about their clothes, transportation and food, for example.

The study of **etymology can also be woven in** here because, as we look up the roots of our words, we find them coming from Anglo-Saxon origins. Words with that origin came into our language from that time in history - so this is what we want the children to realize. Have the sounds of the letters always been the same? Just to give one example, the letter *a*, today, can make 8 different sounds. During the time of Anglo-Saxons it made 2 different sounds.

Another difference between modern English and the language at that time is that **Old English had no silent letters.** Every letter used made a sound. So we can find words that look the same as today but they were pronounced very differently.

If we study the Anglo-Saxons and their lives, we can find some interesting facts. Because they invaded England, for a long time,

they were depicted as warrior-like, rough and uncultured. But recent discoveries have been made that indicate a relatively high-level of culture. There is very little written evidence left for us to know exactly what their lives were like. So it is necessary to piece together evidence from artifacts.

The Anglo Saxon poem Beowulf is in manuscript form in the British museum. But there is only that single manuscript. The story is actually not English but Scandinavian brought to English by the Angles and made into a poem in England around 700 AD. The manuscript was not written down until about 1000 AD. So for 300 years that poem was passed along orally.

The story is about a monster called Grendel who is overcome by a warrior named Beowulf. The poem gives a picture of society at the court of the king of the Danes. The story itself belongs to the Pagan life of the Germanic tribes. But it wasn't written down until after England had converted to Christianity. Old English verse was certainly in existence at the time – but this story was passed down orally. There are no original manuscripts of it remaining. Songs and sagas existed in the same way.

What we know of Anglo-Saxon poetry is in four groups of manuscripts. One of those groups was collected by Sir Robert Colton. It is this collection that is now in the British Museum. The manuscript of Beowulf was part of his collection. It is recorded as being part of his collection in 1706. So there is no record of where it was from the time it was written down around 1000 AD until 1706 AD. Twenty-six years later, in 1732, it was almost destroyed in a fire and if you go to the British Museum, one can see the charred edges from that fire today.

Beowulf is about 3000 lines long and is the first poem in English so it needs to come into the study of English literature. There are translations available and it should be present in the classroom.

The Hymn of Caedmon is possibly the oldest surviving piece of English poetry composed on English soil. It is all that we have left from the English poet Caedmon. It's quoted by St. Bede, who's greatest work is "The Ecclesiastical History of the English Race." This is prose written in Latin, not Old English. Caedmon was a cow-herder employed at the Abby of Whitney. St. Bede says he became a poet after being visited by an angel who encouraged him to sing. The story goes that he had crept away from the other cow-herders because he did not feel able to join in with their singing and composing of poetry. And this is when he was visited by the angel – the result is the Hymn

of Caedmon. St. Bede lived between 673 AD and 735 AD. He spent almost his entire life in the monastery of Jarrow, making a great study of religion. He had a reputation all over Europe at the time.

The first great prose book – not poem – written in English, is the Anglo-Saxon Chronicles. This is a national history of England inspired by King Alfred, who lived from 849 AD to 899 AD. The Anglo-Saxon Chronicles continues until 1154; it is a systematic revision of earlier records from monasteries and abbeys. It is the first continuous history of a Western nation written in its own language. This book gives the story of England developing around the two big events before the Norman conquest – the Anglo-Saxon invasion and the conversion of the country to Christianity. One finds in this book the story of the resistance to the invasion and the effects of it on the country – as well as religious writings that were used for educational purposes.

In the beginning of recorded English literature, there is little we would consider light reading. We want to help the children understand that when there were few people who could write, there was no time and there were no materials to waste. So anything that was considered unimportant was not written down. It existed but was not recorded. Religious manuscripts were there to be used constantly – as teaching material.

Aelfric was a pupil of the monastery school at Winchester. He wrote in order to make Christian documents available in English instead of their 'original' Latin. He also wrote of grammar, hoping to expand a knowledge of English in England itself. Any literature for recreational purposes was left to memory. We certainly want to help the children develop an appreciation for the minstrels of the time and how they helped develop a literary culture; these people are owed a debt of gratitude – the story-tellers of the past. Written literature developed from these oral recitations. This is why literature has to be kept as part of education. It mirrors human life. We spend time on Anglo-Saxons since not many people know about them. But whatever literature the child is studying, that literature needs to be put into the context of that country's history.

Chaucer (1340-1400) wrote for a small audience. He wrote for the members of court and for the professional and merchant class. He is best remembered for “The Canterbury Tales”, which is actually an unfinished collection of tales told by pilgrims on their way to Canterbury. At the time he wrote this, the English language was still divided – though the language of the East Midlands was gradually becoming the standard dialect. This is where London is and was at the

time – so that population brought its influence to bear. In the Western region, at the same time as Chaucer, a man named William Langland wrote “The Vision of Piers the Ploughman.”

In a series of scenes, the poet shows almost every side of 14th century life. Much of the working population was decimated by the plague in 1360 AD. As a result, there was a big change in social life. Up until that time, working people lived under the feudal system. But with the black death, the feudal system began to die out since the working people were the hardest hit and most effected by the plague; so the first class struggle came about which stimulated a new sentiment in poetry. This is what one will find reflected in “The Vision of Piers the Ploughman.” It became a symbol for worker's independence. Later, as a result of this piece of writing, labor conditions changed. So this is how we need to make literature understandable for the children. As we follow the history of a nation, literature should be one of the aspects we include once it had been developed.

Another aspect the children will encounter through these studies are **the forms of that early literature and the order in which they developed**. At the beginning, there was **prose and narrative poetry**. This continued **through the Norman rule** of England. The next form to appear was **lyric poetry, and then finally, the novel**.

January 26, 2005

American Literature

Children in the United States have their own history and therefore their own literature. As they are presented with American history, and as they begin to realize the building up of our nation and its society, they should come in contact with at least some of the many changes that has occurred in American Society.

The influx of people from other countries of the world has made its mark on our society and the life lived by people in this country. As people have come from other countries and cultures, they've brought aspects of their culture with them. They've brought their literature with them and these have become part of the wealth that is available to those in the United States.

In the study of American writers and their work, it is important that the children know the backgrounds of these writers. They may have written in this country but were they born here? Maybe yes, maybe no. So help the children look at the life of a particular writer so they understand what influences have effected that person.

Recorded American history began as almost an extension of English history. Then, as people flocked into this country, society in the United States became colored by these influences, becoming more diverse and culturally rich. Each new group of people reflected some aspects of their native culture, here. So the study of American literature has to accommodate this history and influence. The study of American writers needs to be a study of where the authors came from and how their backgrounds influenced their work. Then we need to look at their current environment to see how it also influenced them. Did they write poetry - what kind? Did they write short stories or a novel. If a novel, what kind of novel was it. Did they write non-fiction? How was all this conditioned by their background.

The presentation of American Literature follows the same path of historical development, as with other material in the classroom. First, there is an introduction which comes through our reading to the children plus what they choose to read on their own. This can often include exploring what else a particular author has written. The writer needs to be put into his or her own social context for the children - placed it historical context. What was written first? How did her writing develop of change over time? So as we present

American history to the child, he should come into contact with American writers and some of their important work. When we speak of an American history timeline, influential writers is one topic that might appear there. If we are successful in generating interest in the child, he may want to build up a timeline of American literature or literature generally.

January 26, 2005

Children's Literature

When we think of children's books and their place in literature, we are faced with the fact that children as children, are something realized and understood only quite recently in historical development. To quote John Rowe Townsend, "Before there could be children's books, there had to be children, children, that is, who were accepted as beings with their own particular needs and interests - not merely as miniature men and women." Children have been around since the beginning of the human species but the approach taken with them was to train them for adult life. So the first books for children were there for that training purpose. They were not there to appeal to interest or the fancy of the children.

Books were being made by hand and therefore they were quite scarce as we go back in history. The age of manuscript has therefore left us nothing that would be considered a book or story for children. Children had access to the stories that were around them, to the common property of legends and romance, to things like King Arthur and Aesop's Fables, and to the folk tales that were passed down by word of mouth. Minstrels of history were gathered around as they performed and children were certainly part of those groups. But the stories were not meant for children. Any material specifically for children was to help with their imitation of adults.

By 1497, Caxton, the first English printer, had published some of both kinds of literature - for adults and for children's training to be like adults. Until the end of the 17th century, books for children were nearly all school books or books of manners and morals. The 17th century writer, John Bunyan wrote "The Pilgrim's Progress" in 1678. This book was not written intentionally for children but it came to be regarded as a children's book. In 1686, Bunyan wrote a book, "For boys and girls" which today reads as a stern exhortation on morality. It is hardly what one thinks of as pleasure reading.

By the early 18th century, children began to be thought of in a different way. "Robinson Crusoe", published in 1719 and "Gulliver's Travels" (1726) became children's literature - - though they were written for adults.

William of Orange and Queen Mary came to the English throne in 1688 establishing the parliamentary form of government in England. This was important since this system of government

provided the money, time and education needed to make it possible for more people to read. The publishing of books became more widespread and children's books became more available. Older children may want to study this period of time to see how it influenced the development of literature and sped up developments taking place.

In 1744, John Newbery published his first book for children, "The Little Pretty Pocket Book." It was a book of pictures, rhymes and games. The following year, a children's bookshop opened in St. Paul's courtyard. Newbery followed his first book with at least thirty others over the next few years.

Another interesting historical aspect to look into is – who exactly authored certain books? Sometimes there are books we're told were written by a certain person but historical question about it. There is a question as to whether Newbery actually wrote all of the work attributed to him. "Goodie Two Shoes" is one of them, written by Oliver Goldsmith but thought to be perhaps penned by Newbery. There is an annual award given today – the John Newbery medal – that is given by the American Library Association, for the most distinguished children's book of the year. It is easy to find lists of these Newbery winners. This is one source of books that are considered to be good literature for children. But it still means one needs to check each book before reading it to the class; make sure there are no surprises in content and appropriateness for the class.

The children might want to look into how successful these award-winning books have been. How often have they been checked out of the library or what publishing heat are they in – first publishing, second and so on. Are they really the books most popular with children?

By the end of the 18th and beginning of the 19th centuries, the writing of children's books in England was being taken over by gentlewomen – as they were referred to. Maria Edgeworth was one of the best remembered of this time. She wrote "Simple Susan" and "Waste Not Want Not." As one might guess, these books were still moralizing and didactic – meant to teach. Imagination and anything related to fairy tales were still thought of as unnecessary for children's reading.

In 1839, Catherine Sinclair wrote a book called "Holiday House." She wanted to write about "that species of noisy, frolicsome, mischievous children, which is now almost extinct. Holiday House is a story told to the children by an uncle that is a non-sensical story about giants and fairies. Fantasy had finally been accepted in England. After the translation of "Grim" which took place from 1823 to 1826 and of

"Hans Christian Andersen" in 1846, John Ruskin wrote "King of the Golden River" in 1841. And with the reign of Queen Victoria, we begin to approach the modern age of children's literature. Certainly didactic stories continued to be written but now new kinds of work were also appearing. Literature for children's enjoyment arose. Finally, there were adventure stories being written for children. Captain Marriot wrote "Mr. Midshipmen Easy" and "Children of the Forest". RM Valentine wrote "The Young Fur Traders" and "The Coral Island." Robert Louis Stephenson (1850-1894) wrote "Treasure Island" and "Kidnapped." Henty wrote historical adventure novels such as "Beric the Brave"; this book is interesting because one chapter gives history and the next chapter gives the story, followed by another chapter of history again, followed by story - alternating back and forth.

In the 1850s, we have what are referred to as the "boys school stories". Book like "Tom Brown" and "Eric", by FW Farrar. In the 1860s, Louisa May Alcott wrote "Little Women." This book was written especially for girls - so finally there is literature especially for girls. In the 1870s, Mark Twain's "Tom Sawyer" and Anna Sewell's "Black Beauty" were published. History and adventure were being mixed together in books now - historical adventure stories - in books written for children. This began around 1840 and was especially prevalent up until 1915. These were books written to be of interest and enjoyed by children; no longer were children's books for moralizing. One adventure book was "King Solomon's Mind" by R. Haggard

At the end of the 19th century, writers like A. Conan Doyle, John Buchan and H. G. Wells, were writing books for adults that were also being enjoyed by children. Alongside the books for boys - telling of action and adventure - were what was considered girl's literature. "The Secret Garden" and "Little Lord Fauntleroy" written by Francis Hodgson Burnett were two of these types of books.

The Alice books by Lewis Carroll and Kingley's "Water Babies" began the age of fantasy in children's literature. George MacDonald wrote "The Princess and the Goblin." E. Nesbit wrote "The Story of the Treasure Seekers" and "The Railway Children." J.M. Barrie wrote "Peter and Wendy." Rudyard Kipling wrote "Puck of Pook's Hill." So the age of fantasy had arrived with this literature.

Thomas Hughes wrote "Tom Brown's Schooldays" and F.W. Farrar wrote "Eric" and "Little By Little." Both of these books were published in the mid-1800s and they began that period referred to as "school stories" for children.

Animal stories began to appear as well. There were two kinds of animal stories that were written early on. One was about humanized animals and the other was about animals as such. This is when we find Beatrix Potter and her animal stories for children. Rudyard Kipling wrote "The Jungle Book" and "The Just So Stories." Kenneth Grahame wrote "The Wind in the Willows." Then we have Walter De la Mare who wrote "Collected Stories for Children." Eleanor Farjean wrote "Martin Pippin in the Apple Orchard." A. A. Milne wrote "Winnie the Pooh." John Mansfield wrote "The Midnight Folk." Then we have fantasy of JRR Tolkien, "The Hobbit" and "The Lord of the Rings."

Arthur Ransome (1884-1967), in the Lake District of England, began a new kind of story. He wrote about the real lives of boys and girls. In a 12-volume set of adventure stories called the "Swallows and Amazons." These books were republished briefly around 1990.

January 26, 2005

Children's Literature in The United States

If we look at literature in the United States, we see that books in the early days of the first colonies here came from England. John Foxe's "Book of Martyrs", first published in 1563, was read to children in England and in New England. One of the leading Puritan writers in England was James Janeway, who published in 1571 "A Token for Children, being an Exact Account of the Conversion, Holy and Exemplary Lives, and Joyful Deaths, of Several Young Children." In 1900, this book was reprinted in Boston with the addition by Cotton Mather of "A Token for Children of New England."

The most important book for children in Colonial America was "The New England Primer", which was for the most part a combination of an ABC book and a Catechism book. It included a set of alphabetical rhymes accompanied by wood cuts for illustrations. These sorts of writings were influenced by the Puritans.

These books were followed by a softer sort of book called "Divine Songs" written by Watts. This book included a fairly well-known cradle song "Hush My Dear, Lie Still and Slumber." Divine Songs became popular in both New England and in England. One interesting historical note here is that the Puritans were influential for a longer time in the colonies than they were in England. So that in the early 18th century, the approved books in America were the Bible, The New England Primer, Bunyan's Pilgrim's Progress, Watt's Hymns and Divine Songs, and Janeway's Token for Children with the American additions. Still pretty grim reading. A somewhat lighter side to literature began to creep in as Robinson Crusoe and Gulliver's Travels were brought to the United States.

A printer named Isaiah Thomas, in Worcester Massachusetts, introduced the John Newbery books to the United States. For most of the 18th century there was practically no American writing being done for children. Printers were taking books from England, making modifications to Americanize them and then publishing them here. The first American to write specifically for children was Samuel Goodrich who lived from 1793 to 1860. He is better known as Peter Parley. In 1827, he began a long series of books, "Tales of Peter Parley about America." He felt children naturally loved the truth and that they didn't need to be given fiction, so he had this idea of writing tales about travel. He wrote books about

nature, history and art. His tales about America was so successful that it was followed by "Tales about Europe." During the next thirty years, he wrote about 120 books for children.

In the early 19th century, Jacob Abbott came on the scene as a writer for children. Included in the approximately 180 books he wrote for children, is a series called the Rollo books. "Rollo Learning to Talk", "Rollo Learning to Read", "Rollo In London" and "Rollo in Holland" were some examples. There was also a collection he wrote of Lucy books and Jonas books - all series around a character. Most of his writing was instructive as well as being entertaining. What is considered to be his main contribution to American Children's literature are the Franconian stories - fiction about the lives of children in a New England village.

In 1819, Washington Irving retold the "Tales of Rip Van Winkle" and "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow." Children in America were finally able to enjoy fairy tales and imaginative stories. Sir Walter Scott helped to set the state for the 19th century adventure story with his books "Rob Roy" and "Ivanhoe", which were written in England; he was an English author. He helped set the stage of James Fenimore Cooper, who is referred to as the American James Walter Scott, when he wrote "The Last of the Mohicans" and "The Path Finder."

L. Frank Baum, who lived from 1858 to 1919, wrote "The Wizard of Oz" and invented a fairy land here in America with his tales. Mark Twain was writing during this same time period so children here enjoyed his books as well. In America, we also had our version of the school stories that had come from England. In 1870, Thomas Bailey Aldrich wrote "The Story of a Bad Boy" - a book considered auto-biographical - and closely resembles Tom Brown's "School Days" in spirit. Carl Sandburg's "Rootabaga Stories", published in 1922, are considered modern American fantasy or fairy tales.

Between the first and second world wars, historical and period stories formed the main fiction in America for children. Some of the best known were the Little House series, written by Laura Ingalls Wilder. Currently, there are so many books available for children that it is hard to know which are the best and which will become classics over time. We want to use resources to help choose the best books. Children's librarians and children's bookstores can be helpful. Colleagues, sharing with each other, is another great way to find the best books. Read the book first before planning to use it in class. Sometimes, even an award-winning book, may be better suited

for some than for other classes.

To sum up, what can we do with literature besides read it to the children and encourage them to read it for themselves? As timelines are being developed about a country or group of people, make sure to include stories about writers and books that were part of that culture. Literature should be one aspect that is looked into and included on timelines we make. We make a literature-theme timeline for our country or any other – even without regard to national origin. If we get the children interested, they may want to do a timeline for a specific author – on his or her life.

The children might want to write a biography about a favorite author, compiling it into a book or scroll perhaps – to be shared with other interested. Going out should also include the homes of authors that might be in the area. Interviewing current writers to find out about their lives and their work is another source of education. How much do they write in a day? How many times do they rewrite their work? Sometimes children think published writers merely sit down and write a book from front to back. The process they use is fascinating to those learning to write and hoping to relate their experiences to professionals. Poetry should be read to the children and they should be encouraged to write and even memorize favorite poems – to create an anthology of poetry. The lives of poets can be investigate and the different forms poets may use. Maybe the children will want to take an independent approach as some of poets have done.

January 28, 2005

Style

We want to help the children to be able to express themselves, not merely in ways that are correct, but also **in ways that make sense and are aesthetically pleasing**. The children should be able to write so that their writing has music to it – not just words on paper. We want them to be able to change their **style of writing to fit the topic**.

This lecture, like so much of the work in language, builds upon the ideas we have already considered – and then adds a new facet – the concept of style. **Style refers to the choices a writer makes about language** and in the case of fiction – the ways the various elements of fiction are used. Style has to do with whether or not a writer uses **symbolism or allegory or is very literal** in relating a story. It is reflected in a **writer's word choice, sentence length and structure**. The choice of **standard English, dialect or slang** is also a part of style.

When Abraham Lincoln, in the Gettysburg address, used the phrase 'four score and seven years ago', rather than 87 years ago, he was using a particular style in order to catch everyone's attention. It is both the content and style of this address that makes it memorable. So we can think about style and its importance in writing both fiction and non-fiction.

We have already spoken of the fact that **one should read good literature to the children**. One way we help **them understand and appreciate style is through reading both prose and poetry**. When we read, we should be sure to choose selections with different styles of writing. From time to time, read a passage from one author and then read a passage from a different author on the same subject – such as the description of a landscape. Ask the children to listen for similarities and differences as you read. Hopefully the child is also reading to himself. If we have carefully chosen the books he is exposed to a wide variety of authors in the classroom. This allows the child to find different writers that appeal to him. His own tastes are formed because he has been allowed to browse and select on his own. One might challenge children in the 9-12 class to see if they can write something in the style of one of their favorite authors. One might also challenge them to write on the same topic in different styles. For example, write a paragraph about going to the store, first time writing literally and the second time using similes and allegory.

Grammatical, Clear and Appropriate

We want the children to appreciate the literary form which is the style of any given written work. We want them to be able to develop their own style but also to appreciate the style of others. There is general agreement that **good literature can be judged on three marks:**

- 1. It should be grammatically sound**
- 2. It should be clearly expressed**
- 3. It should be appropriate to the subject.**

From the very beginning in the Children's House, we've encouraged the children to express their own thoughts. In the elementary class, using cosmic education **we expose the child to the whole universe**. We open the doors of the creation of the earth and its furnishings. We introduce the creatures upon the earth and we give stories about the life of human beings from the time they first arrived, to the present. All of these are **possible topics for the content of the children's writing**. We do not dictate what they should write but do give them ideas and guides, then leave them free to choose their own topics.

We give the children many tools for writing. In the area of **grammar and syntax we help the children increase their vocabulary, understand the function of words and structure of sentences**. We present along with the syntax work, the concepts of simple, complex and compound sentences. We give them an understanding of punctuation rules and rules for forming paragraphs. So, hopefully, we give them the tools for writing in a grammatically correct manner.

Clarity of thought rests on the ability to think in a logical manner. We have been providing the children, through our lessons, many opportunities for reasoning. We help them to write in a clear manner through defining terms and comparing them to definitions in the nomenclature, or writing up results of experiments and comparing their work with the text on the control cards. We also help them learn how to edit their work for increased clarity. We ask, **"Do you think what you've written is clear?"** Encourage the children to have friends read any experiments or word

problems and riddles that they write and see if their friend understands what was written.

Help the children to write simply, without complex sentences that lose their focus. Help them break up and punctuate sentences that are too long. Help them to combine sentences that can be combined gracefully.

From a book entitled “**The Elements of Style**” by **William Strunk Jr. and E.B. White**, under “**Contemplation on Style**”, we read “**Vigorous writing is concise**. A sentence should contain no unnecessary words, a paragraph, no unnecessary sentences, for the same reason a drawing should have no unnecessary lines and a machine no unnecessary parts. This requires not that a writer makes all his sentences short, or that he avoid all detail and treat his subjects only in outline, but that every word tells.” (Introduction page xvi).

When we presented written language, we spoke of helping the child to understand that different subjects require different styles. The children can readily understand that writing up an experiment uses one style; there are technical words to use. The writing should be in the third person. But when we write a friendly letter to a friend, we write in the first person. And we might use colloquialisms or slang. We might include elliptical sentences in a letter to a friend but never in a letter to inquire for information. Help the child to notice the various styles used while they read various things and then to **reflect upon the appropriate style for whatever they choose to write**. We need to ensure that the **child develops his own style of writing**. We give help but should not expect a copy of our style or anyone else's. It is the child himself and his thoughts that alone are to be expressed in writing.

Again, from the Elements of Style, we read, “.... we **approach style in its broader meaning: style in the sense of what is distinguished and distinguishing**. Here we leave solid ground. Who can say what ignites a certain combination of words, causing them to explode in the mind? Who knows why certain notes in music are capable of stirring the listener deeply, though the same notes slightly rearranged are impotent. These are high mysteries and this chapter is a mystery story, thinly disguised. There is no satisfactory of explanation of style, **no infallible guide to good writing, no assurance that a person who thinks clearly will be able to write clearly**, no key that unlocks the door, no inflexible rules by which the young writer may shape his course. He will **often find himself steering by stars that are disturbingly in motion ...**

every writer, by the way he uses the language, reveals something of his spirit, his habits, his capacities, his bias.” (pp. 66-67)

It is through the skills that the child has developed and an appreciation of different styles of various authors, that the child can come to develop his own style of writing. Then we have a few exercises that are specific to the examination of style that the children can be shown. We can **use the grammar symbols to further the exploration of style. This begins when the children are doing the work with logical analysis.** From time to time, but not each time, have the children symbolize a sentence before they do the analysis. This brings out a visual pattern for the younger children to see. They can do this right on the paper. Then, when the children are doing their own writing, again, from time to time, suggest they leave a few blank lines between each line of their writing. The children can then **draw their grammar symbols over each word or they may paste paper symbols over each word. Discuss with the children what we saw - what was the pattern of the symbols? Was it heavy with nouns - lots of black triangles?** Is it active with verbs - lots of red balls? If it is a description, do we see lots of adverbs and adjectives?

Do the same thing with passages from various authors. To begin, take a paragraph from a favorite author, symbolize it and find patterns in it. Later, the children can consider two authors writing on roughly the same subject and to the same audience - symbolize each and compare the symbols. How do they differ and how are they similar. Does one use more adjectives than the other? We make it visible with the symbols.

The children can also take a few passages from three or four different books by the same author and to the same comparison. Does the same author always have a similar pattern? Do we see pattern in the symbols usage over a timeline of the author's books?

In the **Children's House, we spoke of helping the child with 'total reading.'** We did not mean simply that the child could read every word but that they could arrive at an understanding at the heart and sentiments of what they read. Total reading means that the child **begins to arrive at the center of the authors expression.** With the study of style, including work that symbolizes text, we want to help the child get at the very heart of literature. Then, the sentiment, spirit and life of what is being expressed can be grasped.

This work is not complete at the end of the second plane of

development. We have given the child some tools and methods for looking at style. But remember, we are sowing the seeds that may be taken up in the third plane of development. It is during the third plane that the young adult may delve further into the style of a single author or a particular group of writers with similar styles.

February 4, 2005

Appendix

Remedial Language

Notes compliments of Carson Wright

Material

Maybe sandpaper letters, a piece of material called the green board, small colored moveable alphabets, large script moveable alphabet (for reading), phonogram cards, phonogram booklets, phonogram cards and puzzle words.

Introduction

The word **remedial means to supply a remedy**, of how we fill in the gaps that some children might have. Don't ever refer to the lessons as remedial math or language to the children. Elementary children have an immediate need to read and write; this entails knowing the shapes of the letters and how to write the letters, the sounds of the letters and how to combine those sounds. We need to remember that **the child has lost the sensitive period for learning language**, it is over. Their **interest in tactile exercises is over**. Their interest in letters for their own sake is over. The sand paper letters and the moveable alphabet, used as they are used in primary will not be of much help to the children of this age. Additionally, **the child himself is often frustrated** when they see other children read and write, they feel bad because they know they should be able too. They are **often frustrated and act out**. It is important to elicit the cooperation of the child. If they are resentful and resisting, progress will be slow. If you can get their cooperation things will be easier.

As quickly as you can give them a sense of success, do so. If the sensitive periods are recalled, **writing comes before reading, because in writing the child is in touch with something known**. It's his own language, his ideas which are in his mind and it helps to make these words visible to him.

Writing involves the analysis of a word that they can hear; those sounds are put together with a symbol. The sounds are then put together with the moveable alphabet or actual writing on paper.

Reading involves understanding someone else's language, you have to take it, analyze it and break it into component sounds - after recognition of the symbols for those sounds has completed. Then you have to make a synthesis of those sounds.

Reading is a more complex process, now in the elementary that sequence is over, we need to work on both reading and writing at the

same time. Taking them on parallel to each other, but concentrating on the child's ability to read. If she can read, she can do so much more to affect her own education throughout life.

Reading

Material

Large moveable alphabet.

Prologue

Start out by seeing if a child knows any letters or sounds. If a child does not know any, pick three, one being a vowel.

Do a three period lesson. Pick letters that are similar but are often used together (ex: b, a, d, t, g, n). = bag, tag, nag or gab, nab, tab. Include word families (e.g., 'at' for cat, hat, fat, that - or - 'ake' for make, take, cake, fake, etc.)

Once they know 6 letters they can form many words; our approach is sound by sound. We will blend two sounds together.

Begin

Place down the b & a letters These two letters together (blending) make the sound ba (sound it out) and the consonants one adds - sounding out the new word; emphasize the sound combination ex: bat, bag, etc.

(keep the words out and bring more (ba) down from the letter box)

Do this whenever you get a chance each day and then write them down in *your very own word book*

Epilogue

Encourage the child to take out the book and read their words whenever they want to, be enthusiastic in response. The next time you get out these materials add another sound and try an add more words to their booklets.

As they get better add more blends together (sa) state the sound and the blend (nd) *when we put them together they have this sound*. Put them together and see how many blended words we can put together, write the words down in the child's book.

They can also decorate the pages, which gets them involved in making these books. Continue this way until they are comfortable making words like this and fusing the sounds together.

These are lessons in the classroom which **should occur frequently in the day, but are short about 10 minutes. Stop while the child is successful**; do not go until they do not succeed.

Phonograms

1. We will use two of the small moveable alphabets, very much like you used in primary, choose the phonogram and put it together with a blend.
2. Suppose we choose the phonogram (sh) form out of one color say the sound several times. Then say (ip) say the sound several times and then form with letters. (Push)
3. Repeat for other phonograms, making sure to use the phonogram in the beginning and end of a word.
4. Add to their wordbook.
5. Explain what a phonogram is, when you put these letters together they make a particular sound. Children often catch on to them pretty easily.
6. We need to teach a certain number of phonograms to each child, as soon as they have a certain facility for reading these words also introduce puzzle words. (words you can't sound out)
7. In the elementary we should have all three of them working together in parallel.
8. Try to choose words they will see in the first grammar boxes. (the, because, mother, father)
9. Taught by sight in a three period lesson, try and get through this work in the first six weeks of school. Give these lessons often in order to see progress.
10. Sometimes a child will get stuck on the sounds of the letters and sounding out the words, and has trouble putting the sounds together, dad, just read the word together and read it as dad.
11. See if they know any sight words with out sounding it out.
12. If a child will benefit from using the sand paper letters, use them in a method that is tactful, it is probably best to use the moveable alphabet to teach the sounds.

Writing

The explosion into writing, which Maria Montessori describes for the first plane is not going to happen, so we need to offer the help which we may have, in the class, to aid the child with his fine motor-control. One important part of this effort is to strongly encourage the child to hold his pencil using a tripod grip; rubber or foam "pencil grips" available in stores seem to help some children improve their natural writing grip.

Introduce design work with metal insets, hand work after fractions, making scrolls, charts and booklets. Present these early, because the follow-up work also helps us with their writing and fine motor skills. One only needs the ability to hold a pencil.

In order for them to learn to write the letters, we can use the green board sand paper letters, there are five boards and the letters are grouped according to how they are formed. They are useful, but we the teacher have to work with the children in forming them. We need to sit with a group of children and practice with them in forming the letters. When we are doing

this, we need to write neatly and clearly; be a good model.

Watch as they are forming the letters, aid them, and stop any potential bad habits. Remember that when they are doing practice writing, they can also decorate the paper. Not only do we need to help them form single letters, but also help them joining letters. **Make sure they can connect the letters.**

Move on to writing words next, their name. Remember all of the early work we have done that involves single words and that follow up work that can be included. Writing the singular and plural, masculine and feminine nouns, colors - any words that they will see in their environment often.

They need to learn how to do **capital and lower case** letters. Showing them how to form any that are different. Guide them. When we have children who need this sort of writing practice we need to guide the children in **small groups to practice their writing together.**

We need to work with **reading and writing in parallel** to one another, giving a larger emphasis on reading. Do not give the child a book and have them read through it. Preview the book with the child and help them with any unfamiliar words. Society wants the children to read but it is a natural development which will occur; it varies, so do not apply too much pressure.

Give them the keys, present to them word studies, and grammar boxes, the work will go a little slower, that's OK, remember to do nomenclature work with the children – matching words to pictures. Make sure the child has developed the facility in word reading before you ask them to read the book.

Write books for them, or have them write books, draw pictures or paste pictures down in a booklet. Have the child dictate to you what is happening in the book.

Because these are the child's own words they will have an easier time reading them. They can make the cover and decorate it. You can also make a group book. Use print, because it is for the children to read.

Be ready for a child who is ready to read their own way to read, the self-learner. Sight readers are like this. There's a certain percentage of children who don't learn through the phonetic approach; usually it would be by sight. Try books on tape. Have the child follow along with the text in the book.

Another approach is echo reading, the child is sitting right next to you read the words out loud and the child repeats them. There are a variety of different ways to learn to read so try a variety of methods to see what works best with a child who is struggling.

When it comes to remedial work and those who need remedial work try what ever works. We are looking for what will help and give them the tools which will aid them. Remember, these are the children who need our help. **These are not the children to turn over to the classroom assistant.** We have gone through the training and have the keys to aid the child with most rapidity.